So Difficult, So Simple (And Still It Feels Like Coming Home)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/21470263.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Lonnie/Scorpia (She-Ra), Kyle/Rogelio (She-Ra)

Characters:
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Back on the romcom train my dudes, Fluff and humor and a touch of angst-oh my!, The aftermath of the reunion, Some drama necessary, Catra and Adora try to reasonable adults while rebuilding their relationship, Everyone else just wants them to kiss already, And they were yearning, OH MY GOD THEY WERE YEARNING, Speculations on Magicat biology and culture because s4 refused to feed me, feat. Glimmer and Lonnie as Chaos Gremlin and Queen of the Barbecue respectively, Here to roast the hell out of their respective best friends for making this complicated, -bangs gong like a midieval herald-, "THERE SHALL BE NO SMOOCHING UNTIL THE PROPER PINING RITUALS ARE COMPLETE", Catra actually goes to therapy, -smacks fic- This baby can fit so much cuddling and PDAs in it, I know what I'm about y'all, "NOT A STANDALONE FIC"

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Part 4 of Rhythm & Blues (C'mon, Darlin', Make Some Noise)

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by MalachiWalker

Summary

After ten long years and one climactic reunion, Catra Leandros and Adora Eternia have reunited and are giving the concept of "us" another shot.

But of course, that's a little easier said than done, as the two struggle to consolidate the old with the new, endure the ruthless dragging of their friends, and try to rebuild their trust in the face of a few long-buried secrets. Because nothing can ever be simple with these two involved.

We Make An Insubstantial Territory (Whenever We Sit Close)

Chapter Notes

> Here you go, my dudes. We're picking up where we left off at the end of "I Thought I Was Just Haunted" to explore the aftermath of the reunion and the frankly intricate rituals these two dumbass gays engage in instead of just asking each other out. XD Hope you're ready for three chapters of humor, drama and fluff. Enjoy!
>
> Quick note for anyone who hasn't read Nocturnes & Preludes: Star is a white furred deaf cat that Scorpia and Catra found in Arizona. When not on the road with the entire band, he rotates between each of their homes every week to avoid the inevitable custody battles for their shared "son."

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The thing about being around Catra in real life again, Adora concluded three days later as she sat at the kitchen table Monday morning heroically trying *not* to have a nervous breakdown, is that once you got past the defensive barriers you found someone entirely too easy to love.

Which turned out to be a big fucking problem for her initial plan of trying to take it slow and catch up on the ten year gap between them. It was just so damn *effortless,* slipping back into their old dynamic.

"So wait a second. Let me see if I get this straight," Glimmer drawled from where she hung halfway over the back of the couch in her pink and purple pajamas looking like a glitter-bombed sloth. "Even after that big damn reunion--which took a lot to orchestrate, by the way--you still haven't woman-ed up and kissed the girl?"

Adora groaned, rolling her shoulders to try to get the tension loose as she drummed her fingers on the table. "Look, it's complicated, all right? We had enough to talk about as is regarding everything that happened without also heading into new territory-"

"Hold the phone!" Bow cut in, muting the tv and whirling around to look at her. "Ok, look: did we misread the situation or something? The way you always gushed about Catra and growing up together and how much you missed her and how damn *hot* she is-"

"Yeah, we kinda always got the impression you two had been girlfriends in a big way," Glimmer picked up the metaphorical baton. "So what's the deal?"

Adora frowned, leaning back in her chair and staring at the ceiling as she grappled with a way to explain that didn't involve a five hour crash course on what life in (F)Right Zone had really been like.

It wasn't that she didn't trust them, but even after years of therapy it was still so hard to think of herself as someone who had a right to talk about the abuse. Not when Catra and the others got it so much harder.

'Adora,' Dr. Hope's voice cut into her thoughts. *'Just because you weren't physically abused doesn't mean your pain is any less valid. It's not some competition; we all have our own ghosts to deal with.'*

She kept reminding herself of that, but by the time the lesson really sunk in it was three years after starting BFS and she didn't know *how* to bring it up by that point. *Man, screw emotional trauma.*

"You okay there?"

"Yeah, just... Trying to find words that'll make sense," She exhaled heavily through her nose, and turned her head a little to meet Bow's gaze. "Basically it was like this: I loved her, and she loved me, and we were both very much on the same page about that. But it wasn't safe for us to be officially together."

"Wait..." Glimmer chewed her lower lip thoughtfully, brows creasing. "Don't tell me Right Zone was one of those weird 'pray away the gay' kinda places?"

Adora couldn't help the sharp laugh she responded with, remembering how absolutely over-the-top Pride Week got among the older kids--even to this day, it was weird remembering that there had even *been* straight kids present in the Fright Zone. Then again... *Hets. Ew.*

"No, for the most part the adults didn't give a crap who was involved with who as long as protection was involved and no one had to worry about STIs or unplanned pregnancies. Though there was still some bullying among the student body itself over interspecies relationships, but Catra had effectively made every racist kid in the place her bitch by the time we were fourteen, so she wasn't taking any crap in that quarter."

And *damn* if that didn't still bring a smile to her face (even as the other two exchanged a "What the-?" glance beside her.) Just remembering how Catra--now physically grown past the point where any of the other kids could try to bully her without the *guarantee* of needing serious stitches after--had begun reacting to every challenge with a "come at me" smirk and total confidence once it finally sunk in that things were different now...

Adora *shivered.*

"Anyway," She coughed, trying to play it off as nothing while she continued. "The problem had more to do with me.

"Not like me being a dumbass or not wanting to or anything like

that!" She hastened to cut in as Glimmer opened her mouth. "It's just..."

Another sigh. "The headmistress, Ms. Weaver... I was her favored student, though that sure as hell wasn't the perk it sounds like. And she *hated* Catra. Like true, bottom-of-the-benighted-pit-where-most-people-have-hearts *hate.* She tried hard enough to keep us apart when we were just friends-" (*But were we ever, really?*) "-so we had no idea what she would do if word got out that we were in love. It wasn't safe."

The pained look on Catra's face when they were fourteen and Adora tried to kiss her for the first time, like she'd just been sucker punched. "We can't."

Adora drew back, her mind whirring broken-record sharp with, Oh God did I fuck this up? Catra's hand fisting her jacket to keep her in place, keep her from running. (And for the first time ever, Adora felt like running from her, felt that visceral need to get as far away as possible and maybe/definitely have a good cry because her heart was cracking under the weight of everything she was feeling in that moment.) Then Catra let out a low whine that derailed Adora's entire thought process.

"I want to," She murmured, tucking her head against the crook of Adora's shoulder. "Fuck, Adora, I want to. But if she finds out..."

They both shivered, and not in a good way. Adora instinctively wrapped an arm around Catra's shoulders, taking extra care to avoid touching the expanse of skin just below her shoulder blades. The area where...

Catra's breath against her neck as she turned her head to look at Adora, so close but so damn far that it made Adora heartsick with longing to close the distance.

"Just hold on," She whispered, bringing up her free hand to cup the back of Catra's neck and keep her as close as she possibly

could. "We won't be in this place forever. She won't be able to control us forever."

It tasted like desperation. It sounded like hope. It was probably both, but either way Adora felt it from the bottom of her heart. And the words that went unspoken, but they both plainly understood...

She had never meant anything more in her life.

"So hang on," Glimmer cut into her thoughts with a little wave, jolting Adora out of the memory. "Again, let me see if I got this straight--or as straight as anything is about this situation: so you two have been pining for even *longer* than the ten year separation?"

Adora nodded.

"And the accident happened right when you were supposed to get out and finally be together?"

Another nod.

"And you were roommates?"

"That whole time?" Bow chipped in.

Adora stared, face completely deadpan, and Glimmer dragged a hand across her face. "Holy shit, Adora, how are you still *alive?*"

"*I don't know*!" She shouted back.

So yeah. The end of their reunion went a little something like this.

"Oh my God. This is so cute I wanna throw up."

A snorting laugh. "Tell me about it. Even after ten years they still look like a big goofy golden retriever bundled up with grumpy cat. I mean, just listen to those *purrs!"*

Glimmer and Lonnie, Adora dimly recognizes as she fights feebly against the sleep and the warmth and the weight on her chest to try to resurface. Beneath her chin, there's the flick of furry ears brushing against her skin as Catra grumbles, obviously in the same predicament.

"Honestly, I'd let them stay like this if we could. Catra tries to play it off like she's fine, but she hasn't had a decent night's sleep in weeks."

"I feel ya. But we've distracted the venue owners long enough," And now there's a hand gently shaking Adora's shoulder. "C'mon, you big dork. We gotta get out of here so they can finish cleaning the place for the next concert."

Adora groans, nuzzling against Catra's mane and hearing an echoing 'mrrp' even as she forces her bleary eyes open to see both Lonnie and Glimmer standing beside the couch, simultaneously managing to look both extremely chill and *insufferably* smug. "How long...?"

"About three hours, give or take. But we gotta let the janitors do their job so they can go home too, so up and at 'em, sleepyheads."

'I would literally give them all my money and your car to stay like this,' Adora thinks, even as she blearily forces herself into a half-sitting position, arms still tight around Catra's shoulders. The woman in question finally seems to accept the way the wind is blowing, if the rather distracting huff against Adora's neck is any indication, and they reluctantly disentangle from each other to sit up on the couch properly (though their sides still touch.)

Catra--head in her hands as she runs her fingertips through her fur the way she always does when she's sleepy and needs to get

up anyway--mumbles, "Thanks for letting us have this time alone."

"No prob, furball," Lonnie states simply, each of them reaching out a hand to help pull their respective band mates to their feet. "Much as you do for the rest of us, it was nice to give back for once."

"Here," Glimmer held out a single Styrofoam cup three-quarters full of black coffee. "It's not too strong, but it'll at least keep you both upright 'til we all get home."

Catra accepts the cup with a grateful nod and slams back half of the drink with a grimace before passing it to Adora. Their fingers brush, the contact sending little jolts of electricity through Adora's veins even as she chokes down the lukewarm drink to drown it out.

They look at each other for the first time since awakening, and Catra's eyes soften, voice small and hopeful. "Call me later?"

"Definitely," Adora replies a little breathlessly, patting herself down to figure out where the hell she stashed her cell. "Need me to give you my number...?"

"Nah," Glimmer cut in. "Your magnanimous band leaders have it covered. I'll text Lonnie your number once we get home."

"And vice versa," Lonnie adds.

Well that settles that. Talk concluded, the four of them exit the room, past a pair of very grateful looking janitors and walk down the long hallway to the door leading out of the stage. As they walk, Adora's hand brushes against Catra's and there's a corresponding touch as Catra's tail sways back and forth, grazing the backs of Adora's legs in a soft caress on each swing.

They exit into the cool night air, Adora shivering and wishing she'd thought to bring a jacket or something. It's gotta be past one in the morning; the parking lot is empty aside from No Plan B's tour

bus pulled up to the curve, and Glimmer's hideous driving purple people eater pulled up behind it. It's spring, so it's not freezing, but it's still chilly this far from sunset. Adora braces herself for the walk to the cars...

Only to feel a sudden jolt of warmth as something wraps around her. Glancing over, she sees Catra sans suit jacket respectfully moving away. Catching Adora's expression, she smiles wryly. "You know I run hot."

'In way more ways than one,' Adora thinks, but at this point it's more an observation than her usual level of thirst; she's just too damn worn out to feel anything other than a vague sense of warmth and affection. "And I suppose the fact that I'll need to return it later had no influence on that decision?"

Catra just winks.

The four meander over to the vehicles, where both members of their crews are clustered in the middle chatting and joking with one another, and Adora's suddenly hit with the profound realization that this could be what she always wanted; both of her lives, the past and the present, finally merging into one. Even if Scorpia and Bow both make drawling "Awwww" sounds when they notice Catra's jacket around her shoulders, and the rest of the group just shares a nudge and a knowing smirk.

Then it's time to go. She looks to Catra, only a few feet away from her and still Adora has to suppress a whimper at how much she wants to close the distance. Her only consolation is that Catra seems to be in the same boat, judging by the subtle way her ears dip and her tail has wrapped itself around her leg.

Adora doesn't want them to be apart.

Lonnie, however, seems to mistake her *apocalyptic* levels of yearning for simple worry, because she slings an arm around Catra's shoulders and gives Adora a long wink and an ear-to-ear grin. "Don't worry, Adorkable. We're all just going back to me and

Scorpia's place for the traditional post-tour living room camp out. Catra'll be just fine in our hands, and we'll make sure she calls you tomorrow."

Glancing over at the other members of No Plan B, she's met with knowing smirks, and Scorpia mouths something that looks distinctly like, "We got your girl." Adora's not even sure how she manages to convey a thumbs up with her claws, but somehow she does.

Oh fuck it.

Brushing Lonnie aside, Adora grabs Catra in a crushing hug, trying to convey everything caught in her throat in a single action. It only takes a split second for Catra to reciprocate, her maimed hand wrapping around the point where Adora's back meets her waist while her right hand finds Adora's left shoulder blade, pulling them both in so that their heads rest against the crook of each other's necks.

"This is *not* a goodbye," Catra says, pitched low so only Adora can hear, because she knows Adora *needs* to hear it right now. "This is a 'to be continued.' Got it?"

Adora nods, unable to say much of anything at the moment. They stay like that for what could be a minute or could be an eternity, until there's an awkward throat clearing beside them. Even then, it's difficult to break apart any way but slowly.

"Talk to you soon." Catra whispers, eyes locked on hers, and it's a promise.

Adora barely remembers the drive home after that, sitting in the back seat of the car while Bow tunes the station to smooth, inoffensive jazz instrumentals just to fill the silence, watching the street lights pass by and pulling Catra's jacket tighter around her shoulders. Thankfully, Glimmer and Bow both seem to understand that she's way too wiped out to engage much past that point, because once they get home and back into their apartment, they

each just give her a quick hug and a soft "Good night" before returning to their own rooms.

Adora changes quickly into an oversized t-shirt and a pair of sports shorts before crawling under the covers, exhausted with her mind whirling through how much has happened in just one day: going from moping, to frustration, to exhilaration, to sheer elation, to anger, sorrow, love and Catra Catra *Catra.*

It's a lot to take in, so she curls up and surrenders to the embrace of sleep...

Only to have her eyes fly open when a single thought occurs to her. "OH SHIT, I FORGOT TO ASK IF WE'RE DATING NOW!"

"Ok," Bow said, rubbing the bridge of his nose to try and massage away the beginnings of a little tension headache. "So we've established that you two have simultaneously managed to have the most ridiculous slowburn romance *ever* while also being completely aware of each other's feelings--and can I just say, *'Wow'?*--and then you got separated by Catra's accident and the resulting traumatic fallout, and now you're finally back together after ten years of concentrated yearning."

Adora nodded. "Pretty much."

"Adora," Bow sighed. "That just means it somehow makes even *less* sense that you didn't jump Catra the instant you laid eyes on her."

"Seriously! Why are you even *here?!"*

"And please don't say 'it's complicated'," Bow interrupted before Adora could even fully open her mouth to respond. "Like yeah, we get it. It's super complicated. But please explain, because this is just kinda... WTF."

"Bow, you're twenty-eight years old. You can just say fuck."

"I'm also 99% sure my dads will somehow sense it and call me the instant I do. Now please just answer the question."

Adora groaned, rubbing a hand across the back of her neck. "Ok, look: a *lot* of stuff came out when we had our talk. Stuff that's gonna take a while for us to work through. Everything we had is still there for the most part, but there's also a bunch of new stuff as well. Which I guess is just natural from being apart for so long.

"And honestly, I'm *okay* with that. She's still the same Catra I fell in love with. She's just also... More, now. And I want to get to know that Catra too. I'm just getting used to dealing with both sides of that coin."

They hadn't had time to meet up over the past few days, partly due to them both still processing and partly because Adora had thrown herself back into her rewrites and No Plan B was getting swamped with requests for post-tour interviews from various entertainment news outlets. Though that hadn't stopped them from texting back and forth regularly, to the point where Adora was really glad she had unlimited data.

It was great, but also a little awkward. They were still trying to figure out how to approach the subject of their separation, and especially Catra's night terrors (and Adora was still trying to figure out how to process that in the first place, because even though it still sounded completely insane she also knew Catra wouldn't lie to her about something that important. And even if she was inclined to lie, she'd definitely be able to come up with something *way* more plausible then "yeah, I've spent twenty three years haunted by horrible nightmare visions of another me who is apparently a chaotic-evil supervillain with serious abandonment issues.")

Yeah. Talking about *that* was gonna be super weird for a while, though Catra was trying to give Adora more details when she could emotionally handle it. Just to help her understand.

"All right," Bow conceded with a smile. "We'll respect your decision for now. But we definitely reserve the right to an

intervention if things get too ridiculous."

"Yeah, it can be the first meeting of the Concerned Bystanders of Useless Lesbians club," Glimmer added with a nudge and a wink.

"Why are you so insistent on that name?"

Bow smirked. "Because C-BUL is the perfect acronym for this situation."

"As in," Glimmer snorted with a mischevious grin. "'We see right through your bullshit.' And I still think you're making this waaay more complicated than it needs to be when you could be enjoying some serious sloppy makeouts."

Head in her hands, Adora sighed, hoping Catra was having better luck dealing with this than she was.

"So, you wanna tell me why you haven't ripped her clothes off yet?"

Catra literally *spat* her coffee out, narrowly avoiding spraying it across her cell phone and most of the kitchen counter. "Lonnie, *what the fuck?!*"

Across from her, Lonnie rolled her eyes from where she was trying to cajole Star from his carrier, since it was Catra's week for custody. "Ok, look, I get it if you're trying to be a gentlewoman or whatever, but every single time you two make eye contact I feel like I could hold up a match between you and have it burst into flames. So what's the deal?"

"Look, it's complicated, okay?"

"Bitch, please," Lonnie snorted with a knowing smirk. "We've known each other for twenty years."

"What, are you going to jump out of a cake at my birthday or something?"

"Well now you've just ruined the surprise. You really don't wanna see me jump out of the cake? You *insult* me."

"I'm just thinking you should save the elaborate foreplay for your actual girlfriend and not your best friend without benefits."

"Har har," Lonnie deadpanned as she finally succeeded in coaxing Star out and stood upright, planting her hands on her hips and glaring at her. "Deflect all you want, Catra. Doesn't change the fact that you and I know damn well that 'it's complicated' is just code for 'it's really not, I'm just being an emotionally constipated idiot about this whole thing.'"

Catra sighed, setting aside her phone and massaging her temples with her good hand, running the other through Star's fur as he hopped up on the counter to greet her. "Do we really have to do this right now?"

"Well, why not? I mean, I know for certain that you don't have a hot date to get to. That's the *problem,* you useless-ass lesbian."

"Ok, fine." She breathed in deep through her nose as she felt her tension headache spike. "It's fucking great, okay? Every time I'm around Adora we slip back into our old rhythm so effortlessly it's like breathing. Like we were never even apart. But we *were.* And something inevitably comes along to remind both of us of that fact. In many ways we're the same Catra and Adora we always were, but in about as many ways we're not. And I guess I'm just..."

Catra breathed out hard, looking away as her ears flicked back and she felt a blush rising to her cheeks. "I'm taking my time trying to learn those new pieces. Because I want to see *all* of her, the way I used to."

There was a moment of silence before Lonnie snickered. "Dude. You know what's a good way to-"

"That's a hard no. I'm not going there, not yet. Also shut the fuck up."

"I was gonna say 'take her out to dinner and a movie if you want to learn more about what she's been up to,' you dumbass bitch. Damn, your subconscious is thirsty. Also, I'd call you out on the presumptuousness of that 'not yet,' but it's Adora, so I'll let it slide."

"Wait, what the hell's *that* supposed to mean?"

"It means that if we could find a way to turn Adora's baseline level of thirst for your furry ass into kinetic energy, we would singlehandedly solve the energy crisis. I'm talking full-on perpetual motion machine, free-electricity-for-the-masses kinda deal."

There went her entire thought process into a mess of gay screaming. *Nope, nope, nope! Do not think about Adora being hot for you right now. Keep it together, Leandros, your life depends on it!*

Failure: step one. *Fuuuuuck...!*

Catra stared at Lonnie in disbelief. "Remind me again how someone like you ended up with a sweetheart like Scorpia?"

"I like to think of it as God's apology for five very long years of dealing with the four of you making heart eyes at your respective SOs and another seven of watching you specifically pine your way into the fucking Olympic gold medal of useless lesbianism."

And Catra just sorta gave up on having a peaceful morning at that point. *Man, I hope Adora's having an easier time of it than I am.*

Catra <3
Please oh please tell me you're free to get coffee with me. If

Lonnie roasts me any more, I'm gonna be more charcoal briquette than Magicat.

Adora
Oh God yes. If Glimmer and Bow drag ME any harder I'll be more roadkill than pop star.

Catra <3
Awesome. I know a quiet little place I think you'll like.

The place in question ended up being a combined coffee shop/library and Adora unambiguously loved it, taking some time to browse the shelves until a hand tapped her on the shoulder. "Been waiting long?"

Turning, she was greeted by the sight of Catra wearing a grey short sleeved hoodie and ripped jeans, but the thing that really made her breath catch was that Catra had most of her mane pulled up into a high ponytail (though there was still plenty of fluff around her face and ears.)

Upon seeing Adora's jaw go slack, Catra chuckled. "I take it you like the look?"

"Most definitely," Like all of Catra's best looks, it was still a little rough around the edges, but she looked... How could Adora describe it...? *Softer,* somehow. More open.

Catra winked. "Looking pretty good yourself, hot stuff."

(Adora would only admit with a gun to her head how much time and consideration she had put into her outfit instead of just defaulting to a plaid shirt/jeans combo like any self-respecting lesbian; gray slacks, brown hiking boots, and a red jacket with the sleeves pulled up to the elbow over a black tank top, which she had chosen *specifically* so she would have an excuse to slip it off later and show off her biceps, because *DAMNIT* she had a pretty girl to impress!)

"Thanks," Adora grinned back, trying not to let on that her stomach was doing gymnastics, and nudged Catra with her shoulder. "Since you've been here before, got any recommendations?"

"Well, the double roast is pretty good and if you want to split a brownie with me, I'm game. It's been a few months."

Yeah, it had turned out that some of Adora's childhood caution had been valid. Due to being an even mix of both cat and human, Magicats *could* eat chocolate--unlike regular cats--but only in smaller doses and nowhere near as frequently as humans. There were even apps to keep track of how often they could do so. Catra had developed a fondness for the stuff based on years of sharing their birthday cupcakes, but she was still very careful not to overindulge.

After making their order and getting both their drinks and a plate with two forks, they found a two-person table at the far end of the shop up against the wall so they could put their backs to it and still comfortably talk to one another. While they split the brownie, they made small talk, catching each other up on what had gone on in the past few days.

"So yeah, even though I told her I was fine with taking things slow, Lonnie still dragged the shit out of me," Catra finished her summation (though from the blush showing through her fur, Adora had a sneaking suspicion that she wasn't divulging the whole truth. Not that she had any stones to throw; she hadn't told the full truth about her conversation with Glimmer and Bow either.)

"Well, can't say I don't know what that's like," Adora admitted with a wry smile, which shifted into a thoughtful expression as Catra took a sip of her coffee and she caught sight of her name written on the cup. "Hey, can I ask you a question?"

"I'll answer any damn thing you ask me. Shoot."

"Well, while I was going to Juilliard," They both cringed a little, but Catra gave her a reassuring smile and a tap on the hand and Adora powered through the discomfort. "I hired some investigators to try and find you."

Catra's ears shot up. "You *paid* people to look for me?"

The genuine surprise in her voice physically *hurt* her, but Adora turned her hand over and gently clasped Catra's fingers in her own (fully aware that it was her left hand, which she had noticed Catra still tended to default to for any task that didn't require too much manual dexterity), before saying softly, "Of course I did."

They looked at each other for a long moment, before Catra sighed with a self-deprecating smile playing across her lips. "Sorry. I didn't mean to imply you didn't care or anything. It's just... I spent so much time messed up in my head that part of me was convinced that after the stunt I pulled, you wouldn't even bother trying to find me. My therapist has me working on challenging those thought processes, but they still sometimes slip through."

"I get it. Really." Shades of Dr. Hope helping her acknowledge her own abuse.

Catra's smile softened. "So you had a question?"

"Huh? Oh, right. So I had them looking for you for about three years," Catra almost choked, but Adora kept steaming on through. "But they found almost nothing. No paper trail at all. About the only thing they could tell me was that you weren't dead. How the hell did that happen?"

"Ah," Catra scratched the back of her neck awkwardly. "Yeah... So I might have an explanation for that."

Adora said nothing, just watched as Catra glanced at her and waited for her to continue.

"Ok, I just want you to know that it wasn't something I hid from you deliberately back at the Fright Zone. It just... sorta never

came up?" Adora's frowned, and she leaned in across the table when Catra muttered. "So, um, yeah... Catra isn't the name on my birth certificate."

Adora's brows *shot* up. "Wait, really?"

"Yeah," Catra mumbled, having given up on her neck and taking to rubbing her shoulder. "My birth name is C'yra Leandros the III. You can probably guess what that made my mother. But when I was just learning to talk as a kit, I couldn't pronounce my name correctly and called myself 'Catra' instead. Mom thought it was a hoot, and since it got pretty confusing around the house with two C'yras running about, the nickname more or less stuck."

"It's really pretty," Adora murmured. "C'yra, I mean."

"Thanks," Catra squeezed her hand gently. "Like I said, I wasn't intentionally hiding it or anything. It's just that after they both died there was really no one around to call me C'yra anymore, and by the time we met I didn't even think of myself that way. But on the rare occasions I do have to sign legal documents--not that I did that often in those three years--I was still legally obligated to use my birth name. Though I'll admit it *is* pretty convenient to avoid snooping paparazzi."

"I see," That explained quite a bit, actually. "Um... Do you want me to call you...?"

"I mean, if you want to," Catra shrugged. "Honestly, it doesn't particularly bother me either way. Though I would probably have to get used to hearing it again."

Hmm... Adora tucked that thought away for later. "I think I'll stick to Catra for now."

A chuckle. "Fine by me."

It was weird, Adora mused as Catra steered the conversation back into lighter topics: she had come to this meeting prepared to find

revelations about the new Catra. And instead, she was finding out new things about the old Catra.

Maybe they're not so different after all.

Later that afternoon, after she and Adora had parted ways with a long hug and a smile, Catra finished her sign-in and sat down to wait in the lobby of Bright Moon community psychiatry. She didn't have to wait long; despite the name it was a private company, which meant both added privacy for her now that she was officially in the public eye but also less patients to compete against for time slots.

"Miss Leandros, Dr. Micah is ready to see you now."

Smiling softly at the man's continued insistence on being known solely by his given name, Catra stood and strolled through the door, tapping once on the door to Micah's office before letting herself in.

"Well," Micah, the only man Catra had ever met who looked good with a top knot (it was probably the grey adding a distinguished touch), looked up over the top of his reading glasses and smiled at her. "If you'll permit a very bad dad joke on my part... Look what the cat dragged in."

Catra couldn't help but chuckle as she shook his hand. "Good to see you, Doc."

"Likewise," His laugh lines deepened along with the smile, before he gestured at the cozy armchair across from his desk. "Shall we get started?"

Catra settled back into the leather, which had a cushion that sank just right and little fist sized knobs protruding from the edge of the armrests so hybrids could grab on with their claws when feeling stressed without damaging the chair itself.

"So you've just completed your first big tour," Micah said as he checked back over his notes from previous sessions. "How do you feel?"

"Honestly? It was fucking incredible. I don't know what your taste in music is like, Doc, but we were on *fire."*

Micah chuckled. "Well, I do try to keep my work and home life separate like any proper therapist, but I *may* have heard a few songs by a certain band on the radio."

He looked up, an almost fatherly gleam in his eye. "You've come a long way since I met you."

"Thanks," Catra grinned, but her tail started thumping against the couch and she glanced away a little shyly as she continued. "Um... Something else pretty great happened."

"Oh?"

"Yeah. I um... I ran into Adora. Or rather, she ran into *me,* if you wanna get technical."

"That *does* sound like great news," He jotted something down on his paperwork. "I think a certain tell-tale tail is already giving me my answer, but for the sake of total transparency... How do you feel about that?"

"Amazing, if I'm being honest. I, uh... I told her about the dreams."

His eyes widened, leaning in a little. "That's a huge step forward for you, Catra. I take it she took the news relatively well?"

"Yeah, though she did threaten to suplex me off the couch first," They shared a laugh, while she gave him a brief rundown of the entire events of Friday. "But we're giving it another shot. Us, I mean. It's only been three days and I'm taking it slow so I can relearn her, so I don't wanna get ahead of myself but... Feels good."

"That's fantastic," Micah agreed, glancing over to the picture of his wife he kept on the wall. "It's always nice to be in love. Even when it's tough."

"Especially."

"That said... I do have one small concern."

Catra's nose wrinkled slightly, tail stilling. "Go on..."

"I worry that your keeping secrets will damage the renewed trust between the two of you, especially in a time when you should be most open with one another."

And Catra felt like the air had been driven from her lungs, her good hand lunging against the little knob for support. "How did you...?"

"I wouldn't have been your therapist for five years if I didn't have a good grasp of your personality by now, Catra," Micah pointed out. "So yes, I have noticed that you tend to be cagey around certain topics. Especially *one* topic in particular. Hey now, don't forget to breathe."

Catra sucked in a harsh breath, held it, and exhaled. "Sorry."

"It's all right. Some wounds cut right to the heart of us, and they can be very difficult to show to others, even trained medical professionals like myself. That said, the reason I am bringing it up is because if Adora knows you as well as our past discussions would indicate, she will likely pick up on the fact that you are hiding something sooner or later."

"Shit," Catra hissed, sinking her claws into the scratch knob almost as a reflex. "Look, Doc, if there's anyone in the world I can open up to about it, it would be Adora. But I'm not ready yet. I don't even know when I will be."

"And that's perfectly fine, Catra," Micah set down his pen and settled back in his desk chair, folding his hands. "Here's my advice

as your therapist: simply be honest with her. Tell her that you do have a secret you are keeping, but that you just aren't ready to tell her yet, although you hope to do so someday. Waiting patiently can be difficult, but it's less difficult than repairing damaged trust if it comes out at a bad time."

Catra sighed heavily, shoulders dropping as she looked away and chewed it over. Thinking about Adora; how good it felt to be together again, how nice it was to be on the same wavelength.

How much she liked holding her hand.

"Yeah, okay."

Chapter End Notes

The drama. She is here. ;) Also, feel free to picture canon!Catra's stunned face after DT (as Adora) calls her kitten when Lonnie crashes rockstar!Catra's brain, because that's sure as hell what I was imagining. XD

Next Time: an important discussion is had, Adora meets No Plan B's "son", summer arrives and that means it's time to hit the pool, Catra opens up a little to the other two members of BFS, a resolution nearly comes within kissing distance -wink-, and a very frustrated Adora calls in some advice from a certain very buff and very loyal new friend.

Living Is A Serious Business (Just Like Loving You)

Chapter Summary

> In which s4 comes back to haunt Catra, an important discussion/breakthrough is had, a group chat is initiated, Kyle goes off, a pool party is proposed and Adora and Catra plot Revenge™.

Chapter Notes

> Oh hey, look at that there increased chapter count. ;) Anyway, this guy ended up being way bigger than it should have, so in a few days I'll go back and revise the "next time" portion of last chapter. About half of this is angst and hurt/comfort (because the good people on tumblr doing Catra meta decided to hurt me) and the other half is right back into the hilarious bullshit zone. Now with a surprising amount of flirting. Enjoy.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra jolted awake shaking.

Kicking the sheets off--ignoring a startled "mrow" from where Star curled on the foot of the bed--she stumbled to her feet, not even bothering to turn on the lights. Afraid of what she'd see when the dark was banished...

"But did you ever stop to think... Maybe they're not the problem?"

Her hands trembled as she fumbled to turn on the water faucet, splashing her face, trying to ignore the sting of salt in her eyes. Reached blindly for the towel beside her as she dried her fur. Looked up...

Her reflection *grinned* at her beneath a mask of red.

Catra hit the wall behind her hard, and it was just her in the glass again, wide eyed and trembling.

"People have hurt you, haven't they?" Her own face smirking back at her, advancing slowly.

"It isn't real," She choked as she slid down to the floor and buried her hands in her mane. Her heart was trying to hammer it's way out of her chest the only way it could; salvo burst. "It isn't real. I didn't-- I *haven't-!"*

Adora's face shifting into mocking laughter. "Whoa. I knew this would get a rise out of you, but still... You really <u>are</u> obsessed, aren't you?"

Her left fist slammed into the floor tiles with a whimper, the sound of one of her knuckles popping. Didn't matter. Wasn't like she could use it much anyway. Most days she could barely make enough of a claw to strum her guitar.

"Huh," Adora, sitting at her desk when they were at regular school outside the Fright Zone. "Says here the word sinister used to be a way to refer to left-handed people. Then it just became a way to be mean to them. That's really dumb, huh?"

Sinister hand for a sinister wielder... Isn't that right, kitten?

"No," She whispered back to that voice purring in her head. "That's *my* memory. *Mine.* You don't get to just take it from me like that!"

"Looks like we're both alone."

"Stop it..."

"Didn't need you," Adora smiled cruelly as she took Catra's hand in hers, and brought it to her face, looking at her with half-lidded

eyes the way Catra had always dreamed of. "Left you."

And Catra broke.

"No..." She choked back the sob, curling up into a tight ball with her claws burying themselves in her shoulder. "I didn't... This time *I'm* the one who-!"

A mocking little chuckle. "It's for your own good, darling."

"We both know this was never what you <u>really</u> wanted."

Catra drew her fist back...

Duh-da-da... The sound of a Dsus2 chord followed by two open Ds. Or, in layman's terms... The opening riff to "Summer of '69."

"Really, furball? Most people just slap down a single text notification sound and call it a night. But nooooo, Catra Leandros just had to be extra and get specific with her contact list."

"It's all right, Lon. You can admit you're just mad because I assigned you 'Crazy Train.'"

Catra slowly lowered her arm, glancing over her shoulder back toward the bedroom where the light of her cell phone screen dimmed back to nothing. The riff didn't repeat.

Of course not. It's gotta be two in the damn morning. Get it together.

Climbing shakily to her feet, she stumbled back to her bed on jelly legs, throwing herself down and completely ignoring the large wet patch left behind from her panic sweat. There was a loud meow as Star stretched and meandered his way over to her, settling across her shoulders and kneading softly as the cat started up a chainsaw rumble purr.

Catra stared at her phone for several long minutes before reaching over and thumbing on the screen before she could make herself reconsider. It opened to her text messages.

Adorable
Hey.
So I'm really hoping you mute your phone when you sleep and you'll get this in the morning but...
I wanna see you? I mean, I know we had coffee just yesterday, but I still want to.
Is that too much?

"Didn't need you..."

"Shut the fuck up. You're not her," Catra whispers back to that other life, before tapping her claws across the screen.

Catra
It isn't. And I'm not doing anything important tomorrow.

Nothing except stewing in my own head trauma. A minute passed, and just when she started to wonder if Adora had sent that message just before going to bed the screen flashed.

Adorable
Catra... Are you awake because...?

Ah. To be honest or deflect, truly that was the question.

Adora's eyes, the only shade of blue that had ever taken Catra's breath away, looking up at her with knife-point intensity like she could see straight into Catra's soul. "Don't pull away. You don't have to run, and you don't have to drag me down. Just lean on me."

Swallowing past the ache in her throat, she typed three short keystrokes.

Catra
Yes

The message turned to read, but there was no corresponding notice of Adora typing in return. Catra waited, feeling like complete shit as the adrenaline finally wore off and the exhaustion settled in.

The phone rang, displaying Adora's picture from their coffee... Hangout? Date? Who even knew at this point, because Catra sure as hell didn't. (Just that she was still so fucking in *love* with this girl.)

Swallowing hard, she brought the phone to her ear.

"Hey," Adora said softly on the other end. "You wanna talk about it or do you want me to just babble until I bore you back to sleep?"

Heh. How very like you to mistake total relief and comfort for boredom.

"Why are you even awake, Adora?"

"I hit a creative burst, so I'm working on finishing those rewrites I mentioned. Glimmer and I have a meeting with the record execs next week and I'm going all in."

"Rainbow isn't going with?"

"His name is just Bow, and he's not as big on the politicking as we are."

"Relax, Adora, I know his name. I was just teasing," Catra chuckled, wondering if it sounded as raw and bloody as she felt. "Don't remember you being big on politicking either."

"Honestly? Glimmer's the negotiator. *I'm* the stick."

There we go. "That makes better sense. But anyway... I swear that guy gives off the same aura as a buffer, more chill Kyle--just happy to be here."

"Honestly, yeah. I got that vibe too. It's part of why we gelled so quick--took me and Glimmer a while to stop butting heads even after we earned each other's respect."

"Oh, I've gotta hear this one."

She listened as Adora launched into the story of how she--fresh out of college and with a *massive* chip on her shoulder--basically stomped into Bright Moon Records like she owned the place and almost immediately started a throwdown with Glimmer over her guitar skills. But as amusing as it was to picture the indignant look on Sparkles' face when Adora practically drop-kicked her off her high horse... Well, imaginary Glimmer wasn't the only thing starting to drop.

"Hey, Catra?" Adora's voice was gentle as Catra forced herself back out of that hazy zone between sleep and awake. "Feeling a little better?"

"Rrrrrryeah," She groaned out, nudging Star off her back so she could flip over. "Just sucks."

"I get that," A half-hearted chuckle. "But I never stopped having your back, you know? Don't hesitate to call. I'll do what I can to help."

You can start by getting the fuck over here and not letting me go.

Nope, not going there right now. Now when her heart still felt like it had gone twelve rounds with a spring-loaded boxing glove.

"You still okay with getting together tomorrow?"

Catra blinked, realizing she hadn't even responded to the assurance. "Yeah."

Simply be honest with her. Micah's voice. *It's less difficult than repairing damaged trust.*

She only hesitated a second, claws going to her hip so she could scratch her part-time cat's chin. "Wanna come over to my place? We can just chill like old times, and there's someone I want you to meet."

"I don't know..." Adora sing-songed, and Catra's tail lashed contentedly in response. "I'm not gonna be third-wheeling anyone, am I?"

"Being a third-wheel or *making* someone a third-wheel?"

"Do you really have to ask? You wound me, Catra. Shot through the heart."

The knot in her chest (and the phantom noose around her neck) *finally* loosened. "Syntax is important, sunshine."

There's a pause, and when Adora speaks again Catra could almost hear the smile. "Been a while since I heard that one."

"Stick around a while. You'll hear it plenty."

"Oh believe me, I intend to."

And Catra decided to just bite the bullet, because it's three a.m. and she's too damn tired to keep pretending everything's all right to the only person she ever fully believed in. "Hey, umm... Do me a favor?"

The pencil scratches on the other end cease. "Yeah?"

Catra's cheeks heated up, but she powered through anyway (even

though her voice became whisper-thin.) "... Hum for me?"

Like you used to. Back when that was the only thing that was right in our lives.

A pause, and then, "Of course. Any requests?"

"Dealer's choice."

It sounded a little tinny over the phone so it took Catra about half a minute to figure it out. Once she did... Well, she couldn't stop the purring if she wanted.

It's gettin' near dawn
When lights close their tired eyes
I'll soon be with you, my love

Really, Adora? "Sunshine of Your Love?" And people think I'm the extra one. Catra chuckles. "You're such a sap."

"Admit it, you like it."

Well, you're half right.

They both wind down slow after that.

Adora bounced on the balls of her feet as she rode the elevator to the sixth floor. *Shoulda taken the stairs. But that'd take too long. But then I wouldn't feel so keyed up. Dang it... Why are executive decisions so hard?*

The doors finally slid open with a ding and she breathed a sigh of relief as she stepped out into the hall and checked for room 6. *There.* Perfectly ordinary as far as doors went, but it might as well have been a magnet for how fast Adora marched over.

The door swung open before she could even knock. "Hey, Adora."

Adora smirked. "That excited to see me, huh?"

"Don't flatter yourself too much. These ears," Catra tapped one claw against the appendages and Adora's fingers twitched in response. "Hear everything. Great for party tricks, less great when your neighbors are having kinky roleplay sex at two a.m. C'mon in."

Adora frowned as Catra turned away, pondering the sudden standoffishness, before she heard her mutter, "Answer's yes, by the way."

Holy crap, I didn't know the back of her neck blushed too. That's so cute.

Didn't help that Catra was looking surprisingly cozy in an oversized mottled grey hoodie (right sleeve pulled up) and a pair of dark gym shorts that read "Feral" across the back. Hiding a wry smile, Adora remembered how Catra liked to bundle up when she either was or wanted to feel comfortable, but was always balancing against the issue of how much heat her body put off. Which lead to a fair amount of oversized sweaters paired with short shorts, or fuzzy pajama bottoms with tanks. *Also very cute. But stand by for more data on whether she is comfortable right now or just trying to be.*

Fortunately she did have other things to consider beyond her level of concern/affection/*gay,* taking in her surroundings with a curious gaze. Catra's apartment was a studio with an open floor plan, though she had cleverly partitioned off certain areas with strategically placed book cases and (to Adora's absolute delight) a full-sized record player cabinet separating the "bedroom" from the designated living room. About the only area that was clearly separated by original design--aside from a door she presumed lead to the bathroom--was the kitchenette in the corner, where the carpet transitioned to tiles and much of the space was taken up by an island in the center.

Though... As she made a beeline for the bookcases to Catra's knowing chuckle--both to check the books themselves and eyeball the sizeable cd collection on the top shelves--she couldn't help but find it a little odd that it was a row of *half* bookcases, especially when there were new cds and books and composition notes cluttered atop in sometimes dangerous constructions.

"Ah," Catra rubbed the back of her neck when Adora shot a questioning glance her way. "It's a lot easier to calm down when I can clearly see that I'm alone."

Ouch. Ok, put a check-mark in the "attempt at self-soothing" column. And be patient. She let you into her space, after all.

To give herself some time to figure out how to steer this visit back into less-painful waters, Adora wandered over to the farthest wall, which was mainly just a giant sheet of glass. Glancing out over the city, she couldn't help a small smile at the memories of her and Catra sitting at their dorm window, looking out over the grounds of Fright Zone and dreaming of the future. "Good view. But does it bother you that scummy reporters could have a clear line of sight in?"

"Why would I be? After all..." Catra smirked and stuck her tongue out. "It's not like they're looking for C'yra Leandros. But if I do want some privacy I can drop the shutters outside."

"Clever girl."

There was a loud "Mrow" from behind her and Adora jumped. Half turning, she spotted a lithe white cat with piercing blue eyes sitting on the record player watching her.

Moving slowly and telegraphing her motions, she stood at the end of the cabinet and waited for the cat to come to her. "So this is what you meant by me meeting someone?"

"Yup," Catra smiled as she joined her, and the cat made a direct line to her, rubbing along the front of her hoodie. "His name's Star. Scorpia and I found him on our previous tour, and we more or less

adopted him as No Plan B's mascot. Just give him time to figure you out; he's deaf."

"Really?" That explained the extra loud vocalizations.

"Yeah, cats with his fur and eye color combo are really predisposed towards deafness. Probably why he was abandoned in the first place," Despite the harshness of the words, Catra couldn't help but laugh when Star hopped up onto her shoulder and began rubbing his face up against her ears. "Malnutrition stunted his growth a bit, but with perks like this I can't say I mind much, even if I still wanna beat the hell out of his first owner."

"I'm with you there," Adora stretched out a hand in the cat's general direction, stopping short and patiently waiting for him to make the next move. The whiskers tickled as he balanced delicately on Catra's shoulder and extended his neck to sniff at her. "So is he with you all the time, or...?"

"I wish. But if I tried to gain full custody it might actually cause a band breakup. Obviously he stays with all of us together when we're on the tour bus, but in the off season we rotate week by week."

Star seemingly made up his mind and began rubbing his face against Adora's hand. "So how'd you find him?"

"Well..."

"Hey, Scorps, you get lost on your way to the ice machine?" Catra called out as she exited the hotel room into the frankly ridiculous desert heat. Like living in hell's own microwave. She'd even had to pick up a pair of cheap flip flops just to keep from scorching her feet on the pavement while they were here.

No answer. She sniffed the air, picking up a bit of that weird burnt ozone smell that always seemed to linger around the other woman, as well as the hydrating oil she used to keep her carapace from cracking with the lack of humidity in this area.

The scent went about halfway towards the ice machine before suddenly veering off down the hallway leading to the parking lot. Bracing herself for the noon day sun (and wishing she'd grabbed a pair of sunglasses) Catra followed after, blinking as she stepped from the shade into the brilliant afternoon heat. Shading her eyes, she spotted Scorpia crouched down a few meters away from the motel dumpster.

"Hey, what's u-"

"Shh!" Scorpia hissed, waving one claw to bring Catra over. Hands shoved nonchalantly in her pockets, she obeyed, coming to a stop next to her. Scorpia murmured, "Hey little guy, it's all right."

A pale face and a pair of very blue eyes peeked out from beneath the dumpster, followed by one of the loudest vocalizations Catra had ever heard from one of her feline "cousins."

So that was the game. Catra rolled her eyes fondly and crouched down beside Scorpia. "You and your strays."

"Aww, c'mon Wildcat. Tell me you're not enamored with those big blue eyes."

Well, they were the second prettiest pair Catra had ever seen, but it wasn't like she had to admit that. "Oof. Should I go back to the room and tell Lonnie she's been replaced? I may have to specify that it's a real cat, or she might break a chair over my head."

Scorpia laughed softly and elbowed Catra in the shoulder before resuming trying to coax the little guy out.

Catra wasn't sure how long they crouched there, but something eventually clicked in her head. A car went by only fifteen feet away, crunching the gravel and kicking up dust... But the cat's ear didn't even flick in its direction once. It just kept its eyes fixed on the two of them.

'Ohhhh... All right, I got this.'

Reaching up to tap Scorpia on the shoulder, she said, "Ok, I figured it out. Sit down, keep your claws forward and relaxed and close your eyes. Then just wait patiently, and don't make any sudden moves."

She demonstrated and Scorpia copied her. Before long, they heard the light crunch of footpads on gravel. Scorpia's breath hitched in surprise, but Catra kept her eyes closed and hummed a little under her breath.

A whisper soft brush against her hand, a tentative touch, before a soft body rubbed up against her. Catra giggled and finally looked down as the cat settled in the nest of her crossed legs. "Aww, little guy's touch starved. You can look now."

As Scorpia cooed at their new feline friend and held out one claw for him to investigate, Catra snaked her hand behind the distracted cat's head and snapped her fingers once, twice. Not a single twitch of the ear. "Thought so. This guy's deaf."

"Whoa, seriously?"

"Yup. That's why his vocalizations are so loud; he can't hear himself to modulate it. It's also why I told you to stay still and close your eyes; that's a big indicator of trust for cats, and since he can't hear body language becomes doubly important."

"Not to make it weird, but I always assumed Magicats wouldn't really like cats all that much. Y'know, what with people comparing you to them all the time in a derogatory way."

"I mean, sure: some Magicats <u>do</u> hate cats for that exact reason, but the way I figure that's not the cats' fault. That's just people being assholes," Catra grinned broadly as their new friend stood on his back legs to sniff at her face. "Besides, shitty comparisons and racism or not... Cats and Magicats understand each other."

"Hey, I was starting to worry you two had been abducted! What the hell are you doing?" Lonnie's voice came behind them as she jogged up to her girlfriend and best friend, before drawing up

short when she caught sight of the bundle of fur in Catra's lap and the big puppy dog eyes Scorpia had trained her way. "Guys, no..."

"Guys, yes," Catra parroted back with a smug expression. 'Nope, not helping you be the adult today, Lon.'

"We're on tour."

"Cats sleep most of the day anyway. Just let him crash on the window seat."

"Most motels don't allow pets."

"What they don't know won't hurt 'em," Scorpia chipped in with a pleased twinkle in her eye as Lonnie's facade of control started to crack.

"Look, we can just take him to a shelter so we can be sure he'll get adopted-"

"Yeah, that's a <u>real</u> bad idea," Catra drawled. "Deaf cats take the longest to get adopted. So you'd basically be rolling the dice on whether or not he'd find a family up to the challenge before he gets euthanized."

That did it. Lonnie's shoulders slumped in defeat as she looked between the two of them. "Ok, fine. Let's hustle him back to the room before anyone notices. Then we all need to get some sleep for the show tomorrow."

"Thanks, honey!" Scorpia half shouted as she delicately picked up the cat and Catra had to put a hand over her mouth to hide her smirk at the way Lonnie's pleased blush darkened her ears. Scorpia turned to glance down at Catra as they trudged back to the room. "What do you think we should call him?"

Catra hummed thoughtfully, mind already focused on the next day's show and the need to pick up some pet supplies ASAP. "How 'bout Star?"

"Star? I mean, it's a good name, but I'm not seeing the connection. I was gonna suggest Snowy as an opener, but that seems a bit too on the nose."

"Star," Catra confirmed with a resolute nod. "Because that's what we're gonna be, yeah?"

"So hilariously enough, it turns out Rogelio has a mild allergy to cat fur that we never noticed before because I'm good at brushing and keeping myself clean, but it wasn't anything some anti-histamines couldn't fix," Catra finished up her story as she and Adora relaxed on her comfy sofa together.

Adora laughed. "Somehow that's even funnier when you remember how often you two would go back to back in a throwdown, or carry each other when injured. Or just brush up against each other during shedding season."

"I know, right? Those scales, man; next best thing to a shed brush."

"And your claws," Adora pointed out with the appropriate hand gesture.

"Well duh," Catra snickered with a puckish wink. "Gotta return the favor."

Raising her left hand from the back of the couch, she teasingly wiggled the fingers... Then abruptly paused when the sleeve slid down a bit, eyes flicking between the hand and Adora. Clearing her throat, she stood up and pattered, "You still a big Sprite fan-"

Only to pull up short when Adora stood as well (an offended Star racing off to studio parts unknown) and put a hand on her shoulder to stop her. "Let me see."

Tail curling defensively around the opposite leg, Catra turned to Adora with a bitter twist on her lips. "Can't fool you, huh?"

But she still let Adora take her hand. Bracing herself--because this was the first time she'd gotten to look at Catra's left hand in ten years, even after their reunion she always wore gloves--Adora rolled up the sleeve. The knuckles were obviously swollen and bruised beneath the fur, but although Catra winced a little as Adora gently probed the damage, they didn't appear to be broken. Further up...

She had to hand it (no pun intended) to the surgeons; they'd done a pretty amazing job considering there had once been questions of whether or not Catra would keep that hand. But that didn't stop the ache behind her eyes as they traced along the jagged, zig-zagging lines of knotted scar tissue arching up and down across the back of Catra's hand, a couple even extending into her fingers. It was a minor damn miracle she could even move them at all.

A whisper. "You okay?"

Adora forced herself out of the past and returned her focus to the fresh damage, though not without a light stroke across the scars first. "What happened?"

"Freakout. Was still caught up in the night terrors, so I smashed it into the bathroom tiles."

"Shit," Adora hissed, shooting Catra a glare. "And you decided to hide it via an overheating hoodie... Why?"

Catra flinched at the venom in her tone, ears going back. "Ok, look. I promised you I wouldn't run away again. And I won't. It's just..."

She dipped forward so she could rest her forehead against Adora's shoulder, and even while pissed off, Adora would never force her away from that. "I'm just having to get used to not dealing with it on my own again. All right?"

Damnit. Adora knew she had anger issues, but Catra always had a way of explaining things in just the right way to neutralize that

impulse. *Patience, remember?* "Ok, fair. Why don't we just relax for a bit and I can patch you up? *After* I get us both those drinks."

"Fine. But I'm putting on *Back in Black*."

Within a few minutes they were both sipping on their respective preferred sodas (Coke for Catra, diet Sprite for Adora) while Adora applied an ice pack and neosporin to Catra's injury. No stitches this time, so Adora figured they had to be doing better.

"Hey," Catra mumbled about halfway through. "Can I tell you something important while you're too distracted to go off on me?"

Adora paused, raising a questioning eyebrow. "I can assure you that I am way better at multitasking than I was as a child, so I am fully capable of taking care of you and berating you at the same time. But I won't."

They watched each other in silence, nothing but the contact and the sound of AC/DC playing softly--or at least with the volume greatly diminished--in the background.

"Ok," Catra started with a slow drawl. "My therapist recommended I tell you this, and I tend to value his advice on most things. That is what I'm paying him for, after all."

Weak attempt at humor, but Adora let it slide. But she also wasn't gonna let Catra off easy. "And...?"

Catra sighed, shoulders slumping a little. "There's one thing I haven't told you yet, about everything that's happened. And it's not because I don't trust you; you're probably the only person on the whole damn planet I would trust with it. It just..."

Damnit, Catra, you don't get to nearly give me a heart attack and then follow it up with sweet--and stupid--consideration for my feelings! You're giving me whiplash!

The Magicat in question broke eye contact, oblivious to Adora's internal struggle. "It just still hurts... A little *too* much. But I don't

like lying to you by omission, and I don't want you to worry that I'm hiding something from you. Not anymore. Not when we're finally together again."

Adora exhaled slowly, coming down from the adrenaline burst that had spiked through her system when she thought Catra was admitting to outright lying to her. "Ok. I can understand that."

After all, you're the one who still hasn't explained to Glimmer and Bow what really went on in the Fright Zone. Shoving that thought into a box and tossing it out the metaphorical window, she continued, "I won't lie and say I'm not worried. But... Thank you for telling me. It means a lot."

Pretty much everything, her mind conceded as Catra finally relaxed and let Adora pull her against her shoulder. "Yeah, well thanks for listening. And for not threatening to suplex me off the couch again."

Adora couldn't help but chuckle as her hand went up to scritch at Catra's ears and they leaned fully into each other.

That was one of the weirder side effects of growing up in the Fright Zone, Adora had found over the past decade. It taught you pretty quickly that inside its walls, words were just weapons, and they cut both ways. She had learned pretty quickly to disregard them entirely unless they were backed up by plenty of corresponding actions, and even then... Adora still valued actions alone way more heavily than pretty little speeches.

But then she'd ended up in the normal world, where most people didn't grow up constantly looking for subtext and where the next attack was coming from, and had thus discovered that to most people words *did* actually mean something on their own. It had taken her a long time to start letting her words do the talking, and it was always a work in progress.

She and Catra had been forced to communicate almost entirely in actions to convey how they felt to one another. A hand on the

shoulder meant, *Tell me what's bothering you. Tell me where it hurts.* A gentle nudge, a tap on the chin, *I'm here. How are you doing?* Holding onto each other in the dead of night, anchoring each other through their respective demons, *I love you, I love you, I love you so much that it sometimes makes my heart hurt, but I don't ever want it to stop.*

All of that was still there. That was never in any doubt for Adora. But maybe (just maybe) it was time they started to exhume those long-buried words. Maybe it was finally time to unearth them again, learn to blunt them until they were no longer knives made solely for stabbing outward while lacerating the hands that held them.

The Fright Zone was gone, and they were together again. They had time.

"Well, well, well...." Glimmer leered at her with an impish grin and a wink when Adora unlocked the door to the apartment the next morning. "And where have *you* been, young lady?"

"Slept over at Catra's," Adora replied with a wink and a grin of her own. At Glimmer's opening mouth, she added, "And before you follow that up, I slept on the couch. I was a perfect gentlewoman."

Catra had also slept on the couch (apparently that was just becoming their thing?) but they didn't need to know that.

"Literally nobody asked you to be, but all right. You don't seem to be at all bothered by it, so you do you, Adorkable."

"So are you just going to start borrowing all of Lonnie's nicknames?"

"I prefer to think of it as cross-culture-*troll* exchange," Bow chipped in from where he was frying up some sausage and eggs,

making Glimmer whirl with a delighted grin and start on him and his bad pun instead.

Chuckling under her breath, Adora made her way to her room to change into some new clothes, remembering how nice it had felt to wake up with one rather content purring Magicat on her chest and an equally purring normal cat stretched across her shoulders. Trading jokes and smiles and light brushes against one another while Catra whipped up some pancakes and bacon *("Not* bacon pancakes?" "Oh my God, you are such a dork.") Feeling like a weight had been lifted between them.

It was good.

About the only thing Catra hadn't been able to provide was a strong cup of coffee--she was just as much of a caffeine hound as any other musician, but too much at one time did some funny things to a Magicat's system, so she was more or less forced to be a smaller doses around the clock kind of gal. Adora, meanwhile, had a monthly repeat order for the most caffeinated coffee available on the market (amusingly named "Caffeinated as Fuck") and tragically had nowhere higher to go up the fuel ladder.

Didn't stop Adora from drinking half the pot anyway, just to linger a little longer.

Feeling less gross in clean clothes (or at least until she could take a shower) she made her way back to the kitchen so she could make a cup of her own brew. Glimmer and Bow were sitting at the table eating their breakfast--Bow had graciously set aside a plate for Adora, which she slid into the fridge with a wink in his direction.

"So when are we gonna get to formally meet Catra?" Glimmer asked, not quite polite enough to avoid talking with a full mouth but courteous enough to at least cover it with her hand while she did so. "I mean, technically we met last week, but I think she was a *little* preoccupied at the time."

"Funny you should ask," Adora chuckled. "She's coming over Saturday to, as she put it, 'check out your new digs,' because turnabout's fair play. Can I count on you two to behave?"

They replied in unison. "No."

Yeah, she hadn't expected it either, she conceded as she hid her grin against the curve of her coffee cup.

Friday, June 1st
(Admin) Lonnie created group chat.

Lonnie named group chat 'Summer's Here and We're All Queer'

Lonnie added Scorpia, Catra, Rogelio and Kyle to group chat 'Summer's Here and We're All Queer.'

Catra: What the hell?

Catra: Lonnie... What are you up to? We already have a group chat.

Lonnie: Gimme a sec.

Lonnie added Adora, Glimmer and Bow to group chat 'Summer's Here and We're All Queer.'

Catra: ... Lonnie, no.

Lonnie: Lonnie, yes! I am your friggin' god here! In fact... ¬‿¬

Lonnie changed name to 'Your Beneficent Overlord'

Your Beneficent Overlord changed Catra's name to 'Cat Scratch Fever'

Cat Scratch Fever: I SWEAR TO GOD, LONNIE I WILL KILL YOU IN REAL LIFE!!!

Cat Scratch Fever: YOU KNOW I HATE THAT FUCKING SONG!

Cat Scratch Fever: ... Why can't I change my name?

Your Beneficent Overlord: You need admin access for that. And you're insane if you think I'm giving you that.

Cat Scratch Fever: akdhjfbak!!! FUCK YOU LONNIE!

Your Beneficent Overlord: ...

Cat Scratch Fever: ...

Cat Scratch Fever: ... -sigh- What do you want?

Your Beneficent Overlord: Hmm? ;D

Cat Scratch Fever: What do I have to do to get you to change this stupid name?

Your Beneficent Overlord: Oh, nothing much.

Your Beneficent Overlord: Just ask nicely. ¬‿¬

Cat Scratch Fever: ...

Your Beneficent Overlord: ... I have all day, Catra.

Cat Scratch Fever: Ok fine. -sigh- Please change this stupid name.

Your Beneficent Overlord: See, that wasn't so hard, was it?

Cat Scratch Fever: Bitch.

Your Beneficent Overlord: I'm gonna choose to overlook that.

Your Beneficent Overlord changed Cat Scratch Fever's name to 'Catra on a Hot Tin Roof'

Catra on a Hot Tin Roof: ... You know what? I'm okay with this. But only because that play is gay as fuck.

Your Beneficent Overlord: Option B was "What's New Pussycat" but I figured that'd be going too far.

Catra on a Hot Tin Roof: You'd be right.

Adora: Whoa, so this is why my phone's blowing up.

Adora: Hey, Catra. ;)

Catra on a Hot Tin Roof: Hey Adora. ;)

Your Beneficent Overlord: Christ, get a room you two.

Catra on a Hot Tin Roof: You invited us, asshole.

Adora: Heh. I think we just got one. ;)

Your Beneficent Overlord: ...

Catra on a Hot Tin Roof: ...

Adora: ... Deja vu, huh? ;D

Catra on a Hot Tin Roof: >;) > ;3 >;D

Your Beneficent Overlord: Oh crap, what have I done? Control those eyebrows, furball.

Bow: Hey, what's going on?

Your Beneficent Overlord: PRAISE THE SUN. You know the rules, you two. No obscene behavior in front of the sunshine boy.

Bow: ?

Catra on a Hot Tin Roof: Tch, fine. But only if you promise to never refer to him as just sunshine. The modifier stays.

Your Beneficent Overlord: ... Yeah, I can already guess why, but I'll accept the terms of this agreement. Also...

Your Beneficent Overlord changed Bow's name to 'Sunshine Boy'

Your Beneficent Overlord changed Adora's name to 'Dumb Jock Energy'

Dumb Jock Energy: ...

Catra on a Hot Tin Roof: ... Lonnie.

Your Beneficent Overlord: Ok, fine.

Your Beneficent Overlord changed Dumb Jock Energy's name to 'Adorkable'

Adorkable: Much better.

Sunshine Boy: So what's all this about?

Your Beneficent Overlord: I'll tell you when the other gays get here.

Rogelio: Well you can check off two more, because *what fresh hell is this?*

Kyle: Ordinarily I'd be calm or at least upbeat about this, but you're interrupting our date night. So yeah... What the hell.

Your Beneficent Overlord changed Kyle's name to 'Roadie To The Max'

Your Beneficent Overlord changed Rogelio's name to 'The F*cking Lizard King'

The F*cking Lizard King: ...

Roadie To The Max: ... Thanks for the compliment, I guess?

Catra on a Hot Tin Roof: Check the backlogs. I got worse.

Your Beneficent Overlord: No prob. :P Now we just gotta wait for Glimmer.

Sunshine Boy: I'll go give her a heads up. She's been talking to her mom on the phone for the past hour.

Adorkable: Oh boy. -_-

The F*cking Lizard King: No Scorpia?

Your Beneficent Overlord: She's taking a nap.

Your Beneficent Overlord posted a photo to the group chat.

Your Beneficent Overlord: See?

Adorkable: Aww, lap pillow? That's really cute.

Catra on a Hot Tin Roof: Please don't encourage her.

Your Beneficent Overlord: You do not get to take the high ground on this one, snugglepuss.

Catra on a Hot Tin Roof: ... I know where you sleep.

Your Beneficent Overlord: What a shocking turn of events. I know where you sleep too. Hey, Adora, how's it hanging?

Catra on a Hot Tin Roof: akghsjgahjy!?!!!

Roadie To The Max: Business as usual, huh?

Adorkable: Where did you go off to?

Roadie To The Max: Well Rogelio and I are at a club, so I think I'm allowed to take a break from these shenanigans to dance with my boyfriend before coming back to this clusterfuck.

Catra on a Hot Tin Roof: Damn, Kyle, go off.

Roadie To The Max: -fistbump-

Glimmer: Ok, I'm here. And thanks for the excuse to end that awkward conversation. 'Sup bitches?

Sunshine Boy: She says "awkward" but what she really means is "so volatile I got a contact burn just standing there."

Glimmer: You don't have to tell everything you know, Bow. :) Gimme a sec while I check everyone's names.

Your Beneficent Overlord changed Glimmer's name to 'Respect Your Local Drummer'

Respect Your Local Drummer: Ok, I'm back.

Respect Your Local Drummer: You know what? I'm okay with this.

Catra on a Hot Tin Roof: Well, everyone's here. Wanna tell us why you've dragged us into this little circle of Hell?

The F*cking Lizard King: It's only hell for the emotionally constipated and perpetually dragged. The rest of us are having a gay old time.

Respect Your Local Drummer: !!!!! BURN SNIPE!!!!

Adorkable: We're doing perfectly fine at our own pace. **Back off.**

Respect Your Local Drummer: o.o

Sunshine Boy: Yeah, Adora's doing that thing where her glare seems to pierce right through you like a plasma cutter. It's focused on her phone screen right now, but I still feel extremely threatened.

Your Beneficent Overlord: Ok, let's cool it with the teasing for now and get down to business.

Catra on a Hot Tin Roof: Thank heaven... -_-

Your Beneficent Overlord: As you guys know, summer has officially arrived. And it just so happens that Scorpia's moms are still travelling on their second honeymoon off in Solace (#lifegoals) and asked us to house sit for them while they're gone.

Your Beneficent Overlord: So what I'm basically getting at is they've *GRACIOUSLY* given us permission to have a pool party at their place this coming Friday. So I figure let's get both crews together and have some fun.

Respect Your Local Drummer: FUCKING AWESOME! I'm in. B)

Roadie To The Max: I mean, I'm not gonna turn down a chance to hang out with friends.

The F*cking Lizard King: Do Scorpia's moms still have that kickass firepit and grill?

Your Beneficent Overlord: You know it. ;)

The F*cking Lizard King: ... I will cook and eat like the f*cking king I am.

Sunshine Boy: Well if you guys're handling food, I guess we can bring the sodas and stuff. Be sure to send me a drink list later.

Your Beneficent Overlord: Cool. Hey, Adora, you're being awful quiet over there. You in?

Adorkable: Hmm? Yeah, definitely. I'm just adjusting my revision schedule to free up a day.

Your Beneficent Overlord: Holy crap, they've got you guys doing revisions again?

Respect Your Local Drummer: Why do you think I was fighting with my mom? -_-

Sunshine Boy: Enjoy your glimpse into the music industry with corporate overseers. -.-

Your Beneficent Overlord: Well at least you can all take some time to relax between that bullshit. Anyway, since we're all confirmed, you can go about your own business now if you want.

Catra on a Hot Tin Roof: Wait... You never asked if I was coming.

Your Beneficent Overlord: You already RSVP'd. Adora's coming, isn't she?

Catra on a Hot Tin Roof: ...

Catra on a Hot Tin Roof left the group chat!

Sunshine Boy: Oof, made her mad.

Your Beneficent Overlord: Nah, she'll be fine. She always ragequits after a certain amount of dragging.

Respect Your Local Drummer: I'd still sleep with my door locked tonight if I were you.

Your Beneficent Overlord: It's cool, it's cool. Just ask Adora.

Your Beneficent Overlord: ... Adora?

Adorkable went idle!

The F*cking Lizard King: You were saying?

Your Beneficent Overlord: Oh balls.

Private message between Adora and Catra <3

Adora
Hey, you good?

Catra <3
Yeah, I just reached the edge of my snarky BS limit for the day.

Adora
Ok, so I don't wanna assume anything, but /are/ you coming to the party?

Catra <3
Duh. Can't have my revenge on Lonnie otherwise.

Adora
Ooh... Please give me the details when you're ready. I'll back you up if need be.

Catra <3
Well of course. Where would I be without my favorite partner in crime? ;)

Adora
Aww...

Adora
Ok, I just wanna check real fast. Is your problem with water thing gonna be an issue?

Catra <3
Shouldn't be. Obviously everyone from the Fright Zone knows, and so does Scorpia. I'll let Rainbow and Sparkles know what's up if necessary, but it'll be nice to just lounge in the sun and enjoy some hot dogs.

Adora
Awesome. :) We still on for tomorrow?

Catra <3
You know it.

Catra <3
<3

Adora
!!! <3

Chapter End Notes

I wanna note real quick here that I absolutely adore DT's callout speech and can rant for hours about it from both an analytical and psychological symbolism perspective. The point I was trying to convey here is that like a lot of Catra's storyline, context is super critical (and even in context, some parts are fucked up, which is why Hordak and Shadow Weaver didn't pop up) and once you take away said context, it becomes outright cruel. Hope I conveyed that well enough.

Oh, and "Caffeinated as Fuck" coffee is actually a real thing and I drink it every morning. So like Adora, I too have nowhere else to go. XD Next chapter's a third of the way written, but it's my mom's bday tomorrow so I'm gonna be busy this weekend.

Next time: A pool party is had, everyone gets to know each other a little better, Catra commits a crime against both God and fashion in the name of petty vengeance and later opens up to the other two members of BFS, Adora does some opening up of her own, Kyle accidentally becomes public enemy number one, Rogelio is a bro, and our two idiots are forced to seek counsel from old and new friends.

Gently, Gently, Make Room For Happiness (At Last)

Chapter Summary

The pool party arrives and a lot happens. Featuring: Catra meeting the Best Friend Squad, Adora chooses artistic integrity, Adora dresses to impress and Catra dresses to *distress,* the embarrassing stories only your best friends know and will ruthlessly use against you, healthy discussion of past traumas and emotional boundary setting, Kyle accidentally becoming Etheria's most wanted, and our two overly dramatic gays managing to coordinate a love song across the space-time continuum.

Chapter Notes

Oof. Sorry this one took so long, guys. We had a week of rain at my place and Seasonal Affective Disorder does not play nice with depression. But the upside is you get a mega, double-sized update! I'll try to get the next one out sooner than two weeks. :)

Quick notes: I meant to mention this in previous chapters, but if Rogelio is around people who don't speak sign you can generally assume one of the others is translating for him. The two songs near the end that Catra and Adora sing the first stanza and choruses to are "Takeoffs and Landings" by The Ataris and "Never Be The Same" by RED if you wanna listen along. Also small joking discussion of recreational drug use in the past, but nothing serious.

Unbelievable HUGE shoutout to UnsolvedRubixsCube for managing to find THIS amazing cover of "The Killing Kind" by lady singer Emi Pellegrino. While I wish the background instumentals were as bombastic as the original, in some ways the vocals are even better. Check it out. I'll add it to the concert notes later as well.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The parking attendant at Bright Moon Towers (to Catra's amusement) did a double take when Catra rolled down the window and handed over her ID for him to check. He was professional about it, to be sure, but she could still practically hear the gears turning in his head.

"You can ask," She laughed as he returned her ID--but only because there was no one in line behind her. She wasn't that kind of asshole.

"You're Catra Leandros," The satyr said as he leaned forward a bit conspiratorially. "What on Etheria are you doing at an apartment complex owned by one of Bright Moon's two record companies? N-Not that you can't go wherever you please, mind! But you four have been adamant about staying independent in your mission statement. So please forgive me for being a bit surprised."

Catra smiled. "Just visiting an old friend. So you'll probably be seeing me around a lot more."

The satyr's ears perked up a little. "Um... If it's no big deal, any chance you could sign my copy of you guys' second album? When you come back, I mean, I've held you up long enough."

"Sure thing. Always nice to meet a fan. And hey, with any luck the other three will start coming around too, and I'm sure they wouldn't mind doing the same."

"Even Lonnie? I *love* her death growls."

"Fingers crossed. And she'll be thrilled when I let her know that."

With an ear-to-ear grin he waved her through, and Catra was still smiling to herself after she parked the old van and made her way to the front door of the building. A massive doorman frowned at her approach, probably taking in the ripped jeans and t-shirt/sleeveless hoodie combo, but before he could even say

anything the door swung open and a familiar blonde head popped out behind him. "She's with me, Giles."

"Thanks," Catra said to the doorman as he held open said door for her, before leaning into Adora as they entered the lobby, voice low. "His name is Giles? *Really?"*

Adora laughed, giving Catra a bear hug as she replied. "I know, right? Guy was born to either be a doorman or a butler with a name like that. He's actually pretty cool though; just a major case of active bitch face."

"Well, I'm sure we'll get to know each other soon enough," Catra half-teased as they made their way to the elevator, which Adora ushered her into with a cheesy waist high bow and a flourish for effect. "Anything I need to know in advance about your bandmates?"

Adora hummed thoughtfully as she hit the button for the ninth floor. "Well, Bow's a total sweetheart if a bit of a burn sniper, so you shouldn't have to worry much on that front. As for Glimmer... Just imagine a shorter, more 'fight me' version of Lonnie and adjust your expectations accordingly."

"Oh, this'll be fun. I haven't gotten to hip toss anyone in at least five years."

Adora laughed and even though they both kept their eyes forward to hide their dopey grins, their hands still kept brushing against each other the entire ride up. *Fuck, I could never give this up again.*

They emerged onto the ninth floor, and Catra's ears (and brows) shot up in surprise at the sheer cacophony coming from the first door on the left. It was a garbled mess of electronica music, but the lyrics smothered underneath... Was that a *sea shanty?!*

"When you get on the docks and the long trip is through/Ther's pubs and ther's clubs and ther's lassies there too/When the girls

are all pretty and the beer it is free/And ther's bottles of rum growing from every tree!"

"One sec," Adora groaned, before pounding on the door and shouting. "Sea Hawk! Mermista bought you those headphones for a reason!"

The music cut off, and a surprisingly soft voice called out in the ensuing silence. "My apologies, Miss Adora. It just doesn't compare to really hearing the music in the open, you know?"

"I get that. But next time at least tell your neighbors first so they can prepare. Not everyone appreciates the 'majesty.'"

"Roger that. Sea Hawk out!"

When Adora turned back to her, Catra's eyebrows had taken up an almost permanent residence in her hairline. "Explain."

"Ok, it's really weird and everyone just kind of ignores it because it makes our heads hurt, but Sea Hawk--that has to be a stage name but no one has ever gotten the real one out of him, so I'm terrified by that implication--was actually a fairly popular indie artist before BRM signed him on. Like, *inexplicably* so, but apparently there is just this rabidly loyal niche market that loves to listen to covers of sea shanties in other musical styles? But he somehow always makes a guaranteed profit and his stuff doesn't cost much to produce, so... Yeah."

Catra stared at her. "So let me see if I'm getting this right... They let *him* do whatever he wants but won't give you guys even the slightest bit of artistic leeway?"

Adora could only shrug helplessly in response. "He has his market on lock-down."

"Holy shit, you have *got* to get better managers."

"Oh trust me, I have some things planned for Wednesday's meeting," Adora groused as she nudged Catra towards the door to

BFS's shared apartment. "You ready for this circus?"

A snort. "Adora, I've been a ringmaster for roughly twenty years at this point. Bring it on."

Adora unlocked the door, and as she swung it open Catra's sharp hearing instantly picked up a few whispered hisses.

"I'm telling you, just play it cool. We want her and Adora to spend *more* time together, not avoid this place like the plague!"

"*Excuse you*, I am the *coolest!* Not my fault most people can't handle the resulting freezer burn!"

"Do *not* freezer burn Adora's maybe-probably-girlfriend, Glimmer! I'm *begging* you!"

Catra let out a tiny snort, and quickly clamped her hand around her mouth to stifle a full on laugh. Adora, unable to hear the debate, glanced at her quizzically. Catra just mouthed, "Tell you later" with a toothy grin.

"Hey, we're back," Adora called out to the apartment and immediately the whispers ceased. As they exited the entryway into the living room, Catra almost burst out laughing again at the sight of the other two members of BFS trying to act "natural": i.e. leaning against the side of the couch stiffly with a nervous smile (Bow) or stretched out like a lounge singer atop a piano with an equally nervous smile (Glimmer.) "Real subtle, you two."

"Oh whatever! Subtlety is for the weak and those without style!" Glimmer declared as she hopped to her feet (ignoring Adora's affronted huff) and jogged over. "Hi, Catra. I know we technically met before but you were kinda busy then... So what's up?"

"Sparkles and Rainbow, right?" Catra waited half a second to watch their expressions shift and Glimmer's mouth start to open before laughing and shaking her head. "I'm *kidding.* Glimmer and Bow, drummer and bassist respectively. Good to finally meet you both properly."

Glimmer grinned goblin-like as she shook Catra's hand. "Ooh, you're gonna be a fun one, huh? Been a while since I had a decent challenge. Your girlfriend, bless her heart, is a little too easy to catch off guard with a well-timed burn."

Cackling internally at the sound of Adora choking on her own tongue behind her, Catra drawled, "Well, as long as it's not a *freezer burn* I'll try to live up to your expectations."

Then it was her turn with the devilish grin as the other two choked a little and shared a glance. Bow murmured, "Oh, right: Magicat hearing."

"Great for party tricks," Catra confirmed as she went over to the couch and shook Bow's hand as well. "By the way, your coffee's about to go off."

Three seconds later there was a resounding *ding* of a timer. Point made, Catra sauntered back over to where Adora had been watching with folded arms and great amusement, brushing against her with a cheeky grin and a wink.

"Ok, as much as I'm dying to ask you like a million questions-"

"Especially about Adora's dorky teenage years."

"-we both figured that we'll all have that chance at the party. So I mean, hang out with us here if you want to, but otherwise just relax and enjoy yourselves. Oh, and I'm still taking drink orders. Any alcohol or sodas you prefer?"

"Try to avoid booze if I can. Species quirk. But coke's fine."

"You got it!"

Adora looked over at her with a fond expression, and Catra had to fight down the purr, as well as the urge to bury herself against Adora's shoulder and breathe in that calming scent... At least until they were alone. From what she knew about these two, letting

that particular trait slip was the last thing she needed right now. "Tour and then my room?"

"Why, Adora... How very bold. I thought you'd never ask."

"Leave the door open!" Glimmer called after them, bursting into a raucous cackle when Adora flipped her off over their retreating shoulders.

"Species quirk?" Adora whispered as she dragged Catra down the hall.

Oh right. It was old news to Catra, but twenty one had still been forever away when Catra split. And even for the Fright Zone rebels, sneaking in alcohol had been way beyond their capabilities with Shadow Weaver poking about, so they'd never tried it.

Well... That was awkward.

You're gonna have to stop running away from the tough stuff eventually, Kitten. A lilting voice dripping with smugness whispered from the past.

Practice makes perfect, she thought back, feeling a little rush of confidence when she remembered that night in her apartment three days ago. *And I don't make promises I can't keep.*

So Catra shrugged. "It's basically like humans with mild alcohol allergies. I can drink, but I get hammered unbelievably fast--like a single scotch and coke fast--and it takes longer for my body to metabolize than it would yours. I toed the boundary line pretty hard during the stress of working on our first album, so while I sometimes indulge just for fun I try to avoid drinking otherwise. Was actually part of how I met my therapist."

Adora didn't say anything, just squeezed her hand a little tighter.

Adora's place was actually pretty chill considering three famous pop musicians lived there, though maybe that was to be expected given that the impressive floor space had to be split between four

separate bedrooms; one for each plus a mini-gym. Adora laughed when Catra gave the punching bag a "sincere and earnest apology" for all the grief it had been put through in the past few weeks, grabbing her around the shoulder and ruffling her hair.

After briefly popping their heads into Bow (classy modernist furniture) and Glimmer's (surprising amount of harsh colors and slasher movie posters for someone who dressed like a pastel nightmare) respective rooms just to look, they were alone in Adora's--the woman in question shutting the door behind them with a loud enough noise to set off more cackling from the direction of the living room.

Meanwhile, Catra surveyed the space. Very large desk, at this point overflowing sheet music with a pair of swords crossed over it, garbage can that looked like a massacre at a paper mill (Adora rolled her eyes at Catra's knowing chuckle,) several floor-to-ceiling bookcases--one for music theory, one for cds, and one for everything not covered by those two categories, including a fair collection of books about knights, swords, and knights hitting people with swords--a perpetually messy bed... So far, so Adora.

But what really caught her eye was the corner next to the couch, where a cherrywood and cream colored guitar with a black outline and a very familiar dual hook shape rested on a stand next to a small amp. Catra immediately moved forward and crouched beside it for a better look, tail lashing in excitement. "You finally got a Stratocaster?!"

"Yeah!" Adora practically jumped down beside her, eyes sparkling and talking with her hands the way she always did when she got excited. Any attempt at playing it cool flew straight out the window, and suddenly they were two teenage music freaks again, geeking out over all the things they couldn't afford right now but *someday-!* "Got it after our second album. Bow and Glimmer insisted I use my money to get something I really wanted for once. I think they were hoping for something non-music based, but that one's on them."

"Sweet," Catra reached out with her right hand and ran a finger along the curved line of the body, making certain to retract her claws first and shivering with delight over the smooth finish. "What year is this bad boy?"

"'69. Duh."

Most people would have taken that for a sex joke, but Catra recognized the significance. She nudged up against Adora, and yup, there went the purring. "You sentimental dork."

"You like it."

"Well you're half right."

They took a moment to just enjoy the contact before Adora reached over and tapped the ever-present guitar strapped to Catra's back. "Notice you finally got that Les Paw you were lusting over."

"Hell yeah! No more snapped strings and bleeding fingers for this Magicat! All shredding all the time!"

"What model?"

Catra grinned. "Fire Tiger."

Adora laughed. "Oh my God, and you think *I'm* extra?"

"Aww, don't be like that, sunshine. I think we've both proven by now that there's enough extra in the world for both of us to share."

One light shoving match later, Adora asked, "Quick question, though: if it's made by and for Magicats... Why red?"

Catra paused. "Well, I mean... Just because *we* can't see it doesn't mean we don't know it's a power color to people who can. And half of the showmanship of being a rock star is built on casual power moves and theatrics. Plus it's not like many people outside

us know about the red colorblind thing anyway, so as long as you have someone you trust on hand to make sure no one's fucking with you by setting you up with pink or magenta or something, it's all good."

"Ok, good, because that's been nagging at me. Like, all week."

"I'm a little concerned if that's what's been keeping you up at night."

Their eyes met, and Catra's breath caught at the soft expression on Adora's face, the fond little sigh playing across her lips.

"You know better," She murmured.

W*elp, sorry everybody. I think I'm going down as the first Magicat in history to die from an overdose of the gay. Bury me in a pride flag to the tune of Stevie Nicks and classic Rob Halford-era Judas Priest, and console yourself knowing I died as I lived: completely and utterly* ***wrecked*** *by one Adora Eternia. I am the gay. It's me.*

Even if Adora couldn't hear her internal screaming (though at this point Catra had no idea how) she still seemed amused by it, judging by the smirk she shot Catra's way before reaching out to take her Stratocaster. "Jam session?"

"Yes. Most definitely." *And not just because my heart is trying to vacate my sternum, though that sure is convenient!*

They plugged into both the high and low ports and set the volume down low--since Adora was adamant about being a more considerate neighbor than Sea Hawk--and tuned up. And well... Pun absolutely intended on Catra's part, but it was downright electric knowing they were about to play together again for the first time in too damn long.

"Why don't you start us off?" Adora asked as they finished their prep work. "You lead, and I'll follow."

Damned if that phrasing didn't give Catra the best case of the warm and fuzzies.

"Sure thing," She chuckled in response, strumming for a second to warm up. "So... seeing as we're both so big on musical tradition, I think there's only one proper way to start this off."

Adora took the bait, hook, line and sinker, hand going to the neck of her instrument as she eagerly awaited the starting notes. Internally, Catra laughed.

"Anyway... Here's Wonderw-"

Only to burst out in plain old regular laughter as an affronted Adora tackled her to the floor.

Wednesday, June 6

Adorable

So you still haven't explained what your big plan to one-up Lonnie is.

Catra

Oh, we're well past the planning stage at this point. We're doing this, man. We're making this happen.

Adorable

Details. Now.

Catra

Ok, so Lonnie and I have our perpetual game of one-upmanship on perma lockdown and we're usually pretty evenly matched. But on the off chance that I end up on a losing streak... That's when I pull out my ace in the hole.

Catra

And by that, I mean I choose one of our regular get togethers and do something completely and utterly /ridiculous/ just to remind her who's top cat in this friendship.

Adorable

Oh for the love of Joan Jett, stop dragging the lead out and let me in on the evil plan!

Catra

Basically I'm gonna show up wearing THIS amazing little ensemble.

Adorable

... ...

Adorable

OH MY GOD.

Catra

Right? I figure her eyes will water just looking at me. Or she'll set me on fire. Either way... I win.

Adorable

That is completely diabolical and I love it. Want me to take pictures of her reaction?

Catra

As Grizzlor would put it: "Fuck the hell YES."

Catra

You guys still good with driving me over?

Adorable

Honestly, with that outfit it would be a sin for anything /other/ than Glimmer's neon purple hummer to deliver you there. So yeah, we'll be your chauffeurs.

Adorable

I won't show them the photos or anything, but can I give them the heads up that you're trolling Lonnie? So they at least won't think you're usually a fashion disaster?

Catra

Long as they don't alert Lonnie, sure. Thanks for having my best interests in mind. ;)

Adorable

Always. ;) And believe me, they won't. Apart from doing it herself, Glimmer loves nothing more than witnessing a good troll.

Catra

Oh, this party is going to be /fun/.

Later that afternoon, Adora and Glimmer stepped out of the hummer, shared an exhausted look of "why the hell are we doing this," then squared their shoulders and marched into the lobby of Bright Moon Records. After seven years, no one even bothered to look askance at the two of them wearing hoodies and jeans to the meeting. It was more or less accepted, regardless of how many lectures they received about keeping up proper appearances around the office.

Yeah right. Pop stars already know plenty about keeping up "appearances."

It was with that bitter thought ringing in Adora's head that the pair exited the elevator on the twelfth floor and marched into the conference room where their manager of the day out of a group of three or four--a guy named Sibor--was pouring over the sheet music and notes they had forwarded to him a few hours previously, immediately prior to losing some time arguing over whether or not they could get away with adding a whiskey chaser to their coffees (Adora and reason prevailed on that one, but it had been a close call.)

They each remained standing, waiting for Sibor to acknowledge them. He was one of those guys who always wanted his musicians to be the ones to crack first, acknowledge his authority, however petty. Adora could be petty, too, so she started humming the bars of No Plan B's last single and waited for him to catch on.

Like any good market analyst, it didn't take long. (Though of course he'd probably forget the song entirely once a new trend appeared to chase.) Pushing his desk chair back, not even bothering to greet them, he glanced at Adora. "Well, I guess I don't have to ask where the sudden change in styles came from. But chasing a flash-in-the-pan hard rock group's thunder? Not your smartest move, Miss Eternia."

Oh it is <u>on</u> now. Adora smiled, ignoring the tic in her cheek as she replied, "Maybe if you bothered to actually remember my work past the ten seconds it takes to tell me to ruin it, you'd recognize that this isn't new. I take it you're not happy with the revisions?"

"You knew coming in here I wouldn't be," Sibor growled, turning his laptop towards them and highlighting bits of the sheet music. "My colleagues and I asked you to simplify the compositions to better match your target audience, not make them even *more* complex. At the rate you three are going, you're straddling genres enough as is. Soon you'll make the leap from pop entirely and alienate the majority of your fanbase."

"Would that really be such a bad thing?" Glimmer asked, sharing a look with Adora as she laid one hand on the desk. "We've been

stagnating artistically for years because you guys keep insisting that we chase market trends. Even our diehard fans can tell we've been phoning it in. They want us to be genuine with our art. They want some actual passion from our music. Not some cookie cutter garbage."

"Not to mention the bulk of our audience has grown up," Adora added. "They want songs that will speak to their experience, not watered down bullshit."

"Well, I can assure you, ladies," Sibor snorted, leaning back in his chair. "You two may know music, but *I* know the music industry. And what you're doing here is setting yourself up for failure."

"What are we, chopped liver? We've been doing this for nearly a decade now, and I grew up being prepared for every aspect of this job. We know the industry too, and as long as we're all being honest, we probably have a better measure of it than you. Because we actually bother to look at it outside the profit margins."

Next to her, Glimmer barely choked back on the declaration of, "Shots fired!"

"I understand that with a group like No Plan B making headlines right now," He responded, saying the name like a hiss. "You may be getting some... ideas. But they're going to find that when they do fail--and they will eventually--not having financial backup will be the end of them. What they've done so far is pure luck, nothing more."

"It's skill and dedication," Adora declared hotly, thoroughly done with this entire conversation. "And you're just pissed off that No Plan B is selling better than anything *you've* managed in the past decade."

Silence; Sibor, who had never gotten a true look at Adora's temper, staring at her like she'd grown a second head. Adora didn't care one bit.

"Now now, Miss Eternia," Sibor started, but Adora had spent enough time around that too soft tone to ever fall for it again, and she'd learned that distinction from a better actor than him. "I feel I should remind you of something: you work for me."

Adora blinked, pausing for a long moment as that statement processed. She shared a quick look with Glimmer, whose mouth was slightly open, a mutual moment of "Did he really just go there?" shared between them before Glimmer's resulting smile turned outright dangerous; sugary sweet on the surface but knife-edge sharp when combined with the sudden set of her shoulders and the angry glint in her eyes.

"And do you happen to remember who you work for, Sibor?" She asked sweetly.

He paused, paled, and Adora could see him trying to backpedal in his mind, but she was already 110% done. *Screw playing it nice and waiting for leverage, screw accusations of nepotism and especially screw this entire conversation. This has gone on long enough.*

"Glimmer," She said, making sure to keep her eyes locked on Sibor so he fully understood the line he had just drawn. "I've had enough of this. I'm calling it. Omega six."

"We're finally going there?" Glimmer asked, just to make sure, even after they'd talked about it so many times while complaining late at night about the shackles Sibor and their other managers had stuck them in. All the code names and contingency plans they'd come up with to try and finally carve out some wiggle room for themselves before they suffocated.

"Yeah. I'm done pretending we'll get there by playing along and being nice. Time to force the issue."

"What's an omega six?" Sibor asked, eyes wide as saucers.

Ignoring him, Glimmer pulled her phone out of her pocket and hit speed dial. There was a few moments of soft ringing next to her

ear before someone picked up. "Hey Avara. Can you patch me on through? No, I wouldn't be calling this number just to chat. This is important. Uh-huh. Thanks."

Adora watched as the name hit Sibor like a brick to the face and comprehension settled in. *You really picked the wrong group to pull the boss card with, you smug asshole.*

"Hello, mom?" Glimmer said, projecting her voice as she prepared to put the final nail in Sibor's coffin. "We'd like to talk business. How does two weeks from now look for you?"

Adora

So... Remember that talk we had about how I needed a better manager?

Catra <3

Duh.

Wait...

Are you saying what I think you are?

Adora

Got a meeting with Glimmer's mom next Friday. She had to agree to come home for the solstice and bring me and Bow with, but we got the meeting.

Catra <3

Adora, that's freaking INCREDIBLE!

Man, I can't wait to hear what you guys can do with the kid gloves off. It's gonna be so awesome!

Catra <3

Hope it's something closer to your last single.

Adora

Wait... You listened to it? I thought you weren't a fan of pop music.

Catra <3

I'm not.

Adora

... ...

Catra <3

;3

Adora

!!!!!!

Adora

Smooth...

Catra <3

Heh. You know it.

Catra <3

<3

The day of the pool party arrived, and between preparing for the upcoming meeting with Angella and the excitement of seeing Catra, Adora could feel herself *buzzing* with anticipation.

"Ok," She smirked wickedly from the backseat of the Hummer, glad that neither of the other two could see her face. "So Catra is letting me give you guys the context that her outfit today is for the express purpose of trolling Lonnie to reassert dominance, not how she usually dresses. So just keep that in mind when you see her, okay?"

"Ok, sure," Bow chuckled from the driver's seat (Glimmer's price this time had been five pounds of hot dogs and a ribeye steak. Only one of these two would be shared with the group.) "How bad can it be?"

You have no idea.

Of course, Adora conceded with a smug grin as they pulled up to the curb outside Catra's apartment building and caught sight of the Magicat standing cool as a cucumber on the sidewalk, they probably knew that *now.*

Because Catra was wearing her usual fingerless gloves, a pair of bright orange board shorts, a bright green tank top with a picture of a sunglasses wearing cat and the words "Check Meowt" printed on it, a purple and blue gradient Salinean overshirt, and a pair of bright yellow *shutter shades*. And just to top it all off, she had apparently scrounged up a pair of neon green flip-flops from somewhere (possibly hell) to finish off this absolute train wreck of an outfit.

It was completely and utterly ludicrous, and the thing that brought it all home was the arrogant smirk that told everyone unfortunate enough to be witnessing that this no-holds barred assault on the senses was one hundred percent *intentional.*

(The funny thing was, that smirk--that aura of absolute *confidence*--almost made the outfit work. Right along the line. But then again, Adora was--in all likelihood--horrendously biased.)

"Oh. My. *God!*" Glimmer managed to choke out between desperate laughter and gasping for air, thumping the truck door

for emphasis. "Holy crap, Adora, if by some miracle you don't marry this girl someday, *I* will. Because I think I'm in love."

"Keep it in your own lane, Glim," Adora replied, grinning from ear to ear even as a pleased blush crept up the back of her neck. "Bro Code of 'Dibs' in effect here."

Glimmer gave her a thumbs up, wiping tears from her eyes.

"Wow," Bow said as he recovered from his own laugh attack and unlocked the doors for Catra to climb in, handing off her guitar to Adora as she went. "Just wow. I will never doubt your warnings ever again. Wow."

"'Sup?" Catra asked, glancing at the two of them over the top of her shades. "You guys ready to get this party started? Because I'm not leaving until I hear Lonnie beg for mercy."

"Heck yeah!"

"Hell yes!"

Adora just replied by reaching over and running her fingertips through the exposed fur along Catra's left forearm, idly playing with the silky smooth strands. Catra let her, and Adora smiled when she felt the familiar brush of a tail moving across the small of her back in return.

Catra watched with utter glee as the light in Lonnie's eyes *died* when the foursome entered the backyard through the unlocked side gate--Adora and Bow hauling the cooler between them, Glimmer now tapped as designated camera operator and treating the whole thing like a red carpet photo shoot--and rolled on up. "Cat got your tongue, Lon?"

Lonnie opened her mouth, closed it, then opened it again. "Ok, yeah. I deserve this. I accept this punishment."

"I don't know what you mean," Catra smirked as she went to hug the other members of the group in greeting--accepting a surreptitious 'Nice one' and a fistbump from Rogelio with Scorpia's bulk blocking Lonnie's line of sight to the bassist. "Why would I *ever* want to punish my very best friend?"

Lonnie groaned in abject misery and dragged her hands down her face. "I'm not sure I need enemies with a friend like you. You win this round, furball."

"Music to my ears," Catra grinned smugly, popping the collar on her overshirt just because she could, before making her way to the enormous rectangular stone table set up next to the pool. Scorpia's family was old money--old as in industrialist old--and while her moms tried to be humble with only a moderately sized mansion (still a mansion, though, because the family tree was ridiculously huge and nearly everyone in it was expected to host a Taranis family reunion at some point in their lives)... Well, there was only so much you could downplay that kinda thing.

Settling in one of the chairs, she surveyed the scene. No one was in the water yet, mostly just doing the prep work so they could all relax together. Rogelio was over by the grill getting it nice and ready while marinating a few steaks, grinning big and giving Glimmer a one-armed shoulder hug when she passed over her own contributions to the feast. Kyle was helping him out, as well as staying on stand-by to translate for the two party members that didn't read sign.

Lonnie and Scorpia were busy removing detritus from the pool with a pair of skimmers (there were several large oak trees on the perimeter of the yard, great for privacy but bad for cleanup). Adora and Bow had wrangled the cooler onto the far end of table and were currently occupied with passing out drinks.

All in all, there wasn't a whole lot for Catra to do, but for the moment she was okay with that as Adora tossed her a soda and a bottle of water. She just kicked back and enjoyed the light breeze

running through her fur, letting her mind wander for just a little while.

"All right, guys," Lonnie declared with a big grin a few minutes later with the prep work done and everybody gathered around the table, Bow and Glimmer sat down at the head, with Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio on one side and Scorpia, Adora and Catra on the other. (Catra had graciously thrown Lonnie a bone and discarded her initial plan of grabbing the seat opposite and forcing her to avoid looking at her; instead opting to let her look at Scorpia decked out very prettily in a floral dress and sunhat, making the rest of them look like slobs in comparison.)

"Since we got new people here, let's go over the general rules of a No Plan B get together. Rogelio and Kyle get first run of the pool because Rogelio can't be in cold water for very long and he'll be busy cooking after. At least one of us needs to keep an eye on the grill at all times. We do *not* want a repeat of last year's midsummer solstice incident."

Every member of No Plan B fought down a collective shudder; BFS just looked at each other, bemused.

"But unless you're on active grill watch, do whatever the hell you want. Go for a dip, chill in the sun, drink yourself silly--just not in the pool, safety first... Whatever. It's a party."

"Oh!" Scorpia cut in, clapping her claws together. "What about the Questions?"

"Oh, right!" Lonnie grinned, turning to Bow and Glimmer. "Usually we start off by just chilling together and shootin' the breeze. But when we first started out as a group, we would always play a round of modified Questions, partly as a team building thing and partly because it's really hilarious to pull out something like 'what's the dumbest thing you ever did while wasted' and watch the squirming. Since you two are the ones getting to know the rest of us most--Adora's just playing catch-up--it's only fair you

get first go. Just ask any question and we'll go around the table with our answers."

"Well, you kinda put me on the spot," Bow said with a chuckle, rubbing the back of his neck. "So I guess I'll just go with a basic ice breaker question. Favorite color?"

"Really? Bow, that's terrible," Glimmer cut in before anyone could even think of answering, jabbing him with her elbow with a cheeky grin. "Let me show you how you get to the *real* deep truth of someone."

Turning to the rest of the group, she cracked her knuckles and waggled her eyebrows in dramatic fashion. "No judgment if the answer is no, but here it is: have you ever done weed, and if so what are you like when you're high?"

Oh no... Catra was suddenly really glad her fur was usually thick enough to hide her blush from a distance.

"Really, Glim?" Adora laughed from beside Catra. "That's your 'deep truth'?"

"Can you think of a better way to get to know who someone is deep down, without all those inhibitions and morals clouding them?"

"Yeah, it's called air hockey."

"And that's exactly why you two are banned from nearly every arcade in the city," Bow replied with a disapproving headshake.

"Yeah, and you're the one who won't let us buy our own table. So you signed yourself up to be the mom friend this time. But whatever, the question still stands. Go!"

"Meh, nothing to really write home about," Lonnie shrugged. "Mostly just standard mellowing out for me."

"I'll smoke a joint on occasion when I'm having a really anxious day, though I try not to make it a habit," Kyle admitted, taking a quick sip of his sprite. "Mostly it just lets me focus without all that internal stuff getting to me. Rogelio gets the mega munchies. He can tear his way through all the chips in the house if we're not careful."

The man in question nodded stoically.

"I don't really have anything against it," Scorpia contributed while she adjusted her sunhat. "Just not my cup of tea, you know? So usually I just supervise and make sure things don't get outta hand. That can be pretty amusing if more than one of them is in on it."

Which left...

"What about you, Catra?"

Catra groaned internally, but as she opened her mouth to reply she was cut off by a chorus of "No!" from the others followed by a resounding, "Never *fucking* again!" from *Kyle.*

"Whoa," Adora drawled, glancing around with wide eyes before turning to Catra, who took the opportunity to bury her face in her hands and let the groan slip out. "What happened?"

"Oof," Lonnie grimaced, rubbing the back of her neck. "Not trying to drag you, furball, but you know the rules. Question must be answered truthfully. Ok, so after we finished recording our first album we all decided to give getting high together a shot, just for shits and giggles and to relax a little after all that stress. And for a while it was pretty okay. Catra just kinda bonelessly draped herself across every available surface. Back of the couch, tables, Scorpia's shoulders-"

"She chewed on my hair at one point."

"I was hungry," Catra mumbled, face still buried in her hands in spite of the choked snort coming from Glimmer's end of the table

and the minor shaking of repressed giggles from Adora beside her.

"Yeah, she did that too," Lonnie conceded. "Then her switch flipped and she was got really weepy for a bit and none of us could get her to explain why."

'Which is just kinda par for the course with Catra.'

"Hey!"

"Right, right. But the big reason is that immediately after that, she entered into that weird state of clarity where things that would ordinarily upset you don't seem like a big deal? When you just kinda check out from emotions, good or bad? So the result is she starts rattling off all these really fucked up stories from her childhood and quickly reduces half of the group to inconsolable sobbing in a cuddle puddle on the floor."

Silence descended and Catra felt the back of her neck burning with embarrassment even as Adora reached over and scratched at her ears, all previous levity suddenly vanished as her other hand squeezed Catra's under the table.

But Glimmer, not understanding what that actually *meant,* just gave a half stunned, "Holy shit. What happened to the other half of the group?"

"Well, from what I remember, Scorpia and I tried to use google to hire a hitman," Kyle admitted with a confused expression. "But all I found in my search history the next morning was 'ghosts based on gays' and I have no idea what that was supposed to mean."

Coughing loudly to slide over the obvious implication that she and Rogelio had been the ones bawling their eyes out, Lonnie said, "So yeah, we really should have researched that one a bit better. Turns out a normal amount of weed for a human is like a quadruple dose for a Magicat, so once we all came down we more or less just agreed that Catra should never do weed again. Ever."

"It was my decision overall and I'm fine with it," Catra muttered while she finally lowered her arms now that the embarrassing part was over, catching Adora's reassuring smile as she left off on the ear scritching. "And it is kinda funny in hindsight."

"Now, *catnip*-Catra," Scorpia suddenly burst out in an excited grin. *"There's* a fun time!"

"She can do *catnip?!"*

"Oh man, she gets super cuddly! It's great! It's like all the fun bits of weed Catra with none of the crying!"

Never mind. She was officially in hell. *Time to pull out the <u>other</u> ace up my sleeve.*

Faux-casually propping her chin on one hand and glancing over the top of her shades, she declared, "I'll take my turn for questions. Who wants to hear how Lonnie screwed up three and a half times at asking Scorpia out, then got completely shit-faced and punched a tree while trying to impress her?"

All three members of BFS shot their hands in the air (along with a grinning Rogelio and Kyle) while Lonnie just stared at Catra with an expression of utter betrayal. "I cannot believe my own furry sister would do this to me. We've bled together, man!"

"Payback~" Catra trilled with a wink.

"How do you mess up three and a *half* confessions?" Adora asked eagerly, nothing short of delight dancing in her eyes.

Lonnie groaned miserably, and Scorpia reached across the table and patted her on the shoulder while she answered instead. "Well, Catra had to drive us to the ER, but I still said yes once she sobered up enough to understand Etherian again."

'In all fairness to Lonnie,' Rogelio signed with a smirk to every party except Glimmer, who was too busy cackling with her head

tossed back. *'It was her first time drinking tequila. So in hindsight that was probably a mistake on everyone's part.'*

"As was downing an entire third of the bottle," Kyle chipped in with a far too casual shrug that did nothing to hide the smirk crooking the corner of his mouth.

"Never again," Lonnie mumbled down at the table. "I thought I had gone blind when I woke up the next morning."

"And then you spent the next twelve hours groaning on our couch while cuddled up with your new gf watching romcoms," Catra pointed out. "So tequila aversion aside, I think you came out of that pretty ahead."

Catching Adora's questioning look, she added, "Scorpia and I were roommates until she and Lonnie started to get too disgustingly domestic for me to handle."

"Oh c'mon, furball. I know you miss some things about living with us."

"Apart from increased access to our cat and Scorpia's *huevos rancheros?* Hmm... Nope, can't think of anything."

Lonnie flipped her off with a grumble. Grinning, Adora teased, "You know, you spent so many years making fun of the rest of us for being useless gays. Can't help but feel like this is karma."

"No, karma was putting up with Catra pining over your ass for seven excruitatingly long years. If fifteen year old me had known what she was in for she would have kept her damn mouth shut."

"Aww, Lonnie," Catra cooed. "Aren't you at least happy the suffering's ended?"

"My suffering will only end when you stop looking like the dumpster behind a Salineas surf shop. That's been lit on fire. On *fire,* Catra."

The laughter bubbled up in Catra's chest and she nipped the inside of her lip to try to keep it together. And she mostly succeeded... For the one and a half seconds until Adora broke first, laughs pouring out as she grabbed at the sleeve of Catra's hideous shirt, and that was all it took for her to join in.

After about thirty more minutes of talking and coaxing ridiculous stories out of each other followed by another twenty of guarding the grill while Rogelio swam laps across the pool with Kyle clinging to his shoulders ("It's to help with his endurance training!" "Uh-huh. Sure, Kyle.") Adora was finally free to do as she pleased.

Taking a moment to stretch, she took stock of where everyone was: Rogelio and Kyle drying off and getting ready to cook, Bow and Glimmer engaged in a pool noodle battle on the lawn (tempting), Lonnie floating on her back in the pool while Scorpia applied some fresh sunscreen before going back in... And of course, Adora's target: currently sprawled out on a chaise lounge with one leg on and the other tapping a slow rhythm on the concrete with those hideous flip flops. Catra's tail waved back and forth sedately as she basked in the sun, even having stripped off the overshirt so she could enjoy the feel of it on her shoulders.

She looked so relaxed that Adora almost felt bad that she was about to ruin it.

Almost.

Because Catra wasn't the only one capable of diabolical schemes. Ten years was a long time, after all, and even if Adora had only entered the dating pool in very brief interludes before deciding to focus on her career and therapy instead, she'd still made a few improvements to certain skills since she was eighteen.

For example... flirting.

And even if she'd accepted that Catra had genuinely had good reasons for leaving and was working through the hurt feelings,

that didn't mean she couldn't benefit from surprising her with that increased knowledge. *Time to give her a taste of what she's been missing out on.*

Adora had planned this carefully: picking out a pair of khaki swim trunks that cut off mid-thigh and a short sleeved red jacket zipped up over a sports bikini top. So far, so good; the short sleeves exposed her forearms and some of her biceps, and she'd been pleased to note how frequently Catra's eyes had wandered over in that direction all afternoon.

All very nice. But also a very good smokescreen for what Adora really had up her sleeve.

Shucking her own flip flops, she moved over to the edge of the pool and called out to its occupant. "Heads up, Lonnie. You're probably gonna wanna move."

Lonnie opened her eyes and bobbed her head out of the water, and beyond her on the other side of the pool Catra's ears pricked up. "You comin' in?"

"Yeah, just give me a sec."

So saying, she pulled down the zipper and shrugged out of the jacket in one smooth motion, tossing it back over her shoulder toward her shoes and exposing the results of roughly eight years of regular intensive ab exercises. As she got ready to jump, her ears, although nowhere near as sharp as a Magicat's, picked up on the distinct screech of claws scraping reflexively across the metal frame of a deck chair.

Even Lonnie whisper-shouted, "Holy shit," as she hastened to make way before Adora hit the water at a run, jackknifing through and starting a few laps. Yup. Ten years on and Adora was happy to say she knew *exactly* what she was doing.

When she felt she'd made her point and her lungs started to burn, she popped up at the edge of the pool opposite of where Catra

sat, brushing the wet hair out of her face to make it less obvious she was watching the other woman out of the corner of her eyes.

Catra, meanwhile, currently looked like her tail had been stuck in an electrical socket, and Adora couldn't help a small chuckle at the memory of her pouring water over herself at the concert. *Turnabout's fair play, babe.*

"You are *evil,"* Lonnie smirked as she swam up next to Adora. "And I approve. I knew you were working out, girl, but damn."

"Helps with the anger," Adora replied with a smug grin.

"Bet it helps with other things too."

"I have no idea what you mean."

"Well there's about fifty jokes I could make about us not being the only ones who're wet right now, but I'll abstain out of respect for your weird little courtship rituals."

Adora flushed, still smirking. "Not sure if you pointing out the punchline counts as abstaining, but I appreciate the attempt."

Catra had by now smoothed out her fur and seemed dedicated to shotgunning her entire water bottle. Victory was *sweet.*

"Hey," Lonnie put a hand on Adora's shoulder. "Can I ask you something serious real quick while I've got you? One old friend to another."

Adora blinked, taken aback by the sudden change in mood. "Of course."

"Cool," She smiled reassuringly, taking a deep breath. "Why'd you drop off? You did okay keeping in touch with me and the boys for the first few years, but then..."

Oh. Yeah.

"Sorry," Adora sighed heavily, giving a short jerk of her head in Catra's direction. "Pretty similar reasons actually. I was dealing with a lot of rough stuff back in college, lot of anger and confusion and all that, and you three seemed to be doing pretty okay for yourselves."

Lonnie snorted. "Yeah, if you call working construction because you can't find a decent gig 'okay.'"

"I know that now, but you were still a lot better put together than I was at the time. It's just that after a while, it became harder and harder to ignore the elephant in the room whenever we talked. What was missing."

"Yeah," Lonnie softened. "Yeah, I get that."

"And by the time I started going to therapy and dealing with all that, I just didn't know what to say or how to reach out again. I *am* sorry, though. I fucked up."

"You did," Lonnie agreed, but then she punched Adora's bicep playfully. "You're just lucky hanging with you is a lot more fun than holding grudges. Good to have you back, you big, overthinking dumbass."

"Thanks," Adora smiled, warmth burning in her chest despite the freezing water. "Feels good to be back."

"Room for one more?"

Cracking one eye opened, Catra's tail involuntarily gave an excited thump to see Adora standing over her with her jacket back on (unzipped though. *Nice*) and a towel draped around her shoulders, two bottles of water dangling between her fingers.

"That depends... One of those bottles for me?"

"Yup."

"Then by all means..." She wiggled over so Adora could perch at the head of the chaise lounge, bumping her shoulder with her head to get her to loosen up. Adora laughed and settled back more fully against the backrest, one hand tugging lightly at Catra's shoulder blade until she had her settled back against that grey area of hip and leg.

It was a little uncomfortable and both of her legs slipped off the lounge and had to be planted firmly on the concreted and the smell of chlorine made her nose wrinkle something fierce, but Catra wouldn't have traded the moment for anything.

"This's nice..." She mumbled contentedly as Adora gave a little "Mhmm" in response and started carding her fingers through Catra's mane.

A pair of voices on the other side of the pool adjacent to the grill cut into the serenity of her thoughts.

"Oh my God... Were they always this disgustingly *physical* with each other?"

"Yup."

"Even though they weren't even officially dating?"

"Ohhhh yeah. Feel my pain."

"Wait... Are they dating?"

A snort. "Who can even tell? Just let them do the weird courtship dance. I can guarantee we won't even be able to tell the difference in the end, at least in the moments they aren't sloppily making out on every available surface."

Catra perked up and shouted across the yard, "Get bent, Lonnie!"

The woman in question pointed an accusatory finger in Catra's direction (the effect only ruined slightly by the beer also in said hand.) *"Bitch,* I don't have to! This entire social circle is about as

straight as a Plumerian rainbow explosion and you're the most crooked one of the bunch!"

"Well then stop being a wuss and *get on my level!* Oh, and just so Glimmer knows who she's dealing with: sloppy makeouts on every available surface are the reason why I live alone now, ya hypocrite!"

Lonnie responded by glaring at Catra over the top of her shades before downing her beer, Glimmer following suit with a finger gun and an unrepentant wink.

Catra chuckled a little as she let Adora draw her back to her original position. "Best friends, huh?"

"They're the absolute worst," Adora agreed, starting to pet at Catra's ears and ignoring the sound of Glimmer exaggeratedly gagging in the distance. "But they can be useful sometimes."

After all. They brought you back to me.

A jet engine rumble started up in Catra's chest. "Heh. I'll drink to that sometime."

Everything was quiet for a bit while the rest of the party did their own thing, Glimmer and Lonnie eventually hitting the pool with their respective best friend/SO and starting three complete rounds of chicken fighting (2-1, Team Scorpia/Lonnie) before the noise settled down. In the distance she could hear the noise of Rogelio flipping the steaks and preparing to lay down the hot dogs now that they were mostly done, Kyle throwing out suggestions for their next date night.

And through it all, as ever, the sound of Adora humming under her breath to the steady cadence of Catra's purrs.

Her ears pricked up as a raucous splash echoed across the yard, glancing up.

Over in the water, Bow emerged with a laugh from Glimmer cannonballing into the pool beside him and burying him beneath a huge wave. Spotting Catra's attention, he tread water over to the side and called, "Hey, Catra! You coming in or what?'

"Nah, I'm cool where I am. I don't swim."

"Want me to teach you?"

Catra had to chuckle a little at his eagerness. "No, I *can* swim just fine. I just don't."

At this point, Glimmer dog-paddled over to join Bow, propping her elbows on the lip of the pool. "Um... Is it ok if I ask what might be an insensitive question?"

Catra raised an eyebrow, sharing a quick glance overhead with Adora. "I mean, I reserve the right to not answer and to tell you if it is, but sure."

"Ok. Like, I tried to look up more on Magicat culture online but it was really hard to find anything actually written by actual Magicats and not by outsiders, so sorry if I say or ask anything offensive and please call me out if I do. But you seemed cool with Spinnerella asking questions on the interview-"

"Sparkles," Catra cut her off with a laugh and a head shake, pushing herself up on her elbows. "I said I'm cool with it. Just ask your question already."

"Ok..." Glimmer paused to breathe in the aftermath of her rambling. "Is not liking water a Magicat thing? Like if I ask a Magicat to come swimming with me am I being an insensitive asshole?"

"No," Catra answered calmly. "Magicats are just fine with water. We even have some pretty good swimmers, though we haven't gotten anyone into the Olympics just yet because the fur creates a lot of drag and not a whole lot of us wanna shave down just for that. And I mean yeah, it takes some extra effort to fully dry off

compared to humans or even most other hybrids, but most of us are used to that because it's just life. So no, asking a Magicat to swim doesn't make you an asshole. That's just a me thing."

"Cool. Thanks!”

"Um..." Bow said. "Totally fine if you don't or if it's a touchy subject, but do you wanna talk about it?"

Catra reflexively drew in a sharp breath, sitting fully upright on the chaise lounge and removing her shades so she could look them dead in eyes. She paused, drumming her fingers on the plastic slats proper before coming to her decision. "Ok, look. I wanna make it clear that I'm saying this because *I* want to, not to make you guys feel bad or force myself or anything. I accepted what happened a long time ago. *Capisce?"*

They both nodded, crossing a finger over their hearts.

"Good," Catra smiled a little when she felt Adora's hand reach out and cover hers from where it was resting out of sight behind her thigh. "Like, obviously since I was at school with these guys I was an orphan. My parents died in a car wreck when I was a little under five. Eighteen wheeler slammed us into a river."

"Us?" Bow squeaked.

"Yeah," Catra admitted with a deep breath to steady herself. Even if she had accepted it, the memory of that night was still a deep wound across her mind, one that would never fully stop hurting on the rare occasions she felt like poking it. "I was the only one who made it out alive."

A moment of silence. Then Glimmer muttered, "Jesus. I'm *sorry."* (Bow, meanwhile, looked about two seconds away from starting to cry.)

"Appreciate it. But like I said, I accepted it for what it was a long time ago. I just can't help that visceral response I get when I see a body of water bigger than a bathtub," She chuckled to break the

tension. "But I promise I'm good with hanging over here, so as long as you don't try to toss me in the pool I'll be just fine."

"I SAID I WAS *SORRY!"* Scorpia shouted from across the other side where she and Lonnie had been floating in the shallow end.

"AND I *FORGAVE* YOU! JUST DON'T DO IT AGAIN!" Catra cupped her hands around her mouth and hollered back. Catching Adora's expression--somewhere between amused at the exchange and absolutely livid--she quickly elaborated, "Scorpia didn't know about my phobia at the time, and Rogelio and Kyle managed to tackle her before she could actually throw me in, so it was all right in the end. She was *very* apologetic after I stopped breathing heavy and Lonnie explained what was up. She made fish for dinner for about a week until I finally convinced her I wasn't upset."

Adora breathed a sigh of relief, looking satisfied by the explanation. That managed to bring some levity back, everybody chuckling at the protective exchange. But then...

"Catra?" Glimmer bit her lip.

"What's up?"

"The car wreck. Um... Is that where the scars came from?"

Catra's thoughts scattered like bowling pins beneath a strike, ears going back and her tail fluffing up as she fought to keep the shudder from running through her entire body. Around her, every other ex-Fright Zone member tensed up in unison, turning slightly to watch her without making it too obvious that was what they were doing. Just in case.

Especially Adora, her thumb swiping across the back of Catra's hand, grounding her.

Shit. She'd been so excited to spend time with Adora and the others that she'd completely forgotten not everyone here was from the Fright Zone when she took off the overshirt.

Nor did she think about one particularly obvious scar, a jagged line that arched over the junction of her neck and shoulder down toward the collarbone; a remnant from a sloppy strike when Shadow Weaver's belt actually broke one day after years and years of use. There were more marks dancing along the line of her shoulders just below her neck, but seeing those could be avoided if Catra never turned her back.

The other one? In a tank top it was nearly impossible to hide.

Breathe in. Five seconds. Hold... Eight seconds out.

"No." She said it simply, making it clear this was *not* up for further discussion. "Those are battle scars."

Then she hopped to her feet, stalking across the lawn before leaping up into one of the trees and disappearing from view amongst the leaves. Finding a good place about halfway up, she stretched out her legs and settled back against the trunk and just... let the feelings run their course.

"Oh crap! I'm so sorry," Glimmer's voice, heavy with well-meaning concern. "I... Ugh, crap, I know I don't even *need* to ask if I fucked that one up. I just-! I...!"

She gave a frustrated snarl, like the words just weren't coming out the way she wanted.

"Nah, you're good. You just caught her off guard," Lonnie assured her. *Always good in a pinch there, Lon.* "Just give her a little time to breathe. She'll come back down when she's finished processing, and everything'll be cool again. Be prepared to get dragged, though. It's how Catra reestablishes dominance."

"That's totally fair," She replied, then raised her voice. "I am sorry though, Catra, and I promise I won't ask any more touchy questions for the rest of the party. Okay?"

A furry hand stuck itself out from the foliage and gave a thumbs up before retreating back into the green.

Folding her arms back behind her head, Catra focused on her breathing and let the old feelings run through her. The anger, the shame. The pain. The desperate wanting to hide herself away from it all, to never come back out again.

But she wasn't hiding. Even if it was still hard, even if talking about it every so often still felt like pulling teeth, even if there were still some moments where she literally *couldn't* talk about it because opening her mouth would be a one-way invitation to screaming herself hoarse... She was doing better. She was *getting* better.

A rustle below her, and she glanced down to see a familiar blonde head likewise settling down beneath the canopy. But Adora didn't make any effort to engage or get Catra to talk. She just sat there patiently, letting Catra know she was there if she needed it.

That alone was more reassuring than anything anyone else could have done.

Catra dug in her pocket for her cellphone.

Catra <3

Hey Adora.

Adora grinned and had to stifle the urge to glance upward.

Adora

Hey yourself.

Catra <3

Not trying to hover when you could be enjoying the party, are ya? ;3

Adora

Nah. I trust Lonnie enough to believe her when she says you're just processing things. I'm hanging because I want to. Plus I needed a break anyway.

Adora paused, not sure if she wanted to approach the tricky subject. She pressed send anyway.

Adora

Though I will admit to being a little worried. You, uh... You never did talk much about what happened to your parents back in the Fright Zone. I just figured it wasn't a safe topic after that stunt Octavia pulled.

A sharp inhale overhead.

They were coming back from class together after spending some additional time with Grizzlor discussing the latest routine the group was running through, so for the most part the hall was empty and blessedly quiet. Not all the way, though.

"Well, look who it is. The mongrel mouser and her little master."

Beside her, Catra's jaw clenched and she drew in a ragged breath and held it before spitting, "What do you want, Octavia?"

Unlike the other adults around, Octavia wasn't even a musician; she was the main security guard and part time groundskeeper of the Fright Zone. But in practice that just meant that she didn't even have to pretend to be non-antagonistic and could just spend most of her free time bullying the "problem" students.

Needless to say, her and Shadow Weaver were tight.

"Oh, nothing much. Just heard something very interesting from the boss lady herself about my favorite stray."

Adora ground down with her teeth, surreptitiously cracking the knuckles of her right hand--i.e. the punching one--against her thigh. Trying to remember what Catra had said about Octavia

before: "Look, we can pull off knocking down any number of piss-ant teachers. Nobody gives a shit about that. But going up against her is a bad idea, since she has a direct line to Shadow Weaver. Just ignore the taunting."

"Right... Because Weaver knows me so very well," Catra deadpanned.

"Aw, don't you have any faith in me, pussy-Catra?" Chuckling at her own stupid joke, she leaned over the two of them, grinning nastily down at Catra with her predator's teeth. "It's just kinda funny, you know? Maybe if your parents had put you in a sack like they should have, then you would have drowned like all unwanted pets. Save me the trouble of dealing with you."

Catra's face went totally blank, eyes widening as she stared up at the guard... Before twisting just as suddenly into pure, unadulterated rage. Before Adora could react or even think to stop her (not that she would at this point because what the hell?) she let out a roar and brought her claws up--right across Octavia's dumb, smug face.

Octavia bellowed, one brawny arm lashing out and catching Catra across the face, knocking her aside. Catra let out a hard yelp, but still managed to land on her feet while Octavia continued to flail about and Adora rushed to her side, one arm steadying her while she glared daggers at the woman who had just hurt her best-everything.

"Let that be a lesson to you, you sushi-faced bitch!" Grinning ferally, Catra spat blood (oh God, was that part of a tooth) and cuffed the remnants away from her lips before roaring again. "I'm no stray, I'm a goddamn Magicat! And if you ever talk about my parents again I'll fucking eat you alive!"

There had been some serious repercussions of the Shadow Weaver kind after that, but in all their time at the Fright Zone that was the one beating that Catra never classified as anything but, "Worth it." And Octavia never came near them again.

Catra <3

Yeah... I still have no idea how she found out about that, other than picturing her and Weaver having some kind of weekly tea and torture appreciation session. It'd almost be funny if you imagine saucers and doilies and all that fancy shit. And if they weren't both terrible people.

Ok, Adora was a big enough person to admit to snickering at that one, even if it was liberally dunked in bitterness.

Catra <3

Like duh, orphan, but I don't even know if those details were in my file or not. Even for the Fright Zone, that would be weird. And let's face it: Octavia wasn't nearly smart enough to dig up that kind of info on her own, even if it was for the purposes of harassing me.

Put one more tally mark in the 'Keep Calm and Fucking Hate Shadow Weaver' column, Adora thought.

Catra <3

Hey... You okay there, sunshine? I can practically smell the rage coming off you.

Adora

Yeah, I'm good. Just... Still learning how to let my brain work its way through the anger instead of just letting it bottle up or spontaneously detonate.

Catra <3

Mindfulness exercises? That's good.

So um... While we're on the subject, what about you?

Adora

Huh?

Catra <3

I mean... You never talked much about your folks either. I just always guessed it was a touchy subject and... I kinda wanted to return the favor.

Adora sighed, rubbing at the side of her cheek.

Adora

Not much to tell, to be honest. Classic drop-off baby.

Catra <3

Ah crap. Sorry to hear that.

You never tried to find anything out? I mean, we have DNA tests.

Adora

Of course I thought about it. But in the end I decided not to.

A pause, while Catra chewed over that loaded answer.

Catra <3

Tell me to back off and I will.

Catra <3

Why?

There it was, jabbing straight into the vulnerable spot. One ache that never really went away. But Catra had been honest with her even though she had more reason than anyone to shy away from making herself vulnerable, so Adora forced herself to quickly tap out her response, not giving herself time to consider backing out.

Adora

Because not knowing makes it easier to tell myself they did it for a good reason. That it wasn't just because they didn't want me. Or regretted me.

All sounds of motion overhead ceased. Adora started to glance up, not liking it. "Cat-"

Catra dropped down from the tree, landing in a crouch mere inches away from Adora's face. "Listen to me, okay?"

Adora nodded, too dumbfounded to speak. *So close, so close, oh God she's right here and I'm way too gay and too emotionally screwed up right now for this!*

"I'm with you in the 'better have had a good reason' camp, though literally the only justifiable explanation I'm accepting is 'we can't give her the life she deserves,'" Catra's eyes bored into her, and the amount of sincerity and intensity there stole the breath from Adora's lungs. "But I can tell you this: if they *didn't* have a good reason, then they didn't fucking deserve you to begin with. And if that is the case, then I can one hundred percent guarantee that you were the only worthwhile thing they ever accomplished in their entire lives. Got that?"

Adora swallowed, little tears springing up at the corner of her eyes. *Not gonna cry.*

But of course, Catra noticed, expression shifting into a small, jagged smile as she reached up to thumb them away.

"You deserve the world, Adora. Never forget that, okay?"

Fuuuuuuck! That comforting purr started rumbling in Catra's chest as she leaned in and bumped their foreheads together. Then, only then, did it seem to really register just how close they were. Catra's eyes darted down, breath hitching as she zeroed in on Adora's lips. Adora's heart back flipped when their gazes locked again, moving closer by slow millimeters.

Oh my God oh my God is this really happening?! Finally?! Oh my God!

She took a deep breath...

But then Kyle's voice burst their cozy little bubble. "Hey everyone, hot dogs are done!"

They both started and moved away from each other, and Adora's mind deteriorated into a jumbled up mass of frustrated screams. *No fair no fair no fair no fair!!!*

At least Kyle seemed to realize what had just happened, if the way he drew up short and glanced between them with wide eyes was anything to go on. "*Oh*. Ohhhhh nooooo."

Sorry, Rogelio, but I think I'm duty bound to kill your boyfriend now. My overwhelming romantic frustration demands a blood sacrifice.

Beside her, Catra sighed and pushed herself to her feet before holding out a hand to Adora in turn. "C'mon, dork. We should probably go snatch what we can before having Rogelio and Sparkles in one place triggers the Great Bright Moon Hotdog Famine."

Adora stared for a second, mind still swimming with disappointment before reaching out. "Got it."

When Adora took her hand, Catra didn't let go for a long time.

A week and a half later, Adora sat groaning into the wood of her desk.

Ten days, and even though she and Catra had hung out together several times since the pool party they hadn't gotten even close to that moment again. Not that either of them hadn't been trying;

but every single time since then where they brushed up against each other had carried... This underlying tension with it.

We both know where this is going. So why is getting there so hard?

Adora knew what her problem was, at least. That *almost* at the party had felt like the perfect moment, and she desperately wanted that again. Because it was *Catra,* and they'd spent so long having to hide how they felt and even longer apart and she just wanted the two of them to have a good first kiss worth remembering, damnit!

It wouldn't make up for everything that had happened, but it'd be a damn good start.

Sitting back up, she put away the new revisions she had been polishing for the upcoming meeting with Angella and reached for the pad and paper with the words "Things Catra Might Like" scrawled across it. More than half of the notes had been scribbled out.

That was the one downside to knowing each other so well. It was hard to engineer a situation that was freshly romantic when they (as Glimmer so tactfully put it when Adora made the mistake of asking for her input) acted "like an old married couple that's still hot for each other."

"Ten years," She muttered, clicking her pen a few times and tapping it against her lips. "There's gotta be something I can use. Something to prove I'm putting actual thought into this. That I actually care about making this good."

Waking up her laptop, she scrolled over to No Plan B's twitter page. A lot of the stuff were thoughts by Rogelio on the industry, notes on performances, regular quips by the other band members popping in and a healthy smattering of candid photos of the crew. She grinned as she passed a photo of Lonnie and Scorpia

engaged in a playful flex-off. *Good for you, Lonnie. Happy's a good look on you.*

Scrolling further, she paused on a surprisingly artistic photo of Catra sitting on a couch in what must have been Rogelio and Kyle's home, sunlight coming in through the blinds. It looked like she'd been playing an acoustic with her eyes closed (the way she *always* did when she was relaxed and really getting into the music) but the moment the camera had captured instead was her glancing over with only her gold eye opened as Star stepped onto her shoulder from the back of the couch and rubbed against her head. A soft little crooked smile played across her lips.

Adora right clicked on that photo and saved, then turned back to her notes. *Cats maybe? She certainly likes them. But I don't want her to think I'm making a Magicat joke- OH GOD DAMNIT, ETERNIA!*

With a groan, she crossed cats off the list and continued scrolling down the feed before one tweet in particular caught her eye, because it wasn't from any of the band members.

Quicketrix
Found this video on my old phone f/my college days. NPB @ Crimson Waste! Mostly covers, but think last song is an original they never released!

Adora couldn't click on the video fast enough.

The video and sound quality wasn't great, as to be expected with what looked to be a classic bar show. The band was just finishing off what Adora recognized as a rendition of 'Freebird' (and oh, Adora could just tell by the set of Catra's shoulders and the lashing of her tail that she was *pissed* at having to perform that old cliché) and paused for a moment to breathe and drink some water as Catra said into the mic, "Been a great audience tonight, so we'll leave off with something really special. Here's 'Takeoffs and Landings.'"

With an unreleased song, Adora had honestly been expecting another night terror. So she was caught off guard when Rogelio started a thrumming rhythm, Catra bobbing her head a little as she listened before joining in on a reprise with her own guitar.

Then she started to sing, and Adora stopped thinking of anything at all.

"On this coldest of January nights," Catra sang softly. *"I drive out past the runway/And watch the planes go flying by..."*

A span of three heartbeats, and all softness vanished, the next lines declaration and desperation. *"The runway lights are the deepest blue, like the colors of your eyes/So close them tight and kiss me one last time!"*

The pen clattered to the desk, inconsequential.

If you could go anywhere right now...
Where would you go?
(And would you miss me when you get there?)
There's no place that I would rather be
Please don't let me... Go fallin' from the sky
This fasten seatbelt sign just needs to go out!
If only you could be... Right here by my side
Home wouldn't seem so far from here...

Adora remembered.

Sitting on her bed at Julliard, her own acoustic in hand and the words of her school academic counselor Mara still fresh in her mind. "We're musicians, kid. So if you're dealing with rough feelings, just do what musicians do. Play."

Twenty years old and still heartbroken as ever, she plucked at the strings and sang gently, "I know you, who are you now?/Look into my eyes if you can't remember.../Do you remember?/Oh..."

"I can see, I can still find/You're the only voice my heart can recognize.../But I can't hear you now, yeah!"

The sound of neighbors banging on the walls as she began belting out everything that she'd been keeping in for the past two years.

I'll never be the same!
I'm caught inside the memories
The promises, our yesterdays
When I belonged to you
I just can't walk away
'Cause after loving you...
I could never be the same!

Just how many songs had they sung to each other across ten years of distance?

"Enough," Adora growled, shutting her laptop with a slam and pushing away from the desk. "I may not know how to impress her, but I know plenty of people who were with her when I couldn't be."

Throwing open the door, she shouted down the hallway over the sound of video game gunfire. *"Glimmer!* I'm calling in a favor!"

The sound abruptly cut out. "Oh snap."

One week, three days, Catra thought miserably to herself as she rubbed at the developing bags under her eyes. *One week, three days since I almost kissed the girl of my dreams. Seriously, universe, what the fuck did I ever do to you?*

Even if she knew that answer (*Remember what Micah said. That's not your life. Don't let it run yours*) it was still a colossal dick move.

She was hanging out with Kyle, Rogelio, and Scorpia at the latter's apartment, watching sci-fi original movies and pointedly ignoring the way Kyle was endeavoring to sit as far away from her as humanly possible. Lonnie was off consulting with Scorpia's moms (who helped fund their cd distribution) as well as negotiating in

advance with a few venue owners for the next time they went on tour.

Anybody who was accustomed to Catra being the best dresser in the room (which she usually was, dumpster fire revenge moves aside) would be surprised by how trashed she looked; black sweatpants, unkempt mane and a grey (to her, at least) shirt Lonnie had gotten her as a Christmas gag gift last year. Apparently it was a cardinal red shirt with a different shade of red font reading, "You would not <u>believe</u> how red colorblind I am."

It was pretty much her go-to outfit for when her give-a-damn was busted.

Thanks to all that, Catra was honestly pretty grateful for the chance to just chill with the friend group without any real social obligations or work concerns or need to talk about feelings; just bad movies and flicking popcorn at the tv screen while making fun of the bad acting. It had been a little too long for her comfort level with everything that had happened recently.

Plus she wanted to brood a little longer without anyone interrupting her.

'So...' Rogelio snapped his fingers to get Catra's attention. *'How are things going with our favorite blonde wonder woman?"*

So much for that. Catra huffed. "Really, guys? We were *so* close to passing the Bechdel test. Also, thanks for adding the qualifier so I knew you weren't talking about your boyfriend, because you *really* don't wanna know my thoughts on that matter right now."

"Oh my God! I will literally give you my firstborn if you'll just forgive me already!"

"Not a chance, wonder twink; I ain't raisin' your kid for you. Don't think I'm not onto your game."

Kyle groaned and slumped back against the couch.

"You know," Scorpia laughed as she turned down the volume on the TV. "He *has* been begging for your forgiveness since the party."

"And he can beg a bit longer," Catra stated dispassionately as she popped some jerky into her mouth (not a big fan of how popcorn got stuck in her predator's molars.) "I didn't interrupt his first kiss with Rogelio."

'Even for you that would have been a tall order, considering it was on a Ferris Wheel.'

"Wow. Could you be any more teen romance movie cliché? Regardless, he owes me at least another two and a half weeks of groveling."

'Ok, sins of my future husband aside,' Rogelio signed diplomatically, while Kyle managed to both turn bright grey and give an affronted whine of "Babe!" at the same time. *'Seriously. How have things been?'*

Catra sighed. "Fine. Just... Kinda awkward."

Kinda was a bit of an understatement. Ever since that moment of vulnerability, in the few times they'd met up they both just kind of... Circled around each other. Each almost daring the other to make a move.

Loving Adora is easy. So why are feelings so hard?

"Um... Remind me again why you can't just kiss her, Wildcat?"

Catra blushed, taking a sip of her soda as she mumbled. "Mood's not right."

Rogelio's brow ridges shot up. *'Never took you for someone who put much thought into things like that.'*

"Well I *do,* okay? I just want it to be..." *Don't say it, don't say it!* "... Perfect."

Damnit!

Thankfully, Scorpia came to the rescue. "Because it's Adora, right?"

Catra nodded. *At least I didn't say 'special.' Thanks brain, I owe you one.* "Yeah. Because it's Adora. Always has been."

Probably always will.

Rogelio was speaking again. *'Damn, Cat. You're making me swoon. It's uncomfortable. Quit it.'*

"Yeah, I think we're all *super* uncomfortable with this," Eyes slipping half closed, she let her head hit the back of the couch with a dull thud. "Ok, do you two really wanna start paying me back for Kyle's sins?"

'I claim zero responsibility-'

"Babe, no."

'Babe, yes. But I am interested. What's your price?'

Catra glanced over at him, eyes searching. "How the hell did you two sort it out?"

"Um... Excuse me?"

"You get to talk in a minute, cock blocker. But seriously: Lonnie, Adora and I literally had a betting pool running on whether or not you two would man up before graduation, keep dancing around your obvious tension, or just straight up tear each other's clothes off in the middle of practice one day. So how on earth did you two get it together?"

At their appalled expressions, she added. "For the record, Adora won. She had a lot more faith in you two then me or Lonnie."

"Catra, *why?"*

"Because truth hurts, Kyle. Thank you for coming to my TED talk."

While the two shared a look, Scorpia took advantage of a lull in the movie to reach over Rogelio and tap Catra on the shoulder, "So, quick question. Why aren't you asking me for advice?"

"Because you're dating Lonnie, and asking you for info I know will be tailored to my vitriolic best bud to some degree is waaaay too close to emotional incest for my comfort level."

"I can understand that," Somewhere in the depths of the apartment, a jaunty ringtone started playing. "Oh! I'll be right back."

As she hurried off, humming the song, Catra resumed her stare down with the other two.

Rogelio gave her what Catra had come to think of as his "disapproving dad stare." *'So remind me again why I should help you out here?'*

"Maybe because I'm the reason you met Kyle in the first place? And put up with five whole years of you screaming at me about how cute/hot he was whenever Lonnie needed a sanity break? Or how 'bout that time I took the fall for you when those assholes from drum squad found that sketch you drew of you and Kyle's hypothetical kid by telling them it was me trolling you? Frankly, you should be glad I'm just calling in on an interrupted kiss. Given enough time, I could fucking *bury* the two of you."

Man, it was satisfying to watch both their faces grow steadily darker as they flushed. Playing it nice all the time was worth it in the end, but sometimes it just felt so good to be bad.

"Ok, yeah..."

'When you put it that way...'

Checkmate.

"So spill. What happened to get you two from 'oh no, he's hot and I'm struck stupid by the majesty' to basically married?"

"Well, I mean..." Kyle rubbed the back of his neck. "I can't speak for Rogelio but for me, I just sorta... Got tired of being afraid? I mean, it wasn't doing me any real favors. While it's not like I wasn't enjoying being best friends and all--because we still *are* no matter what pop culture says about romance and friendship being fundamentally separate--I guess I just realized I didn't like the trade-off of telling myself I was just fine remaining friends. Not when the possibility of so much more was right there waiting for me. So I went for it."

Catra blinked, a little surprised by the unexpected eloquence. And the fact that apparently *Kyle* had made the first move (in her defense, they had just kinda shown up to practice one day with a clipped *'Hey, we figured it out'* from Rogelio, but *still.)* Would wonders never cease?

'Look, Catra,' Rogelio patted her on the shoulder. *'I don't think you're going to get anywhere by asking what other people have done. I think you should be thinking about what <u>you</u> would do.'*

"Oh no, not the old 'follow your heart' speech."

'Oh hell no, hearts are dumb as bricks and should not be left unsupervised. I'm saying you should follow your instincts. When the right moment arrives, you'll know exactly what to do.'

At this point, Scorpia emerged from the bedroom with her purse in hand. "Hey guys, I've gotta go meet with somebody. Feel free to chill out and order some pizza until I get back, okay? Save some for Lonnie, she's running a little late."

Catra just gave her an exhausted salute while Rogelio grunted an affirmation. Kyle shot them both a dirty look, and replied, "Thanks, Scorpia! Have fun doing whatever!"

Now alone with the two guys who might as well have been her brothers, Catra raised an eyebrow. "Sharknado 3?"

"SHARKS! IN! *SPACE!!!*"

Despite that ringing endorsement, Catra's mind wandered off almost as soon as the opening began. *Follow my instincts, huh?*

Chapter End Notes

Next time: We see what Scorpia's up to, our two lovestruck gays take a chill pill, Angella is a reasonable boss, No Plan B has a barbecue at Kyle and Rogelio's house to celebrate heading back to the studio, a few long overdue revelations come out and Catra and Adora *finally* figure things out in the only way they know how: through SONG!

I'm now finally on tumblr, so if you wanna read some meta and worldbuilding notes in between updates, check it out here under the Rhythm & Blues tag. I'll also start posting little WIP snippets if it takes too long between chapters again. Credit where it's due: the joke about what they're like while high was based off of this post.

How I Loved Her And Love Her (There Is No One Else In The World)

Chapter Summary

> The love birds take some time to relax, Angella is a boss ass bitch, Lonnie has fun with her power over the group chat, the group gathers for a barbecue, Adora is actually way more messed up than anyone else gave her credit for and Catra finally spots the moment they've ~~all~~ *both* been waiting for.

Chapter Notes

> All right guys. -torches 2019 and kicks it down the hill- Let's start this New Year off right: with these two idiots finally getting their shit together. Thanks so much for your patience, and I hope I'll see you all in the next part as well. Enjoy this mega-sized chapter.
>
> We've got three songs this time, so if you wanna listen along they are in order: "Heart of War" by Message from Sylvia, "Behind Closed Doors" by Pop Evil, and "Celeste" by Ezra Vine, though that last one in universe is... Well, you'll see. ;)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora flashed a tired smile as Scorpia slid into the booth across from her. "Honestly, I can't thank you enough for taking the time to meet with me."

"Ah, no biggie. You seem pretty cool, and I'm always up for some good gyros," She picked up the menu delicately in her pincers and began flipping through. "Though I must say I was a little surprised that you had my number. How'd that happen?"

"I might have asked Glimmer," Adora admitted a bit sheepishly. "Apparently you two hit it off pretty well?"

"Oh yeah! We've been texting back and forth about having a jam session sometime soon. I think it could be a lot of fun. Just two drummers cutting loose and bringing the house down."

"Hey, that's great!"

Things went silent for a few minutes as the waiter swung by and took their orders (both drink and food, since they each already knew what they wanted.) Adora nervously drummed her fingers on the table, not sure how to break that silence. Thankfully, she didn't have to.

"Ok, Adora, let me be on the level with you," Scorpia said, nodding her thanks to another server as he put down her iced tea and Adora's sprite. "Don't get me wrong, I do still think you're cool and I would like to get to know you as a possible friend once everything blows over. But if I can take a stab at why we're both here..."

She quirked an eyebrow at her. "Short, snarky, loves to sing, allergic to feeling vulnerable, starts with 'C' and ends with 'Atra'?"

Adora groaned. "Ok yeah, you got it in one."

"Thought so. So why'd you come to me specifically? Wouldn't any of the other Fright Zone vets be better equipped to give you advice?"

Guess Lonnie told her the details if she's using that name. She shifted a little uncomfortably in her seat. "I guess... Maybe I wanted to talk to someone who wasn't there for all of that history but still *knows* Catra, you know?"

"Ahhhhh. All right then. So what do you want to hash out?"

Adora took a deep breath. No time to chicken out, even though admitting this was practically killing her. "Basically, we almost kissed back at the party. The moment felt right, and now things are just awkward. I just... want to try to make that happen again. But it's hard to do that when we're already..."

"Romantic as heck? Yeah, I get that," Dumping some sugar into her tea and delicately stirring it, Scorpia looked Adora dead in the eyes, an unusually serious expression on her face. "Ok, we've got two options here. Your choice: do you want the standard stock advice for these situations, or do you want the real deal? Even if you probably aren't gonna like it."

Adora exhaled heavily, running a hand through her hair. "Well let's be real here: it would kind of defeat the purpose of seeking you out if I didn't ask for honesty. If I wanted stock advice, I could just go to Glimmer and Bow."

"Glad we're on the same page," Scorpia smiled, reaching over to pat Adora's other hand consolingly. "Basically, you're trying too hard."

Adora frowned. "I mean... It's *Catra*. So of course I'm trying."

"Oh, I'm not saying you shouldn't put in the effort. That's what keeps relationships going, you know? But this thing you're doing, driving yourself crazy trying to orchestrate a perfect moment? Well... Remember that story back at the pool party?"

"The summer solstice incident or the time Rogelio and Kyle went viral while twerking to Catra hitting microwave buttons?" Sure, Adora knew for certain that wasn't it, but there had been a *lot* of embarrassing stories shared during that game of questions.

"Not that, though I do recommend the video," Scorpia chuckled. "I'm talking about Lonnie trying to confess to me."

"Oh, right. You didn't really elaborate beyond having to go to the hospital. I woulda asked, but I was too busy being amused by *Lonnie* being the lesbian dumbass for once."

"Well, as you clearly know, love makes fools of us all," Scorpia said with a wink. "But here's the basic rundown. Lonnie tried really, *really* hard to come up with a way to confess that would impress me. Inviting me out to a classical concert despite hating most of the genre, taking cooking lessons for like six months,

standing outside my window with a boom box... And then of course, the tequila incident when we were all out together at New Year's."

"Um... Wow," An understatement, Adora realized, given that Lonnie--arguably the most stable of them all--seemed to have gone through the entire romcom playbook just to ask out her girlfriend. "What happened to mess her up so bad?"

"Well, we ran into my moms at the concert and that made her too nervous, found out she's allergic to abalones when she offered to make me dinner, and lastly she woke Catra up first--I wear earplugs to bed--and by the time Catra came and got me the boom box had shorted out. I'm not even sure where she found one."

"Oh my God," Adora had to cover her mouth with a hand to tamp down on her laughter, planting her closed fist on the table as her shoulders shook, because seriously: what on Etheria had Lonnie *done* to end up that cursed? "I mean, didn't you...?"

"Oh yeah, I figured it out pretty quickly. But she seemed so determined to find some grand way to confess that I didn't want to undercut her efforts," Scorpia admitted with a shrug and a sheepish smile. "The tree punching incident was where I drew the line, though."

"An entire third of tequila?"

"On her first try," Scorpia confirmed, smiling wistfully. "Catra and Rogelio were basically frog marching her when she shook them off and started shouting about how beautiful and wonderful I was and that she felt bad she couldn't think of a way to impress me, but she could *totally* punch down this sapling to show how much she meant it. We were all a little bit tipsy, so we weren't fast enough to stop her."

I am never going to be able to look Lonnie in the face again without thinking about this. Adora thought. "Wait, didn't Catra

drive?"

"It was a couple of hours before we realized she'd actually broken two knuckles, and we initially took an Uber. Catra and I had time to fully sober up, and we were watching over Lonnie at our place so she wouldn't vomit in her sleep. So she was still shitfaced but no longer immune to pain at that point, and Catra was good to drive while I sat with Lonnie in the backseat and tried to keep her comfortable."

"That's... Actually weirdly sweet once you get past the overall disaster."

"Aww, thanks," Scorpia giggled a little, reaching out to take her plate from the waiter. "But the point I'm trying to make is that Lonnie kept getting messed up because she was so focused on forcing a perfect moment that something was bound to go wrong. Just the law of the universe in effect there."

"Yeah, I thought so..." Adora sighed, picking at her own new-arrived food with her fork. "So how did you two...?"

"Well, that's the thing. After all that time trying to orchestrate a perfect moment... Well, the actual moment came when Lonnie woke up with the worst hangover of her life and looked so cute and confused that I just had to tell her that I'd be happy to date her."

"That... Wow. Dunno what to say that wasn't already covered by 'that's really sweet.' Congrats, I guess?"

"Thanks. Think that helps you any?"

"Yeah, I get it. Chill out or you'll just self-sabotage," Adora smiled ruefully, propping her chin on her hand and gazing out the window at all the people milling about on the sidewalk. "It's just hard to relax when it all means so much, you know?"

"Oh yeah. I'd be lying if I said I didn't fall into the exact same trap when our first anniversary rolled around," Glancing around like

she expected eavesdroppers, Scorpia held up one claw and whispered. "But between you and me... I don't think you have anything to worry about."

Adora's head snapped back toward her. "Let me guess... Catra's been freaking out too?"

"Yup. She even asked Kyle for advice. In a set with Rogelio, but still."

"Oh wow," Despite the overall ridiculousness of the situation, Adora still had to smile at the symmetry. "Ok. I'll talk to her about it and we can both chill out and let it go naturally. And I can stop losing sleep over this."

"Yay!" Scorpia cheered, clicking her claws for emphasis. "Now c'mon, let's talk interests for a while. What are you into when you're not being Adora Eternia, pop star?"

By the time she left the restaurant and waved Scorpia goodbye an hour later... Well, Adora would be lying if she said it had been the advice she wanted, but she'd also be lying if she claimed it wasn't *exactly* what she needed to hear.

Adorable
So... A certain very buff, very loyal friend who gives excellent hugs might have let slip that we've both been freaking out.

Catra
So you were the one Scorpia was meeting up with? I kinda figured.

Adorable
Really? How?

Catra
Nothing dramatic. I'm just familiar with most of her ringtones and I know for a fact that any time she makes a new friend she

immediately matches them to a new song. The fact that she got a call with her default and then immediately left to meet someone? It was either going to be you or Bow.

Adorable
Ok, that's actually pretty clever.

Catra
Well it was either that or let Sharknado 3 scorch my remaining brain cells, so I had plenty of time to work on that puzzle.

Catra
So... I guess we're both on the same page that we're being ridiculous?

Adorable
I mean, unless we wanna pull a Lonnie and keep fucking up to the point of desperation, yeah.

Catra
Oh God no, I am not losing that dragging gold standard. We are NOT pulling a Lonnie.

Catra
So we just chill?

Adorable
Yeah. It's not like either of us is going anywhere. The moment will come back around.

Catra
All right. I can handle that.

Adorable
Good.

Adorable
<3

Meeting with Angella was a prospect that was both exciting and utterly nerve-wracking. Not that Adora had ever found her to be anything but "tough yet fair," but there was still something deeply intimidating about a woman who held your financial stability in the palm of her hand. And the fact that Glimmer gave her regular play-by-plays of Angella's comeuppance to primadonna artists did not help matters.

Even Glimmer seemed to be feeling antsy, judging by the way she hummed nervously along to the muzak as the pair rode the elevator up to the top floor. Halfway through a particularly tricky section she was completely mangling, Adora reached out and put a hand on her shoulder.

"It'll be fine," She assured her, tapping at the messenger bag hanging against her hip. "Your plan will work. We have all we need to make our case right here."

Glimmer closed her eyes, placing one hand atop Adora's and breathing deep, before squeezing and letting go. "All right. Let's do this."

The elevator came to a smooth stop with a *ding*, doors sliding open to reveal the understated yet elegant office of Bright Moon Records' CEO. Still in the understated art deco style that had dominated when the tower was built (albeit with the furnishings subtly updated to keep the style but still mesh with the times), a bank of windows dominated one side of the room, around which clustered Sibor and his three... Co-managers? Co-ordinators? … Co-annoyances, Adora decided with an internal sneer.

Seated behind a massive oak desk with her wings folded, Angella glanced over as the two entered, giving them each a nod in turn. "Good morning to you both. Glimmer. Adora. I understand you have some complaints to lodge about your managers. And seeing as they have already inundated me with spreadsheets and data clusters, I welcome your perspective."

"We do, ma'am," Glimmer answered, consciously avoiding the use of "mom" in this context. "Simply put, we feel that our talents have been severely hampered by too much managerial control. Moreover, we have evidence to prove it."

"Oh?" Angella arched one perfectly sculpted brow at them, but Adora knew they had her interest.

Adora stepped forward, opening the messenger bag and removing a small set of bluetooth speakers paired to her phone, as well as two stacks of paper bound together with rubber bands.

"This," Glimmer explained as Adora gingerly set up the speakers and laid the two separate sheaves of sheet music out on Angella's desk in front of her, careful not to disturb anything. "Is the demo recording of our first single, completely unaltered from our original composition."

Adora hit play and watched as Angella listened along, brows sometimes lifting in surprise at certain segments, for reasons she and Glimmer both knew but she doubted the manager squad did. Long moments passed with bated breath... Then Angella pulled the sheet music closer and began to follow along with her fingertip, lips moving silently along with the music.

We've got this.

"And *this*," Glimmer declared with a raw grimace once the demo ended. "Is what we ended up with after all the forced revisions."

And frankly... There was no nice way to put it. Even if you did ascribe to that old chestnut about killing your darlings (and Adora had always thought that was a stupid way to look at things) this wasn't so much a mercy killing as throwing their metaphorical offspring straight into a wood chipper. Sick, wrong, traumatizing to bystanders and oh-so messy.

They barely made it halfway through the song before Angella waved her hand at Adora. "Turn it off, please."

After Adora had complied, Angella sighed heavily before turning and fixing the cluster of Sibor and the other managers with a steely glare. "Gentlemen. I want you all to pay very close attention to what I'm about to say to you. Especially *you*, Sibor."

The man in question rapidly paled, only able to nod.

"Now..." Angella continued calmly as she began spreading out the sheet music for the demo in front of her. "You all pride yourselves on how well you know the current music industry. And yes, I *do* pay attention to your superiors and your persistent crowing on the matter has been... Abundantly noted in their bimonthly reports."

Even though they weren't the ones in the line of fire, Adora and Glimmer still reflexively glanced at one another, nervousness written across both their faces. As satisfying as it was to watch Sibor and co. getting taken down several pegs... There was a reason why Adora dreaded getting on Angella's bad side.

"But that wouldn't be enough to make me angry, gentlemen. No, what's making me angry is how much your attitude highlights either your total ignorance of or complete lack of respect for music history. Especially the history of the very company you have chosen to work for.

"For example," She tapped a finger against a spot on the very first page. "This line here? "I pass the small cafe where we used to dance/Though shadows fall, I still spare a glance"? Maybe if you'd bothered to pay attention you'd recognize that line as a direct reference to the single that jumpstarted my mother's career."

Angella paused and fixed them with a positively withering stare. "You know... The career that Bright Moon Records was quite literally built upon? I can't help but notice that line is completely absent from your version."

Angella paused for a moment to glance over at Glimmer. "You did always like listening to your grandmother's old records, didn't you, sweetheart?"

Glimmer blushed and rubbed the back of her neck, but gave a little nod. Adora grinned and nudged her with an elbow, whispering, "Told you she'd be cool."

"However," Angella continued as the managers snapped back to attention from where they had been nervously muttering amongst themselves. "If that were the only oversight, it could be forgiven. But look here!"

Another stab at the paper, this time much more vehemently.

"This segment of notes here, it's built along the exact same progression present in the chorus to my first single! And then... By the way, this is quite a lovely touch, Adora, good show-"

Adora grinned goofily and fidgeted in response to the praise.

"-it intertwines with a section deliberately paralleling 'Wonderful Tonight.' Which you may--but probably don't--know is the very same song my husband wrote to *propose* to me! But I suppose that since he has retired from music, his work is no longer worth examination?" Cutting off mid-tirade, she glanced between the two separate compositions. "And you replaced it with... Is that the damn Four Chords? Heh. If my mother rolled any harder in her grave we could attach a belt and generate enough electricity to keep this building lit for the rest of our collective lives."

"Holy shit. Go *off*, mom," Glimmer whispered in awe.

"What you have done here, gentlemen," Angella concluded, steepling her fingers. "Is you took a beautiful tribute to my family's history and influence on the musical landscape and utterly *eviscerated* it. And if this is what you did to their first album, I don't even want to imagine what kind of atrocities you've committed since. If I were a less kind woman, I would fire you all on the spot. I'm sure your experience would easily secure you a position in the Horde, and frankly your output thus far would be better suited to it."

Adora's jaw dropped.

"However, I am kind. Whether you choose to utilize the fruits of that kindness to the best of your ability is entirely up to you," Angella sighed and (likely to the collective relief of the entire pack of managers) shifted her attention back to Adora and Glimmer still standing shell-shocked in the aftermath. "I'll make you two a deal. Rework your current album as best you can. No oversight; you report directly to me. Then we'll see how it does upon release, and that will give us an indicator of how to move forward.

"However," She raised a finger to cut off Glimmer's excited exclamation. "You will have to handle explaining the changes to the media yourselves. That is, after all, typically a managerial and PR team concern. So please, for the love of all that is good in this industry, don't make it reflect badly upon our family's company, Glimmer."

"We could turn it into a positive," Adora suggested. "Leave out the executive meddling, say that this was always the plan but we were building a good foundation to start. That way it paints Bright Moon Records in a more reasonable light, letting talent earn more creative freedom instead of handicapping it. And it wouldn't even be a lie; we *were* doing that. It just got to the point where we felt we had to force the issue."

Angella nodded. "And I apologize for that. But I can assure you that no matter how this goes... There will be some serious changes occurring in BMR over the next few years. We've been stagnating for far too long.

"You both have my blessing. So go create the best recording you can. Oh, and Glimmer?"

Glimmer paused midway between jumping up and down and preparing to grab Adora in a headlock. "Yes, mom?"

Angella smiled softly. "Send me the mp3 of your demo later, all right? I'd like to listen to it a bit more."

"Yesssssss," Glimmer hissed, fist pumping before snapping a jaunty salute. "Thank you so much for this meeting. We'll leave you to your work and get back to ours. C'mon, Miss Composer."

"After you," Adora chuckled, falling in step behind Glimmer, who was one closed door away from skipping in glee.

"Don't forget to wear your aunt's sweater to the solstice," Angella called after them. "I know they're hideous, but I'll never hear the end of it otherwise!"

The door swung shut, just slow enough for them to pick up a chilling, "Now... Where were we?"

"Summer's Here and We're All Queer"

A Drummer, Not An Animal: WHOOHOO, GUESS WHO'S FREE OF MANAGERIAL OVERSIGHT, BITCHES?!

A Drummer, Not An Animal: ... Wat.

Lesbian Himbo: I see Lonnie's been having fun again.

Pretty Fly for a White Guy: Hey guys.

Lesbian Himbo: That you, Kyle?

All About Dat Bass: I would have many questions if it weren't. So you got rid of the managers? Congrats.

A Drummer, Not An Animal: Technically my mom did. And I do not envy them one bit.

Here Comes the Sun: Yeah, Mrs. Angella can be pretty scary when she gets mad, haha. You guys on your way back?

All About Dat Bass: You weren't with them at the meeting?

Here Comes the Sun: I know enough about composing to help in making the songs, but technical stuff kinda makes my head hurt.

Catra on a Hot Tin Roof: Yeah, plus you're the human equivalent of one of those cute little marshmallow chicks. So no conflict for you.

A Drummer, Not An Animal: How come YOU escaped a name change?

Catra on a Hot Tin Roof: Because Lonnie still remembers what happened the last time she pushed me. Hey Adora. ;3

Lesbian Himbo: ;D

All About Dat Bass: Good lord, will you two just get it over with already?

A Drummer, Not An Animal: You honestly think that'll free us?

Catra on a Hot Tin Roof: I got five words to answer that. "Fanchild OC, do not steal."

All About Dat Bass: ... I hate you. Point conceded.

Here Comes the Sun: What...?

Catra on a Hot Tin Roof: Don't worry about it.

Scorpions Give the Best Hugs: Hey guys.

Lesbian Himbo: Heh. Well I'm glad we don't have to ask who that is.

Scorpions Give the Best Hugs: :D

A Drummer, Not An Animal: Starting to see a sliding scale of favoritism here.

Actually I AM the Boss: You all would do the exact same thing, so don't even.

Pretty Fly for a White Guy: Hey, welcome back! How'd the negotiations go?

Actually I AM the Boss: Honestly there wasn't a lot there that couldn't have been handled if they'd just forwarded me the paperwork like I asked in the first damn place. -rolls eyes-

Actually I AM the Boss: Btw, furball, you and Ro are gonna have to be briefed pre-performance on the stunts they're willing to insure.

Catra on a Hot Tin Roof: Oh fuck me...

All About Dat Bass: Well at least we won't have to worry about that until next year.

Catra on a Hot Tin Roof: I'll see what I can figure out in the meantime.

Actually I AM the Boss: Please do. But anyway, what's up with you guys?

Lesbian Himbo: Glimmer's mom made some managers regret ever having been born.

A Drummer, Not An Animal: And we did it through empirical evidence, not nepotism! Beat those smarmy pricks at their own game!

Actually I AM the Boss: That's friggin' rad but how...?

A Drummer, Not An Animal posted kickass opener #1.mp3 and dear god why.mp3 in the chat

Actually I AM the Boss: ...

All About Dat Bass: I think this might actually be some sort of crime. Holy shit.

Lesbian Himbo: Well on the plus side, if the new album does well we can probably convince Angella to let us do a director's cut of our most butchered songs.

Scorpions Give the Best Hugs: Man, I hope so. Geez...

Catra on a Hot Tin Roof: I think I died a little inside. But you're off the choke chain?

Lesbian Himbo: Yup. It'll probably take a couple monthss to unfuck everything and retrain our muscle memory, but then we'll be back in action.

Actually I AM the Boss: Suh-weet. All right, I was gonna propose this anyway but now we've got double the reason.

Actually I AM the Boss: K, so here's the deal. In about a month, give or take, NPB heads back to the studio. Since we're all in the business here, we all know that's really just code for "spend a few months writing new songs and playing until our fingers bleed before we even think of setting foot in a studio" but it sounds better.

Actually I AM the Boss: So I figure barbecue at Rogelio and Kyle's place in about three weeks? Celebrate you guys getting to let your hair down and us getting back to business.

Here Comes the Sun: Sounds fun, but should you really be offering their place like that?

All About Dat Bass: It's cool. Since Ma and Mom Taranis came back from vacation we're the only ones who have a grill.

Scorpions Give the Best Hugs: They'd probably let us use it if we asked but... Well, they're not scary or anything but my moms can get a little nosy. Another time maybe.

A Drummer, Not An Animal: Well if that's all cleared, sure I'm down. I'll see if my dad'll let me borrow the family steak marinade recipe.

All About Dat Bass: Much as you dig steak, I'm surprised you don't have it memorized.

A Drummer, Not An Animal: Let's just say the ingredient order is very precise and leave it at that. Also the only copy has been in the family for like four generations, and he refuses to let me make my own.

Lesbian Himbo: She seems like she's complaining, but she loves hanging out with him. She's got the sparkle grin going.

A Drummer, Not An Animal: I will never complain. My dad's the coolest.

Actually I AM the Boss: I'll save us some time since us five'll definitely be there. Wonder Woman and Sunshine Boy, you both in?

Lesbian Himbo: Of course!

Here Comes the Sun: Heck yeah!

Actually I AM the Boss: Awesome. :) We'll hammer out the final details when we get there. Now let's rock this month!

Adora
Hey... You gonna be fine with us both being busy for a few weeks?

Catra <3
Not like our lives haven't been busy up 'til now. Besides... Think of me as your friendly neighborhood wildcat. I don't care if you're focused on work if we can just chill together. I can entertain myself.

Adora
So your place or mine?

Catra <3
Depends on how long it takes Sparkles and Rainbow to drive you up the wall.

Adora
K. Expect me in three days. I'll bring a sleeping bag.

Catra <3
Heh.

One of the things about Catra that never fails to surprise people, Adora has found over the years, is that when she is relaxed and comfortable and unguarded she can be remarkably *silly*.

It just flies in the face of her projected image of the badass rockstar/former school ass-kicker--not that she isn't both of those things, but Adora also knows her well enough to recognize the performative aspects along with the genuine ones. Frankly, she appreciates the fact that Catra trusts her enough to let both sides of her personality slip out. It never fails to be endearing. Cute.

About a week and a half following the meeting with Angella, they were chilling out together on the smaller couch--Adora's brain resolutely *refuses* to call it a loveseat in this context, not while they're stuck in this holding pattern--at BFS's while Glimmer and Bow played video games on the other. Adora, determined to chill out for once since the revisions were by now well ahead of schedule, was taking the time to indulge in some light reading *("Really? You call a piece by piece breakdown of Shostakovich's entire body of work 'light reading,' Adora?" "Just shut up and go back to being a good pillow, Catra." "Fiiine. But only because you indulged my latent praise kink."*)

So yeah, Catra was sitting on the right side of the couch with one leg crossed over the other reading a few fan emails on her phone-

-while No Plan B was quickly gathering so many fans that replying to all of them was no longer feasible, the group did still try to read them and Kyle (who was in charge of the overall group account) dutifully forwarded the ones addressed to specific recipients to their private accounts.

Meanwhile, Adora sprawled across the other half of the couch, her longer legs hooked over the arm and her head and shoulders leaned against Catra's side. Catra's left arm rested across Adora's upper chest, keeping her steady, and although Adora's heart did some frankly dangerous things whenever Catra absentmindedly played her fingers across her collarbone... It was surprisingly cozy. Maybe even (dare she think it) *domestic*.

Across from them, Glimmer and Bow had paused midway through a particularly brutal Mario Kart tournament when Glimmer decided to regale him about the latest cocky teenager she'd decimated in Crimson Waste Online.

"So after I take out his buddy with the grenade--camping little bitch--and disarmed him, I pulled out my combat knife--you know, the one that does like next to no damage? So as I approach to deal the killing blow, the kid's freaking out on voice chat after talking so much smack and he's like 'Why are you doing this?' And I just said: Open the door, get on the floor-"

"*Everybody walk the dinosaur~,*" Catra sang without missing a beat.

Dead silence. Catra glanced up, ears folding back defensively as the other two stared at her. "What?"

"Just a little surprised," Glimmer replied with a smirk. "I mean, Miss Big-Shot Super Tough Rock Star knowing a stupid meme, and not even a very well-known one at that."

Catra frowned. "What meme?"

"Wait, what do you mean, 'what meme?' The joke is to wait until you're at the end of some badass or scary story, and then

completely ruin the tension by ending it with those lines. That's the entire thing."

Adora had to actually bite down on the inside of her lip here, because she knew exactly what was coming next.

"So wait..." Catra's brow furrowed. "You mean you've never heard the song?"

"There's a *song*?!" Bow squealed, a delighted grin stretching across his face.

Catra sighed and exited out of her email before pulling up YouTube, tossing the phone over to Glimmer. "See for yourself."

Adora struggled to keep herself from laughing as they watched with wide eyes what she knew from personal experience to be a video complete with lines like, *"It was a night like this forty million years ago/I lit a cigarette, picked up a monkey skull to go"* frequent use of a cowbell, and a line of women in fur bikinis grooving to the tune while making raptor hands. It was the exact midpoint between deliberately being funny and goofily sincere; pure, glorious late-80s *cheese*.

"Oh. My. *God*," Glimmer's eyes sparkled, glued to the screen. "How have I lived my entire life up to this point without knowing about this?"

"And how do *you* know about it?" Bow asked Catra.

Catra shrugged, trying to play it cool. "It was our guitar teacher's ringtone for a couple of years."

"She's lying," Adora cut in with a sly smile. "His ringtone was the riff to 'Iron Man.' She actually discovered it on a list of cheesiest songs of the 80s when we were tweens, fell in love with it and then kept humming the song for three straight weeks."

"*Adora*!"

"Nope," She chuckled, butting the back of her head into Catra's side. "After how many times you got it stuck in my head right after I got it out, you do not get to play the cool kid here."

Catra stared down at her for a long moment as she processed the betrayal... Before a slow, dangerous smirk spread across her lips and Adora suddenly realized she'd made a horrible, horrible mistake. *I think I hecked up.*

"One time, when we were both fifteen," Catra began in a slow drawl. "Adora forgot to take her towel with her when she went to take a shower. We didn't have like big communal locker rooms or anything, but there were several shower rooms in the dorm and everyone had a designated time to use them. So, being the *good* friend I am, I decided to bring it to her.

"So I get within earshot of the bathroom, and what do I hear?" She glanced over at Adora, and waggled her eyebrows.

Oh no...

"What?" "Don't leave us hangin'!"

"I'm treated to the very surreal experience of Adora singing 'Never Gonna Give You Up' at the top of her lungs, enunciation and everything. Yup: the rickroll song. I obviously didn't get a look because I have friggin' decency, but I'm pretty sure she was dancing too."

Adora felt her face go bright red, while Glimmer looked like all her Winterfests had come at once.

"And then, just when I thought I had recovered from *that*, she transitioned over into 'The Warrior' by Pat Benatar without even missing a beat."

"Excuse you, that was Patty Smythe--oh goddamnit, Catra!"

She winked. "Gotcha. No denying it happened now."

"Yeah, well you know every single 2000s emo rock song ever written," Adora scoffed, rolling her eyes.

"Girl, I fucking dare you to tell me that hearing 'The Middle' doesn't still make you smile. And *you* literally weaponized Nickelback's entire discography."

"And it's still the most effective way to win an argument! Just threaten to play 'Rock Star' at them! Shuts down the entire room!"

"What happens if you run into someone who still likes that song?"

"Yeah, like that'll ever happen. But for the sake of that hypothetical situation, there's plenty of other equally terrible songs to choose from."

"What about 'Photograph'?"

"What *about* it?"

"This might actually be the best day of my life," Glimmer fist-bumped Bow as they both settled back and continued to watch the show, flipping open her phone and setting the recording to go into the 'Blackmail' folder of her Dropbox account.

Adora grinned excitedly as the trio sauntered up the walkway to Rogelio and Kyle's cozy little two-bedroom cottage on the edge of Bright Moon. The door swung open before she could even knock, a grinning Kyle gesturing at them. "C'mon in, guys. Rogelio's just about done prepping. Glimmer, if you've got that marinade, now would be a good time to drop that off in the kitchen."

Glimmer hefted the bottle she'd brought back from her trip to see Micah and flashed a peace sign in return. Kyle just laughed as he ushered them all in.

Light was the first impression Adora got from the house. Everything was painted in bright, cheery colors accented here and

there with deeper splashes. The living room where they all headed was dominated by a huge glass door through which the sun lit up the entire room, beyond which they could see Rogelio working at the small grill on a small brick patio, and a pair of clean white couches facing each other across a coffee table. But the thing that impressed Adora the most was the absolutely *lush* garden that lined the entirety of the small backyard.

"Oh wow," She breathed as Kyle slid open the door to allow Rogelio back in. "Guys, you've done a fantastic job. You must have worked hard."

'Damn right, he did,' Rogelio smiled proudly as he pressed his snout to the side of Kyle's head, who chuckled a little. *'I paved the patio. But the garden is Kyle's.'*

"Dude," Glimmer piped up as she handed off the marinade to Rogelio. "You've got a serious green thumb."

"I do, don't I?" Kyle grinned.

'We're still working on the whole "taking pride in your accomplishments" thing.'

They chatted for a while before Bow asked, "Any idea when the other three are gonna be here?"

"Shouldn't be long, unless Catra and Lonnie start fighting again."

Adora couldn't help the laugh as she remembered that conversation in the group chat.

("Oh hell no. You're out of your goddamn furry mind if you think I'm gonna let you show up with someone else after what you did last time. Nuh-uh. You're riding with us and if I see a hint of clashing colors I will lock you out." "Gee, it's almost like I'm not a grown ass adult who can easily call my own Uber.")

Catra had eventually caved, but not without a few days of bickering and bellyaching on both sides first.

Almost on cue, the doorbell rang a few minutes later. "It's open!"

Lonnie and Scorpia entered first, lugging a cooler between them (it had been decided it was their turn to provide the drinks) which they wrestled over to the kitchen aisle. When Adora raised an eyebrow at Scorpia's arms, she covertly pointed at Lonnie and mouthed, "She likes to help out. Let her have fun."

Trailing sedately behind them and setting down what seemed to be an empty pet carrier, Catra sauntered into the room. She was dressed fairly conservatively by her standards, to Adora's slight disappointment; leather jacket over a light hoodie and jeans, guitar held loosely in one hand rather than across her back. But to her credit, Lonnie hadn't been able to stop her from wearing a pair of aviator shades. "Sup?"

Of course, her attempt to play it cool was almost immediately ruined by a furry white head popping up from the hood of her shirt with a *mrow*. Catra forced a frown at the chuckles--and excited noises from Bow, who loved animals--but her tail gave her away by waving back and forth excitedly.

"Should've thought about that before you let him climb all over you, dork," Lonnie teased, shoving lightly at Catra as she helped the boys wrangle a few extra chairs around the coffee table (since the couches together could only fit about six people max.)

"It might be your eye color, but green doesn't suit you, Lon," Catra snarked back as she plopped down on the middle seat next to Adora, Star jumping clear and racing over to investigate the two new people. Looking over the tops of the shades, she drawled a lazy, "Hey Adora."

Adora smirked. "Hey yourself, hot stuff."

Catra's tail puffed out like it had been caught in a vacuum cleaner.

"Oh man, you are fucked now, Cat. Adora picked up some game."

Catra flipped Lonnie off over her shoulder, but Adora didn't miss the surprised purr that slipped out when she slid her arm around her.

The party went well for a few hours as everyone talked and heckled each other, not to mention the obligatory game of Questions (wherein Bow finally got the answer to his favorite color question.) On his home turf Rogelio somehow managed to turn out an even greater batch of steaks and hamburgers and it was universally agreed that Glimmer's family recipe was "pretty bitchin'."

By the time four rolled around everyone was full and content to lounge in the living room, each side filling the other in on what they'd been up to job-wise in the last few weeks and either congratulating or commiserating based on the result, when Catra finally untangled herself from under Adora's arm, reached for her guitar and began plucking lazily at the strings. "Feelin' in the mood for some tunes. Any requests?"

"Play 'Freebird'!" Lonnie shouted in her best drunk impression (they'd all gone pretty light or in some cases abstained entirely from alcohol, thus requiring a certain level of theatricality on her part.)

"Fuck you," Catra shot back without hesitating while Lonnie guffawed.

"Oh, I'm your huckleberry," Glimmer giggled as she sat up and dislodged Star from her abdomen, who ran off in a huff.

"I feel I should warn you ahead of time that Adora and I learned classic rock together. So if you're gonna try pulling that same stunt you did at her interview, you can save both of us some time and give it up."

"Nope, I've got something different in mind," Glimmer said with her by-now familiar "I'm looking to do a mischief" smirk. "Adora

used to go absolutely apeshit talking about how talented you were at composing when you were back in school together-"

"These days she's mostly going apeshit about how good your songs are now, among other things," Bow chipped in with a casual wink at the now reddening duo.

"Totally. So you think you could bust out some of that? Show us what the great Catra Leandros was like in her teen years."

"Oh man!" Lonnie laughed, reaching across the back of the couch from her chair next to it so she could tousle Catra's hair. "*Please* do something from your emo rock phase."

"She had an *emo* phase?!"

"Oh, c'mon Lonnie," Catra whined, knocking her hand away. "Those were vent songs-"

"So's half our discography."

"Ok point, but we're professionals now. At the time, those songs weren't supposed to be good."

"I dunno, I was pretty fond of 'Light Sleeper'," Adora murmured, making Catra's tail gently lash along her back as a burst of surprised pleasure hit her right in the chest.

'Of course you would be,' Rogelio snorted. *'That was basically a love song aimed squarely at you, you freaking dork.'*

Catra's ears began to burn even as she tried weakly to deflect. "That was meant to be an us against the world song."

"Same difference with you," Kyle chipped in, eyes going up and to the right as he tried to remember bits and pieces from long ago practice. "I mean, *'You are such a light sleeper, count to ten and you're already out?'* I know you two slept in the same bed, but did you have to be that obvious about watching Adora sleep?"

Catra's retort collided with an excited shout from Glimmer and Bow, becoming a weird mishmash. "Oh, like you've never done it to Rogelio?" "You two slept in the same bed?!"

"Kept falling out of the top bunk," Catra mumbled, ears now practically sizzling beneath the fur. "Night terrors and all."

"Doesn't mean Adora couldn't have switched with you, snugglepuss. Also, 'light sleeper?'" Lonnie chuckled with a shit-eating grin. "We all know Adora sleeps like a friggin' brick. So what exactly *were* you getting at with that particular word choice, hmm?"

Well it was getting hard to think through all the mortified screaming in her head, but at least Adora seemed to be in the same boat; veering closer to fire engine red than any normal human complexion at this point. Catra was certain she wasn't much better. There was only so much that her fur could hide. Especially with half the room watching them with expressions of pure glee (Glimmer especially.)

"Before you ask," She muttered, crossing her arms over her chest to try and regain some control over the situation, "No. I'm not playing it."

"Aww... Lame."

"Nope. Choose another. And you three," Catra pointed at her eyes and then pointed at them with a glare that was much the same. "Are on my shit list until further notice."

"Fiiiine," Lonnie groaned, rolling her eyes. "Though as often as I'm on there, I feel like I've hung up metaphorical curtains and redecorated. My place now."

She paused, something suddenly occurring to her. "How 'bout 'Heart of War?'"

Catra went stock still, even as Glimmer excitedly chattered, "Oh man, that sounds prime emo! Can we do that one?" She glanced

over at Adora, who was now looking back at her *very* carefully.

"I don't know that one," She murmured, so low that only Catra could hear.

Yeah. There had been a reason why she hadn't shown Adora *that* song.

Catra held up a finger, mouthed 'One sec' and then looked at the rest of No Plan B. "Ok, you four: eyes on the ceiling."

"Really?" They groaned.

"Yes, really. Private conversation. Eyes up."

"Gah, fine," Lonnie grumbled, putting her arm around the other three as best she could (even with Rogelio and Kyle squeezed on one side and Scorpia's huge frame on the other it was a Herculean feat.) "I'll do you one better."

After she had turned them all away--though the flurry of hand motions made it clear they were all talking some *major* shit in the meantime--Catra looked over at Adora and quickly signed, *'Hey. I just need you to know this song isn't about you and me, all right? It's about me. Well... The other me.'*

"Aww, sign? Rude, having a secret conversation right in front of us like this," Glimmer whined.

"Learn the language and you too can abuse it, Sparkles," Catra snarked back, but her eyes remained fixed on Adora's, watching her chew over the words.

'Ok,' Adora signed back, a little out of practice but still intelligible. *'I think I can guess why you didn't want to show it to me. But I want to make sure that you really wanna do this. Sounds like this song is pretty personal, not standard "this place is absolute hell" level angst. If you want to play something else, I can suggest anything you'd feel more comfortable with.'*

Warmth flooded Catra's chest even as she shook her head, smiling. *'I'm okay with it, promise. Just didn't want you to think I hid it because I was mad at you or anything. If I'm being honest, it is one of the better pieces I wrote there. But since the others don't know the specific details about the night terrors, it'll probably just seem angsty and overdramatic to them. But not you.'*

No, definitely not Adora. Because once you had the key to that particular puzzle box... Well, it became super obvious what exactly you were looking at.

'Got it. And I've got your back. So if you're sure about this... Well, you know I always like hearing you play.'

'Right back atcha, sunshine,' Catra winked, before saying aloud, "Ok, conference is over. You four can turn back around. Rogelio, it ok if I borrow your amp?"

'Sure, let me go get it,' He replied before exiting the room, Scorpia declaring "let me help!" and following after.

A few minutes later, after Scorpia carried the amp back to the living room and Kyle had taken the various wires from his boyfriend and set them up with the rapidity and ease of a longtime roadie, Catra plugged her Les Paw in and adjusted to the right scale. Running through a few of the song's key chords to test the output, she hummed thoughtfully when the sound passed muster. Meanwhile, the rest of the party settled down on couches and kitchen chairs at a safe enough distance to hear the music clearly without being jarred by it.

She'd warned them it was gonna get loud.

Catra looked up, meeting Adora's focused gaze. Adora nodded. *That* gave Catra all she needed to quell the slight pop-rock buzz of anxiety in her stomach. Even if the others wouldn't get the significance, even if Adora was the only one who knew just how

much of a weak point she was exposing... It was still a little nerve-wracking.

She'd shown Lonnie the notes when they were 17, sure, but Catra had *never* played this song for anyone else.

"All right, you guys are really lucky Lonnie remembered the sheet music I showed her, because this is actually one of the few songs I wrote back then that would still be playable on stage without needing a major overhaul first," She chuckled at the self-deprecating bluster to break some of her own tension. "So by popular request... Here's 'Heart of War.'"

Propping her foot on the amp in a show of false bravado, Catra started playing the opening, sticking mainly to the higher notes as she let muscle memory take over, helping her relax. Grounding her. Then about fifteen seconds in, she switched into deeper shreds, signaling that any false sense of security or softness was not going to fly here today. Two sets of five alternating shreds, about half a second each, each one building progressively deeper.

The sound wasn't entirely right; in her head she could hear the drums, bass and keyboard accompaniment, but in all honesty... She couldn't see herself ever performing this in front of a paying crowd, so she'd never bothered to put down those aspects of the composition. Likely never would.

She switched back to the lighter notes, and sang, *"I feel like I'm running, getting nowhere/Can't stop staring at the pictures in my head/I listen to the words that you told me, holding on 'til the end."*

"Til the end," Catra echoed herself, even softer, before her voice sharpened with latent anger. *"Now you're way too far/To keep from falling over!/I can't pull you up/It's always getting in the way..."*

The chorus was almost a scream.

I can't wait
Until everything comes crashing on you
Tell me who will save you now...

She repeated the line in a harsh snarl, and the entire audience--even Adora--flinched in surprise. Catra couldn't blame them for that; while she didn't mind indulging in screamed vocals in her normal voice every once in a while, harsher vocals like that one really messed up her throat. She only saved them for the songs that really deserved them, the kind of songs other people never got to hear.

It's not fate
'cause you know that I can't live without you!
I don't want it anymore...
This Heart of War!

Catra resumed the thrashing, gritting her teeth at the phantom sensation of her claws sinking into Adora's back, her jaw, her heart, before abruptly cutting off again. *Let go. You're okay now. That's not who you are.*

"I'm tired of living on the battlefield/Fighting every moment to erase it all/Seems like I'm always on the defense, doesn't matter anymore/(Anymore.)"

Now you're way too far
To keep from falling over
I can't pull you up
It's always getting in the way...!

For just a moment, the room and everything in it was gone, and it was just her and a different Catra watching each other across an angry pink landscape intermittently shot through with rocky debris and slashing lines of white, and the other her just grinned through the blackness covering her upper body and Catra's hand and chest both ***ached***.

I trusted you.

"I can't wait/Until everything comes crashing on you/Tell me who will save you now?"

I looked up to you. There was a time in my life when I wanted to be you.

*"**Tell me who will save you now?!**/It's not fate/'cause you know that I can't live without you."*

I thought everything would be fine in the end if I was just a little more like you. Strong enough to take the pain. Brave enough to carve my way through it. But I guess the joke was always on me, huh?

… Why?

"I don't want it anymore... This Heart of War!"

The room snapped back into clarity, and Catra's eyes locked on Adora's, quiet desperation clawing its way through her chest even as the guitar screamed in her hands. *Look at me. See me.*

It was hard for her to read Adora's expression. Focused, yes. Intense as always. Not pitying though. Never pitying.

That gaze never wavered.

Catra took a moment to indulge in a light solo to get her head back together before segueing into the final chorus and just... Let the old wounds fade.

I'm not you. And I can damn well promise I never will be.

"Um... Wow," Glimmer was the first to break the ice when Catra finished, the roar of the guitar still ringing in everyone's ears as she disconnected it from the amp and plopped back down on the couch next to Adora, gratefully accepting the water bottle Rogelio tossed to her. "Wow, um... That was definitely emo."

Catra snorted around the lip of the bottle, hastily swallowing so she could reply. "Don't say I didn't warn you, Sparkles."

"I mean you were totally right about it being good enough for stage! Just... Yeah. Emo."

Adora's fingertips sparked with the urge to reach out and touch Catra, but she reined it in. Not after that look. Not until Catra let her know it was okay. Despite the glibness of her words there was still a line of tension thrumming across her shoulders, a sharpness to her smile that wasn't there when she was truly at ease.

Then Catra glanced at Adora, cocking an eyebrow before leaning in ever so slightly and brushing her shoulder against hers, and Adora breathed a heavy sigh of relief. Petting her ears seemed like a bad idea right now--too patronizing, too much potential to be misconstrued by onlookers, especially after Catra had not-so metaphorically bared her heart to her--so she settled instead for laying her hand over Catra's on the couch between them, idly tracing her fingertips over the knuckles. *I'm here. I have you.*

"Geez," Bow chuckled. "Now I'm wondering what kind of angsty secrets lurk in Adora's closet."

"That wasn't really my style," Adora said hastily, because *nope*.

'Nah, you just cultivated the musical equivalent to a string of smashed windows.'

"Hey!"

'What? It's true. You had plenty of reasons to be angry emo, but you still were.'

"Ok, fine, but that doesn't mean I have a bunch of songs like that. Most of mine were competition pieces-"

"Huh..." Kyle broke in, that look in his eyes when he was trying to remember present once again. "What about that one you showed

me? I remember thinking that if you hadn't told me otherwise, I would have guessed it was a straight Catra special."

'Phrasing, love.'

"Aww, you know what I mean."

Karma, Adora thought dimly as the other members of the group looked at her, raised eyebrows from the Right Zone crew and gleeful, teasing expressions from her own friends. *This is karma. Good fucking job, Eternia. Can't be jealous about Catra sharing secrets with Lonnie now.*

Because, well... There had been a *reason* why she had only shown Kyle that particular piece (and the fact that it had been a one-time deal meant she knew exactly what he was talking about, and she didn't think she could weasel out of this by being coy or pretending not to know.) Rogelio was a great guy, but he tended to be more solution minded and there had been a risk of Lonnie reading it the wrong way and getting confrontational.

Plus she and Kyle had spent enough years stuck in what they'd termed the Gay Huddle of Solidarity™ nursing their respective crushes that Adora had known he wouldn't pry. And that had been what she'd needed at the time.

Thus, this is why we can't have nice things.

"Yo, you in there, Adora?" Catra waved her free hand in front of her face, jolting Adora out of her thoughts. Catra chuckled. "There we go. Good to have you back."

"Yeah, sorry," She muttered, only fighting the urge to rub at her forearm by the fact that she wasn't about to remove her hand from Catra's. "Just... Went somewhere for a second."

"Yeah, hypocrisy'll do that for ya," Lonnie quipped, smirking at the affronted expression Adora shot her way. "C'mon, Adorkable. We all saw the look you gave Catra when I mentioned *her* song. Irony's a bitch, huh?"

"Takes one to know one."

"Ooh, catty. Guess that's one way Catra's rubbing off on you. Though maybe not the way you want."

"Lonnie..." Catra growled a warning.

"Ask me no questions and I'll tell you no lies, furball. You know how this works."

She laughed as Adora flipped her off, settling back against the couch with crossed arms and a huff.

"So you're telling us Adora had an angry emo phase?" Glimmer asked Lonnie with a grin.

"It was the Fright Zone," Adora scoffed without thinking. "Everyone had an emo phase. It was practically covered in advanced student orientation."

But then... Bow's voice. "Uhh... Fright Zone?"

Adora felt the wheels skid out from under her.

Because the rest of her former crew were suddenly watching her with an even mix of concern and outright alarm on their faces. Especially Catra.

'Adora,' The woman in question signed slowly. *'How much have you told them?'*

And wasn't that just the question of the year?

Adora grimaced, unfolding her arms so she could sign back. *'Not much. Just that I was trained there and was Shadow Weaver's favorite.'*

'And I'm guessing you left out the part about what that actually meant?'

Adora remained silent. Catra stared at her, brows furrowing.

'Hey,' Lonnie waved to get their attention. *'I know we all got fucked over by that place, but you two got the worst of it. That means you're the ones who decide how much you wanna discuss here.'*

Adora frowned, temporarily forgetting to sign. "That's not-"

'Yes, it is.' Rogelio cut her off with a warning look. *'Yeah, I had to deal with a bunch of violent racists and Kyle and Lonnie were bullied, but we also don't regularly wake up screaming. And you can't tell me you don't still wake up shaking sometimes either. This is <u>not</u> up for debate.'*

"So am I gonna have to start hiring a translator every time we come over?" Glimmer asked.

Scorpia shook her head. "No, this is actually important, guys. Sorry."

"Ok, I'll trust your word. But..." She glanced over at Adora, eyebrows squeezing together with concern.

And Adora just... Couldn't deal with this right now. Couldn't deal with walking on eggshells... No, *balancing* on them the way she had nearly half of her life.

"It okay if I borrow your guitar?" She asked out loud, sidestepping the entire conversation with all the grace and subtlety of a lemming jumping into traffic.

Catra looked at her, mismatched eyes steady as she searched Adora's face. What she found must have satisfied her, because all she said was, "Yeah. Just come over here for a second and let me show you the trick to playing it, since you don't have claws to worry about."

She kept her head down and focused as Catra guided her through a few exercises, letting her get a feel for the extra space between the strings, murmuring little affirmations like "There we go," and "You're getting the hang of it." Once she felt sure she had it

down, Adora pulled herself to her feet and moved toward the amp.

Midway there, she paused and--uncaring of the other four observing, since they weren't discussing Catra's night terrors anymore--quickly signed, *'Same rules apply, okay? I wasn't angry with you, I was angry at... Well, the entire fucking situation, really.'*

"Got it," Catra replied aloud with a resolute nod. "Whatever you gotta do. You know I like hearing you play."

Adora chuckled. "Nice callback. And likewise."

Settling on the arm of the couch next to the amp and tuning up, she launched into the first few chords without warning. Slow and contemplative. Moody. And not giving herself any time to back down.

"Behind closed doors... There's never any light," Adora sang softly, repeating the instrumentals again. *"Behind closed doors, there's never any light."*

Switching on the aggression, she *snarled*, *"Mix a little bit of love and violence!/Mix a little bit of truth and lies!/(I see you...)/(I feel you!)"*

Years and years of her hands across the landscape of Catra's back, a time-lapse of scars upon scars until she could barely remember a time either of them were free of their presence.

"Push and pulling me for my alliance/But nothing's ever gonna make this right!/(I feel you...)/(I see you!)"

"You were always my brightest pupil, Adora." More like most manipulable. "But your talent will only get you so far. Don't allow yourself to be distracted. Other people, other... Creatures, will only want to take what you have."

"You know that's bullshit. We need people. Not just for survival, but to keep our hearts alive." Then why won't you let me in? "It's okay to need others, Adora. Whatever happens, I've got your back."

Adora's chest ached, the next lines a broken rhythm to match.

The doors/Close/So no/One outside hears/But I/Know/The sound/Of your worst fears, it's-!

Cutting through me, it's-!
Suffocating me!
Behind closed doors...
There's a lifetime to forget!

Breathing hard, she repeated the soft opening for a few moments. From the corner of her eye, she saw Lonnie and Rogelio, mouths agape, staring in abject *horror* at Kyle with upheld hands. Kyle looked about as panicked; she made a mental note to clear the record when this was over.

But right now there was only one reaction that mattered to her.

Meeting Catra's gaze without flinching, Adora sang: *"Mix a little bit of our denial/Mix a little bit of black and white...!/(I feel you...)/(I need you!)"*

"You know, Adora, I've overheard some... Rumors about the nature of your relationship with Catra Leandros."

"They'll say anything to bring me down. She's a useful tool, nothing more." SHUT UP SHUT UP SHUT UP--

How many more times will she make me say it before I start to believe it?

"Growing up I learned from your defiance/But nothing's ever gonna make things right!/(I need you...)/(I feel you!)"

"Hey, whatever Shadow Bitch tries to tell you, it's not true. You're good enough exactly as you are, Adora." Then why...?

"It's fine. No cuts today. Guess she was in a good mood or something." Just let me see you. Let me know you're still here.

"Adora, I'm fine. It's okay." ***NO IT FUCKING ISN'T!***

The doors/Close/So no/One outside hears/But I/Know/The sound/Of your worst fears, it's-!

Cutting through me, it's-!
Suffocating me!
Behind closed doors...
There's a lifetime to forget!

Adora barely even noticed as she made the guitar shriek in her hands. Not when she was focused on something more important.

Catra's ears were lowered and her mouth was twisted up in a grimace of pain, but her eyes...

Adora felt it, sounding across her fragile bones. Catra *saw*.

That was all she'd ever wanted.

"Behind closed doors... There's never any light.../Behind closed doors... There's never any light..."

And then the world seemed to skip a step, because Catra was suddenly right beside her, one hand over Adora's on the strings and the other on the back of her neck, pulling her in so their foreheads touched and her entire world was bracketed by *Catra Catra Catra* and the air smelled of salt and ozone and pain and all she could think coherently was 'I just flashbacked, didn't I' and it both did and didn't matter all at once because...

Because Catra was there, murmuring against her. "I'm here now. I see you. I've *got* you. And I'll never let you go through that again. I fucking *promise*, Adora."

Nothing ever should have hurt so good.

Slowly, Adora felt herself slipping back into her body, registering pain in her fingers where she'd dug into the strings, her own heavy breathing, the wetness on her cheeks. She let Catra peel her hand off her guitar, wincing at the realization that she likely owed her a new set of strings, but Catra just helped her lift the strap over her head and set the instrument aside like it was *nothing* before pulling Adora back in.

"We're going to be fine," Catra whispered as she gently swayed them from side to side. "We're both here and we're going to be okay."

Adora laughed weakly, a ghost of an old memory burbling up like the noise caught in her throat as she buried her face against the curve of Catra's neck. "Maybe someday?"

"*Definitely* someday."

"I'll hold you to that," Adora whispered, one arm wrapping around Catra's shoulders and fisting into her shirt while the other snaked across the small of her back because even now she won't cross that line between the two unless she knows it's okay-

"Shh... Just stop thinking for a while, okay?" There's some awkward shuffling as Catra coaxes Adora's legs around her waist and she knows she should be embarrassed about clinging to her like an oversized koala, but the world can take a picture and *shove* it because right now Adora wants nothing to do with it or anyone else in it.

Motion, a few soft grunts of exertion as Catra moves (but never loosens her grip on Adora) and a few murmured sentences passed back and forth, and then they're moving deeper into the house. Catra pushes open a door with her foot and tries to readjust her grip, before apparently just deciding "fuck it" and letting herself plop down on the bed back first.

That snaps through Adora's haze, because more than anything else in the world, Catra hates and fears feeling like her back's against a wall. But before she can do much more than roll to the side an arm wraps around her shoulder and pulls her back to Catra's chest. "It's okay."

That sparked off a little jolt of anger (and an echo) inside her. "Why are you being so calm about this?"

She could almost feel the eyebrow quirk. "Would you prefer if I got angry?"

"I mean, not really, but I-"

"Adora," Catra cut her off with a rumble--not quite a purr as much as an attention grabber--while she maneuvered Adora until she was tucked under her chin. "It's fine. I'm a big girl: I'll let you know if I start to feel uncomfortable. Now can you please calm the fuck down and just let me hold you?"

Adora let the fight drain out of her as she succumbed to the attention, but she still couldn't resist protesting. "Guess I'm just used to it being the other way around."

"Well judging by *that* little number, the balance should have been a lot more even," Catra pointed out sharply.

Adora winced and Catra softened, one hand going to the back of her neck and rubbing at the tension gathered there. "Sorry. I'm not mad at you. Just kicking myself for not figuring this out sooner."

"Wait, what?"

A chuckle and a gentle pressure against the top of her head. "You, sunshine of my life, are one of those people that are so good at internalizing things that sometimes the rest of us forget that you're just as fucked up as we are. And in hindsight, I should have remembered that, but given that we've all been to therapy...

Well, it was a little hard to tell what was progress and what was just you being you."

"You're not much better," Adora grumbled, pulling herself further against the warmth beneath her, like she could blur the edges between them if she could just get close enough. "I couldn't protect you. All I could do was slap a bandaid on it. But that was all you ever let me do."

The hand on her neck paused. "You know why."

"Doesn't mean I don't want-," *Need*. "-to hear it out loud."

"... Okay," Catra sighed, resuming her ministrations. "The night terrors got really bad those last few years. Not that they weren't bad before, but they were a reasonable kind of bad. Shadow Weaver torture, fighting with our crew; bad, yes, but nothing I couldn't handle. That was when it switched to me hurting you."

Adora pulled away and propped herself up on her elbows, just enough to see Catra watching her *very* carefully. "You never hurt me, even when you woke up swinging. At least not like that."

She cringed inwardly at the admission, but she wouldn't be doing either of them favors by being dishonest.

"I didn't," Catra conceded. "But that didn't make the possibility any less terrifying."

She looked long and hard at Adora, and Adora was struck by the strangest mix of deja vu and nostalgia. Because she *knew* that look better than anything. It was the one that said, "I'm being open with you. Pay attention: this is important."

"I know what it feels like to sink my claws into you, Adora. I'm not looking to reacquaint myself with the feeling in the waking world. I'd chew my own hands off first."

Fuck. What did one even say to something like that? In her irritation, she'd forgotten one important thing: Catra wanted to

keep her safe just as much as vice versa. "Let's not. I happen to be pretty fond of your hands."

"Oh, really?"

The reply was given a lilting twist and an exaggerated eyebrow waggle and Adora almost laughed. She settled instead for tucking her head back under Catra's chin, hiding a smile even though she knew Catra could feel it against her. So she figured it was safe to indulge in a little brattiness. "Yup. Especially when they're rubbing my back."

Catra laughed as she complied with the none-too-subtle demand. "Forgot how bossy you can be."

"Only when I need to be."

"Only when it matters."

They stayed quiet for a long time, until there came a soft knock at the door and Scorpia's voice filtering through. "Everyone just wanted to check if you two were okay, and apparently I'm the best middleman. You guys need anything?"

Catra glanced down. "You okay? Or do you wanna hide out here a little longer?"

Well, it wasn't like she could avoid facing the music (quite literally) forever. Even if a large part of her wanted to just grab Catra's hand and abscond out the nearest window.

"Just give it a few. I'm recharging."

"We'll be out in a few minutes, Scorpia," Catra called, before starting up a rumbling purr and resuming her attentions.

Heading back into the living room was just as awkward as Adora had expected it to be.

Catra took the lead, of course, and thankfully Lonnie met them a few feet from the exit into the living room. She'd been leaning against the wall with her arms crossed trying to look chill, but Adora recognized the worried set of her shoulders and the too-tense way she forced herself to keep her gaze nonchalantly fixed in the direction of the living room. Thankfully, she relaxed the instant she heard their approach.

"Hey," She greeted with a small wave, pushing herself to stand straight. She looked at Adora, eyes sweeping over her as if to check for damage. "Feeling better?"

"About as much as can be expected." Adora shrugged, toying with the tip of Catra's tail, which had currently wrapped itself around her wrist.

"Well don't worry too much, okay? We ran interference with Glimmer and Bow and explained things to them without going into too much detail. They know you had a PTSD episode and they're just as concerned as any good friends would be, but they also understand to back off if you don't feel up to it. You're in charge here."

Funny. There had been a time when being in charge was the last thing Adora wanted. But now, she'd be lying if she said she wasn't comforted by it. "Thanks, Lonnie."

"Aww, no big deal. We Fright Zone kids stick together."

I guess we do, Adora thought as they exited the hall. Back in the living room, the rest of the group was crowded around the coffee table playing cards.

As they approached, Glimmer laid down a card, prompting Scorpia to declare "BS." Glimmer groaned and took a drink of her beer without even bothering to wait for the flip. "How do you keep figuring me out?"

"I think with your general personality everyone just kind of assumes you're lying," Kyle said dryly as he added his own card to

the pile.

"Gee thanks."

Rogelio tapped the lip of Kyle's bottle to get his attention. *'There she is.'*

"There's our favorite sword girl," Bow chipped in as Adora and Catra took the couch and Lonnie plunked down on the floor next to Scorpia.

"You mean you have more than one? I'm wounded, Bow, truly."

"BS."

"It's *your* turn."

"And yet," He winked as he laid down his card, prompting a call of *'bullshit'* from Rogelio.

The newcomers watch for a few rounds before she finally felt like addressing the elephant in the room. "We uh... We need to talk about it, huh?"

To Adora's surprise, there was only a collective shrug as everyone else laid down their cards. Glimmer glanced at her from the corner of her eye as she polished off the last few drinks of her beer. "Only if you're up to it."

"I mean, I'm good now. But I also know you and Bow will be tormenting yourselves for weeks if I don't explain at least a little."

There was an awkward throat clearing noise.

"Yeah, by the way," Kyle muttered, rubbing the back of his neck. "Sorry. It's just been so long since you showed me the notes that I didn't remember much about the actual song except the general feel. I would never have brought it up if I had."

Adora shifted. "It's fine, Kyle. I wouldn't have played it if I didn't want to. Just, uh... Wasn't expecting my emotions to go that bad."

Meanwhile, Glimmer and Bow had pulled themselves up and onto the opposite couch.

"Ok..." Glimmer started, breathing out slowly through her nose. "If you need me to shut up, tell me and I totally will. I just need to get this out of my system... WHAT THE *FUCK* HAPPENED AT THAT SCHOOL?!"

And there it was. Adora groaned, glancing around the room to find the rest of the old crew watching her evenly. No pressure, but no condemnation either.

"Your call, girl," Lonnie said. "I know we're all getting to be friends, but they were yours first."

"Don't feel like you have to reveal any more than you want to," Scorpia chipped in with a supportive thumbs-up before wrapping an arm around Lonnie's shoulder.

At her side, Catra's presence burned bright and warm like a furnace. A whisper, a hand brushed against the small of her back. "I've got you."

Yeah. I know.

Adora breathed deep, feeling like a knot inside her had finally loosened.

"Ok," She started, shifting forward so she was on the edge of the couch with her elbows propped on her knees. "So I'm guessing you guys have picked up on the fact that I don't often talk about Right Zone, beyond just discussing the friend group and those adventures."

"I mean... Yeah," Bow admitted. "But we just kinda guessed it had something to do with Catra leaving."

Catra's breath hitched, and Adora shuffled a little to rest a knee against hers. *It's okay*. "Yeah, I was more or less banking on you drawing that conclusion."

Even with her resolve, even with years of practice in therapy, trying to get the words out still felt like chewing glass. "The real reason I don't talk much about Right Zone is because... Well, the place turns out good musicians: that was its one upside. But it was also infested by a pack of sadists and racists who just *loved* to torture kids."

Stunned silence. Maybe the wording had been a little too blunt, but that didn't make it any less true.

"What the fuck..." Bow whispered.

It was like a floodgate had been opened and out came the angry babbling. "Yeah, it was really fucked up. At least half of the teachers hated hybrids and would go out of their way to make their lives hell, the security guard was an awful bitch who liked to beat on anyone smaller than her for just existing, the kids picked up on everything and tore the shit out of each other just to eke out a little bit of security and the headmistress, Shadow Weaver? The absolute *worst*."

"That woman's such an awful bitch that I can't even remember her real first name," Lonnie added. "She's just always been Shadow Weaver to me."

"Ditto."

'Yup.'

"You mean she *had* a first name?"

"Hang on just a sec. Adora..." Glimmer held up a hand, distinctly teary-eyed as she looked across at Adora. "Why didn't you...?"

Adora sighed, rubbing the back of her neck and digging her blunt nails in as she dragged the admission out. "You remember what I

said about being the headmistress's favorite? That was true. Everyone there knew better than to lay a hand on me."

"Right," Catra cut in dryly, tail lashing in agitation. "But if you're trying to imply that being the main focus of that woman's attention was any easier, then I've got news for you: that's grade A bullshit."

"No, I know that *now*. It took my therapist like two years of sustained work to drill that one into my skull. But I mean..." She glanced up at Glimmer and Bow. "It's just... It always felt like I didn't have as much of a right to complain because I wasn't physically abused like the others. By the time I accepted otherwise, we'd been friends and bandmates for years already. I didn't know how to bring it up.

"C'mon, it's not like I could just sit down at the breakfast table and say, 'Hey, you know that school I was raised at and avoid talking about in all conversation? Yeah, I had to watch my best friend get tortured by a sadistic psychopath for over a decade and there wasn't anything I could do stop it and it turns I'm still a little fucked up about that. Can you pass the bacon?'" She cut herself off with a bitter laugh. "Yeah, like that would have gone over well."

"Hey!" Catra suddenly batted her upside the head, lightly enough that it didn't actually hurt but firm enough to snap Adora out of her self-destructive spiral. "You're the reason I'm even alive right now. So this guilt shit? Not gonna fly, then or now. And also..."

She paused, cheeks coloring lightly, but she didn't look away. "If I hadn't had you to hold onto, that place would have broken me. So don't beat yourself up. That's *my* shtick."

The humor fell flat, but a drowning man would cling to a reed, and Adora could feel herself getting there, slowly but surely.

Bow, watching the exchange, swallowed hard. "So the scars..."

"Yeah," Catra confirmed with a sad smile, one hand rubbing unconsciously at the curve of her shoulder. "Little souvenirs from the head bitch in charge herself. If Adora was her 'favorite pupil', I was her favorite chew toy. Hardly ever went more than a few weeks without one of her little 'disciplinary sessions.' Fucked up, right? If Adora hadn't been around to patch me up, I'm not even sure I'd be here."

'She literally could have gotten her field medic certification by the time we were ten.'

"Oh God, I am so sorry I ever asked," Glimmer hissed emphatically, rubbing at her temples and not looking anywhere but at the floor. Bow put a comforting hand on her shoulder.

"It's fine," Catra shrugged. "I mean, you had just found out about the car wreck, so that was a totally logical conclusion to draw. And to be 100% fair, it had completely slipped my mind that the scars would be showing when I was only wearing that tank top. Like Lonnie said, the question just caught me off guard."

"Still..." Glimmer sighed, settling back against the chair and rubbing the heels of her hands into her eyes. "This is all a lot to take in."

Adora couldn't help the pithy comment. "Join the club. We've been at it for twenty years and counting."

"Ok, please no more black humor for now," Bow cut in with a gentle wave, no condemnation or heat to be found. "Like, I get it's a coping mechanism, but this entire conversation already hurts too much for it to start actively biting as well. Like Glimmer said... Lot to take in."

"Right. Sorry."

"S'okay."

Adora's neck and shoulder muscles started to ache. She uncurled herself from her defensive position and sat back, moving slowly to

try to get the kinks out. A hand tapped her shoulder, and she glanced over to see Catra holding an arm out, and gratefully tucked herself under it. Catra pulled her in and a low, rumbling purr started, but Adora had spent enough time listening to that sound to recognize the little hitch that meant she was forcing it.

In a strange way, that was comforting; knowing that despite how cool and collected Catra seemed right now, she was just as affected by it all as Adora.

There was silence for a while, everybody just sitting quietly with their respective person and letting the couple of hours sink in. "Sorry this turned into such a downer, guys."

Rogelio gave a little half-roar, his version of a barking laugh. *'Don't worry about it. You needed to talk. There'll be more parties in the future, ones without hideous psychological journeys.'*

"Yeah, if you think we're gonna let you get all guilty then you're way off," Scorpia said with a soft wink in their direction as she pulled herself to her feet and held out a claw for Lonnie. "I think some tea would be good for all of us. Any particular requests, or just whatever?"

Adora mumbled a general affirmative and closed her eyes, focusing on the sound of Catra's purring and the hand rubbing soothingly up and down her side.

This is good. I'm safe. <u>We're</u> safe.

It was about thirty minutes later, after Scorpia and Lonnie had finished passing out the tea--peppermint vanilla, Catra had to admit Kyle had damn good taste--and everyone had taken the time to drink and decompress and just share meaningless little comments of no real value, when Glimmer spoke up again, and Catra *finally* realized what Rogelio had been getting at with his advice weeks ago.

"The back off rule is still in effect," She opened, looking a little pensive. "I just want to know... Do you guys have any good memories of Right Zone?"

Catra paused midway through rubbing circles into Adora's back to consider the question. "Sure. It wasn't one hundred percent abuse all the time, or they'd have attracted outside attention and gotten the place shut down. And having our merry little gang of misfits around to lean on did make it a lot better. But if you're talking musically... Well, it wasn't exactly the kind of place that was conducive to that."

"Yeah, both those songs from earlier were uncommonly polished but otherwise pretty normal for back then," Lonnie chipped in from where she was happily leaned into Scorpia's side. "The only time they weren't working on something soul-crushingly angsty was when it was time for exams. Couldn't have anyone outside asking why this sixteen year old kid was singing about getting the shit kicked out of them on stage, not without risking some serious retribution."

"And even then..." Kyle shook his head. "Sorry guys, I know you both put a lot of work into showing off your technical prowess in those bits, but they weren't exactly your best work."

'All the skill, none of the heart.'

"Yeah. Honestly, those years when you performed cover songs were way better."

"No, I agree," Adora replied as she finally came out of her post-gut-spilling-and-comfort coma. "Most of the really technical stuff was written to keep Shadow Weaver off our backs. The cover songs were for when we needed to cut loose and actually *feel* something and still maintain plausible deniability."

"If I ever meet this woman, I'm going run her over with my car. And back up a few times for good measure," Glimmer grumbled. "I *hate* how much thought you had to put into this."

"Aww, thanks, Sparkles. But yeah, sorry I can't lighten the mood with a happy tune. Would if I had anything."

But then she felt Adora stiffen against her, turning to look up at Catra. "What about that song you were working on our senior year?"

A jolt went through Catra's body, because she'd been trying really hard not to think of *that* song for over a decade now. Plus with the way everything went down that year... "You remember that?"

"No shit," Adora snorted, sitting up a little just so she could jab Catra in the ribs. "I mean, you were composing a single song for nearly a year. That's beyond noteworthy. And, well... You always looked really happy when you were working on it. I kinda wondered whether you were planning on debuting it at senior exams."

"Yeah, that was the plan," Catra admitted with a shy little half-gesture, face coloring. "Didn't finish it in time though, so I had to switch tack."

Adora opened her mouth to reply, but they were both cut off by a wordless shriek of rage from Lonnie. "ARGH, what the *fuck*, Catra?!"

"Whoa, what's happening, babe?" Scorpia grabbed at her shoulders to keep her from no doubt leaping to her feet and launching herself across the coffee table.

"I'll tell you what's happening!" Lonnie shouted, pointing an accusatory finger at Catra. "This ridiculous bitch just candidly admitted to winning number one in senior exams with her fucking back-up plan! Not number one in guitars, number one *overall*! WITH A PLAN B!"

"And your reaction is making me feel fully justified in not telling you that," Catra remarked with nothing more than a raised eyebrow. "And you took seventh overall, so I don't know why you're bitching."

"I hate you."

"Keep telling yourself that if it makes you feel better, pumpkin."

Lonnie's furious reprisal was cut off by laughter from Bow. Everyone turned to look at him.

"Sorry. Was just thinking how funny it was that for once, Catra actually *did* have a plan B."

Glimmer groaned. "That is such a dad joke, Bow."

"I have two. So I think I'm excused."

Tension thoroughly cut, the group settled back into calm contemplation, before Kyle spoke up. "So wait, you were working on this song for a long time but didn't get it done in time for exams?"

"Wait..." Glimmer glanced at the rest of the Fright Zone vets. "You guys didn't know she was working on a big song?"

"I was keeping that one close to my chest," Catra shifted a little. "But yeah, Kyle, that's the basic gist. With everything that happened after... It just kinda fell through the cracks."

Then Adora looked over at her and it was one of those moments when Catra could barely breathe, too caught off guard by the open affection and light pleading she could see there. "Can you play it now?"

Catra paused.

'When the right moment arrives, you'll know exactly what to do.'

Yeah. Yeah, I get it now.

"Sure thing," She breathed, a little excited and scared all at once. "Rogelio, can I borrow your acoustic?"

"Already on it," Kyle called back over his shoulder as he ambled down the hall. "Rogelio has a hard time moving around in the storage room. His tail gets in the way."

Rogelio made an embarrassed grumble since Kyle wasn't there to see him sign. Taking pity on him, Adora asked, "You learned six string too, Rogelio?"

'It's fun. Plus it helps to know what I'm talking about in group compositions. And sometimes Catra's hand goes weird when the weather changes unexpectedly, so this way I can pinch hit for her.'

"Ha!" Catra teased with a toothy grin, poking at him with one foot. "I knew there was something you weren't telling me about that, you big softie."

'Yeah, I knew you'd make fun of me.'

"Not at all," She softened, reaching out give him a fistbump. "Thanks, bro."

'Hmph... You're welcome.'

"All right," Kyle said as he returned, having stopped off at the laundry room to grab a washcloth and clean the thin layer of dust off the instrument. "Rogelio doesn't get as much time to practice as he'd like, but he still sticks to the monthly maintenance schedule, so you should be good to go."

"Thanks, bud," Catra said with a nod as she accepted the guitar from him. She plucked a few of the more important chords to text the sound, tightening the strings a tad but otherwise finding it to her liking.

She took a deep breath to steady herself before glancing around the room, eyes inevitably coming to rest on Adora, who had moved to the opposite end of the couch so she could watch Catra clearly; hands clasped and blue eyes wide with excitement. One of her legs had gone all jittery. *Yeah. Definitely the right moment.*

"All right... Here we go."

Catra almost wished she could see the looks of surprise on the other's faces as she started to play a jaunty, upbeat tune; a far cry from her usual shreds and aggressive riffing. But she was too focused on what she was doing: even if she'd made some minor mental adjustments the lyrics in the first few years post Fright Zone, she'd never really been able to bring herself to actually play it again.

But she'd also never been able to forget.

After the first ten seconds of playing she added a low hum into the mix, rising and falling along with the music and transitioning into half purrs, before she finally opened up and sang.

"I was sitting in a field of pine trees/Coaxin' the words from the earth and the dirt and/I sought a muse but the words just wouldn't come..."

Herself at 17, fingers drumming frustratedly on the surface of the desk as she struggled to put her thoughts and feelings into melody. In the present, Catra couldn't help but chuckle inwardly at just how *hard* she'd tried.

"It's been a while since I saw you at New Year/Holdin' your breath, your eyes upon the second hand/The way you looked is still vivid to me."

Because in the end, the answer had always been right in front of her. That year had ultimately given Catra everything she'd needed to make the song work.

You're something out of a dream
Messing with my head
And I've been looking for you

She drew the 'you' out for emphasis and opened her eyes to look across the couch at the girl who had made everything possible.

Are you hiding?
'Cause I like the way you're calling to me
Your spell upon me
You're something out of a dream...

She knew Adora caught the meaning of that line; it was written all over her face.

And I like it, though I fight it

Catra smiled, barely even allowing a small "oh" in pause before launching into the next part. *"Took a while for the medicine to sink in/Blow out the fog and remove all the cobwebs/Now I'm clear, I can hear myself think straight."*

Eighteen years old as she opened up the paper wrapping containing the bone bridge, the gift Adora had worked her ass off for just to fix Catra's acoustic because they were both broke and fucking Shadow Weaver wouldn't let her get a replacement from the school's supplies, and Catra had never even known she could feel so <u>much</u> until she looked at Adora's face and realized just how thoroughly done she was with trying to pretend she wasn't completely in love with this girl.

"I'm on the road with my clothes in a rucksack/Over my shoulders, following the whispers/People ask me where I'm goin' in such haste," Catra spared a moment for a brief chuckle, before meeting Adora's gaze with a quick, sincere smile. *"And I said:*

My girl is a switchblade
A brighter light on a cityscape
Wherever she goes I'm gonna chase.

Waking up in the middle of the night to Adora handing her a photocopy of the Julliard application form. "Adora, what the-"

Blue eyes boring into her. "You know I'm not leaving this place without you. If I go, we go together."

Sighing, running nervous fingers through her mane even as she grasped at the papers. "She's going to kill us if she finds out you went behind her back."

"By the time she finds out it'll be too late to stop us. And if she tries anything..." Adora paused, taking Catra's hand in her own. "I'll protect you. So come with me. Please?"

As if there had ever been another choice for Catra.

"You're something out of a dream," She resumed, more forcefully now. *"Messin' with my head/And I've been lookin' for you..."*

Man, eighteen year old me accidentally hit that self-fulfilling prophecy button hard. Heh. Didn't change a thing, not really.

Are you hiding?
'Cause I like the way you're calling to me
Your spell upon me
You're something out of a dream...
And I like it, though I fight it
Oh!

She took up the humming again, intentionally vocalizing the sound of the lyrics rather than the instrumentals before finishing softly. *"You're something out of a dream.../Whoo…/You're something out of a dream."*

"Wow," Adora breathed as Catra finished singing and handed the acoustic back to Rogelio amid mutual murmurs of appreciation. "*Wow*."

Is it way too early to propose? I need to know. This is important information.

"You were working on that for an entire year?" Glimmer asked.

Catra smiled, relaxing as she flexed her left hand to soothe the soreness out. "More or less. I wanted to be sure I got it just right."

"I mean... Mission accomplished, I guess."

"'I guess' thanks, Sparkles."

"Ok, I know you're trying to deflect right now because you're one of those assholes who has a hard time with sincerity outside your safe group, but I'm gonna punch your face if you call me that again today."

"Haha hahaha!" Bow intervened with forced laughter, rapidly changing the subject before Catra could goad Glimmer any further. "Well, what's the name of the song?"

"Huh?"

"The song name! You never said, and otherwise we're just going to be calling it 'that really sweet song Catra sang at the barbecue' for the rest of forever."

"Adora."

"Hmm?" Adora--midway through tapping out the melody on her pants leg--looked up at the call of her name.

Catra, cheek propped up on one fist, just continued smiling softly and watching her with those mismatched eyes.

Then Adora's brain finally caught up amid Bow, Kyle and Scorpia's simultaneous squeals, and her face turned bright red.

"OH MY GOD!" Glimmer shouted in exasperation, throwing her hands up and looking at Catra with disgust. "You did *not* just turn an attempt at lightening the mood into a declaration of undying love! WHO EVEN DOES THAT?!"

"You were literally planning to play a love song named after Adora on stage in front of *Shadow Weaver* and everybody?!" Lonnie joined in on the shouting. "Bitch, how ballsy can you get?!"

But Adora barely even heard any of it, all the non-short circuited synapses in her brain focused wholly on Catra. Because all that time she'd been angry and frustrated at Catra holding her at arm's length… and all that time Catra had been just as occupied with closing the distance in her own way.

She licked her lips nervously, heart pounding. "Catra, I-"

"Adora," Catra cut her off with a laugh, eyes sparkling as she beckoned with her good hand. "Just get over here and kiss me already."

And then the couch became their first official casualty as Adora slammed into Catra, toppling the entire thing over before proceeding to kiss the living daylights out of her.

Lonnie would later tell them that the entire group breathed a collective sigh of relief that at least the pining was finally over--though Rogelio and Kyle had shared a resigned grimace at the fate of their couch as they all filed out of the room to give them some privacy--but Adora had been a *little* distracted in the actual moment.

Because Catra's hands were cupping the back of her head and her lips were softer than Adora could ever have imagined as they pressed against hers--and she had imagined a *lot* in fifteen years. And when they broke apart, just for a moment, and rested their foreheads together as they each drew in ragged breaths... Adora opened her eyes to see Catra looking up at her like she was *everything*, like she'd just been handed every good thing she had ever asked for out of life and so much *more*, before sliding one hand to the back of Adora's neck and pulling her back down again.

Adora had thought that the moment they first saw each other two months ago, when their eyes met and all the missing bits and pieces fell back into place like they'd never been apart... She'd truly thought that had been *the* perfect moment. But Adora had to concede now that it had been *a* perfect moment.

Because this, right here? This was perfect.

Finally.

"Do you have any idea..." Adora panted when they broke apart again. *Whose bright idea was it, needing oxygen?* "How long I've wanted to do that?"

"Oh..." Catra drawled lazily, reaching up to frame Adora's face with her hands and running her right thumb across her cheekbone. "I think I can hazard a guess."

Adora leaned into the touch, keeping her eyes locked on Catra's even as she kissed the fingertips of her left hand, propping herself on one elbow so she could reach up to brush her own fingers along the edge of her ears and try to convey to Catra just how much she utterly *adored* every inch of her. "And you?"

It's somewhere between a plea and a challenge. Still... Catra's grin just softened into a small, sweet smile that told Adora everything she'd ever needed to know. "C'mon, Adora: I've been yours for years and years."

Chapter End Notes

> Next time: Adora Eternia is fourteen years old, in love with her best friend and carrying an anger that can't be exorcised and a lingering emotional wound that cannot heal. Add in Shadow Weaver's entire existence, the pressures of her prodigy status, the horrors of puberty and the way Catra sometimes *really*doesn't make sense, and well... it's gonna be a long four years.

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